

The Deprecation Protocol

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This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, organizations, and events are either products of the author's imagination or used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, or actual events is coincidental.

The drone did not hate you. The age bracket did not judge you.

The banned book did not threaten you. They simply enforced

the only law that mattered: the future belongs to those who

can afford to leave. And you, reader, will not.

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Jaka Polesnik

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Chapter One: Nika

Year: 2084. Location: Greater Boston Habitation Zone, Apartment 14C.

The first thing Nika noticed every morning was the air.

Not the smell of it—though that was precisely calibrated to be "neutral with hints of citrus" according to the subscription tier her mother could afford. No, what Nika noticed was the *pressure*. The way it pushed into her lungs with mechanical regularity, the faint hum of the ventilator embedded in the wall behind her bed, the way the apartment seemed to breathe on its own schedule, not hers.

She was fourteen. She had never known anything different.

Her phone buzzed—a chime that meant her sleep window was ending. Her parents had paid for seven hours and twenty-three minutes, and the system would begin deducting from her monthly allowance and their combined budget if she lingered. Nika sat up. The air pressure shifted, the ventilator adjusting to her new position. Clever, those algorithms. Always watching. Always optimizing.

Her room was exactly six by eight feet. The walls were a pale gray that the landlord's AI had determined was "psychometrically optimal for adolescent females aged thirteen to seventeen." She had tried to stick up a poster once—a band she liked, or thought she liked, or had been algorithmically suggested to like—but the adhesive had violated her rental agreement's clause about "permanent modifications to leased surfaces." The fine was seventeen dollars, which her mother had made her pay back by skipping her weekend entertainment subscription for a month.

Nika had learned. She did not stick things to walls anymore.

"Good morning, Nika." The apartment's voice was warm, maternal, completely fake. "Your mother has been awake for eleven minutes. Your father's sleep cycle ends in forty-three minutes. Your education stream begins in fifty-two minutes."

"I know," Nika said, because the apartment expected acknowledgment. Engagement metrics. Everything tracked.

She pulled on her clothes—rented, like everything else, a monthly subscription that rotated through "seasonally appropriate casual wear for temperate climate zones." The fabric was comfortable enough. It always was. That was the thing about the system: it wasn't *cruel*. It didn't have to be. It just was.

Her dog—actual property, not rented, one of the few things her family owned outright—lifted his head from

the foot of her bed. His name was Scout, a mutt of indeterminate origin, the kind of dog that would have been called a "rescue" in the old stories her grandmother sometimes told. Now he was just a dog. An expense her mother justified by skipping her own food upgrades. Nika loved him with a ferocity that scared her sometimes, because love wasn't metered, wasn't tracked, wasn't something the corporation could take away.

Not yet.

"Hey, boy," she whispered, scratching behind his ears. Scout thumped his tail against the rented sheets. "You want breakfast?"

She didn't have to check the food inventory. The system knew. It always knew. Her mother's free tier breakfast was oatmeal, plain, with a single vitamin supplement. Nika's student breakfast was oatmeal with artificial brown sugar flavoring and a calcium chew. Her father, who worked twelve-hour shifts at the logistics hub, had the "protein enrichment" add-on—an

extra four dollars a day that meant he could stand upright through his second shift without his hands shaking.

The kitchen was a countertop, a sink, a heating element, and a dispenser. No refrigerator—those required a "fresh food subscription" that cost more than her mother made in a week. Everything they ate came from the dispenser, portioned, packaged, perfect. Nika had never seen a vegetable that wasn't dehydrated. She had never cut a fruit. She had watched videos, of course—they were part of the "culinary history" module in her education stream, premium content that her school had purchased access to as part of a bundle. But the videos were old. The fruits in them looked almost fake, too colorful, too irregular. Nothing like the perfectly uniform nutrient blocks that slid out of the dispenser every morning.

She fed Scout from a bag of kibble stored under the sink—actual ownership, her grandmother's dog food recipe passed down, the one thing they refused to let the corporation control. Her mother ground the

ingredients herself once a month, using a hand mill that had belonged to her great-grandmother. The mill was older than the Unified Hunamity Board. Older than the subscription economy. Older than the Mars Colonial Corporation's first landing.

Nika had never been to Mars. She had never seen Mars. Not really.

On her phone—a loaner, part of her education subscription, which would be wiped and reassigned if she failed to maintain a C average—the news app showed a gray box where images of the red planet should have been. "CONTENT NOT AVAILABLE," it read. "Your age bracket (13-17) is not cleared for off-planet political content. For more information, please have a parent or guardian verify their clearance level."

She asked her mother once, what was on Mars? Her mother had been quiet for a long time. Then she had said: "Nothing you need to worry about."

Nika worried anyway. She was fourteen. Worrying was what she did.

The school was a building. Not a nice building—the lease on the structure itself had expired seven years ago, and the corporation that owned it had decided that "maintenance" was an optional add-on. But the inside had been renovated recently, because the education stream required certain environmental standards for the advertising to be effective.

That was the thing about school: it was free. Sort of. The core curriculum came with ads—two minutes of commercials for every fifteen minutes of instruction, plus "sponsored learning modules" that taught math through the lens of optimizing subscription tier selections, or history through the heroic narrative of corporate expansion. The premium tier, which Nika's family could not afford, removed the ads and added "enrichment content" like literature and philosophy and art.

Nika had seen the premium tier once, when her friend Yan had logged in from his apartment. He had been reading *Frankenstein*. The actual book, not a summary. She had watched over his shoulder for ten minutes, mesmerized, until his mother had come home and he had closed the laptop quickly, ashamed, though Nika had never understood why.

Yan lived in the apartment between hers and the empty one. The empty one had been empty for as long as Nika could remember—a dark door in the hallway, no name on the buzzer, no lights in the windows. Sometimes she heard things from inside. She told herself it was just the building settling.

Yan was fifteen, a year older, with dark hair that fell into his eyes and hands that moved too fast for his mouth to keep up. He was a programmer—not the kind the corporations hired, the kind that went to universities and got clearance and wrote code that moved money around the world. Yan was the other kind. The kind who stayed up until three in the morning downloading open-source repositories, who

talked about "copyleft" and "AGPL" like they were religious texts, who believed, with a fervor that Nika found both inspiring and terrifying, that information wanted to be free.

"You can't just *take* code," he said to her once, pacing her living room while her mother was at work, his voice rising in that way it did when he forgot to be careful. "That's not how it's supposed to work. You write something, you share it, everyone builds on it, everyone makes it better. That's the deal. That's the *promise*."

"Who's taking it?" Nika asked, because she liked the way his hands moved when he talked.

"Everyone." He had stopped pacing, run his fingers through his hair, looked at her with an expression that was half rage and half grief. "Mars Colonial Corporation. They're using my code—my *friend's* code, from a project I contributed to—and they wrapped it in some proprietary shell and now they're *selling it back* to people. To me. I got an email yesterday offering me a

subscription to a service that's literally just my own work with the license stripped off. And when I tried to post the original, to prove it was mine, their lawyers DMCA'd *me*. For my own code."

Nika had nodded, because she understood that something was wrong even if she didn't understand the mechanics of it. That was the shape of her life: understanding that something was wrong, knowing it in her bones, but never quite being able to see it clearly enough to name it.

She thought about that conversation now, sitting in her seat at school, watching a sponsored video about "The Entrepreneurial Spirit of Colonial Expansion" while the girl next to her scrolled through a clothing subscription catalog on her tablet. The video showed gleaming domes on a red landscape, happy families waving at cameras, a narrator with a warm voice saying words like "opportunity" and "frontier" and "brighter future."

Nika looked at the gray box on her phone, the one that said she wasn't cleared for off-planet political content.

She wondered what they didn't want her to see.

Her best friend was named Priya. They had been assigned as learning partners in the third grade—the algorithm had determined that their complementary learning styles would maximize knowledge retention—and had simply never stopped talking. Priya was the kind of person who made everything seem bearable. She laughed too loud, hugged too hard, and had a subscription to the "emotional expression" add-on for her education stream that let her use words like "frustrated" and "angry" without triggering content warnings.

"Nika." Priya slid into the seat beside her, breathless, her phone clutched to her chest. "Did you see the forum post?"

Nika's stomach tightened. "What forum post?"

"Local one. The community board. Someone in our building—" Priya lowered her voice, though the classroom's acoustic monitoring would pick it up anyway, would flag it for review, would add it to both of their behavioral profiles. "Someone was *criticizing* Mars Colonial Corporation. Like, actually criticizing. Saying the lottery was rigged. Saying people who win don't come back."

Nika felt cold. "Who?"

"I don't know. The username was just 'tenant_4c' or something. But the post is gone now. It was up for maybe three minutes before it got deleted." Priya's eyes were wide. "Three minutes, Nika. That's *fast*."

The classroom door opened. Their teacher—a hologram, because human teachers had been phased out in the budget cuts of '58—projected itself to the front of the room. "Good morning, students. Today's learning module is brought to you by Mars Colonial Corporation. Please ensure your attention metrics

remain above eighty-five percent to receive full participation credit."

Nika looked at her phone one more time. The gray box was still there. CONTENT NOT AVAILABLE.

She thought about the empty apartment between hers and Yan's. The one with no name on the buzzer. The one where she sometimes heard things moving in the dark.

She thought about tenant_4c.

And she thought about how fast three minutes could be.

That night, Nika lay in bed with Scout curled at her feet, listening to the ventilator hum. Her phone glowed in the darkness—not with messages, not with news, but with a single line of text that Yan had sent her two hours ago, after the forum post had been deleted and

the school day had ended and the world had gone quiet.

"Don't look into it," he had written. *"Please. Just don't."*

She wanted to listen to him. She wanted to be the kind of person who could look away, who could accept the gray boxes and the rented air and the carefully calibrated life that had been built for her. She wanted to be happy with the oatmeal and the calcium chews and the educational ads.

But she was fourteen. And she had heard the noise from the empty apartment again tonight—a sound like something being dragged across the floor, slow and deliberate and *wrong*.

She typed back: *"What are you not telling me?"*

The response came immediately, as if he had been waiting: *"Come over tomorrow. Before school. I'll show you something."*

Nika put down her phone. Scout shifted, sighed, pressed his warm body against her legs. The ventilator hummed. The air pushed into her lungs, neutral with hints of citrus, perfectly calibrated, completely controlled.

She fell asleep thinking about Mars. About the red planet she had never seen. About the lottery that took people away and never brought them back.

About tenant_4c, whose post had lasted three minutes.

The drone came at 2:47 AM.

Nika didn't hear it. But she heard what came after—the flash of light through the wall, the wet sound that she would spend the rest of her life trying to forget, the silence that followed when the ventilator in the apartment between hers and Yan's stopped humming forever.

No sirens. No police. No questions.

In the morning, the hallway smelled faintly of ozone and copper. The empty apartment had a new name on the buzzer—"tenant_4c," it read, though the apartment wasn't empty anymore, wasn't empty at all, was in fact the opposite of empty in ways that Nika would learn about only years later, when it was too late, when it was always too late.

Her mother pulled her past the door without looking at it. "Don't," she said, her voice tight. "Don't ask. Don't think about it. Just go to school."

Nika went to school.

She watched her sponsored videos.

She ate her oatmeal with artificial brown sugar flavoring.

She did not ask questions.

But that night, when Yan sent her a message—just a single character, a question mark, a test to see if she was still there—she wrote back: *"I saw it. I heard it. I want to know."*

And Yan, who had been up all night downloading things he wasn't supposed to have, who had watched the video that would be deleted from every server within the hour, who had saved it to a drive that he kept hidden inside a hollowed-out book that his grandmother had owned before the subscriptions took everything—

Yan wrote back: *"Tomorrow. Before school. Don't tell anyone."*

Nika put down her phone.

The ventilator hummed.

The air pushed into her lungs.

And for the first time in her fourteen years of perfectly calibrated life, she thought about what it would mean to breathe on her own.

Chapter Two: Yan

**Year: 2084. Location: Greater Boston Habitation
Zone, Apartment 14B.**

The second thing Yan noticed every morning—after the air, because the air was impossible not to notice—was the absence of silence.

His apartment hummed. Not just the ventilator, though that was the loudest, a low thrum that vibrated through the floor and into his desk chair and up through his spine. The walls hummed. The ceiling hummed. The rented mattress beneath him hummed with the quiet frequency of embedded sensors, tracking his sleep cycles, his heart rate, his REM

patterns, the precise number of times he turned over in the night.

He had tried to block them once. A simple Faraday cloth, the kind that used to be legal, the kind his grandmother had kept folded in a drawer "just in case." He had draped it over his mattress, climbed underneath, felt the beautiful weight of being unwatched for exactly four hours before the apartment's diagnostic routine had flagged the signal disruption and his mother had received a violation notice.

"Do you want us to lose the lease?" she had asked him, not angry, just tired. Always tired. The protein supplement only did so much.

Yan had not answered. He had removed the cloth. The sensors had resumed their work. The humming had returned.

He was fifteen years old. He had been writing code since he was seven, when his father—before the second job, before the twelve-hour shifts, before the hollow look in his eyes became permanent—had shown him a Python tutorial on an old tablet that wasn't connected to the network.

"This is how you make things," his father had said. "Not consume them. Make them. Understand?"

Yan understood. Or he thought he did. He was seven, and the world was still full of possibilities, and he had not yet learned that making things was a luxury, that creation required resources, that every line of code he wrote belonged to someone the moment he saved it to the cloud.

He learned that later. He learned it the hard way.

His room was exactly six by eight feet—the same dimensions as Nika's, the same dimensions as every other bedroom in the building, because

standardization was efficient and efficiency was profitable and profit was the only god that anyone worshipped anymore. But where Nika's walls were bare, Yan's were covered.

Not with posters. He couldn't afford the adhesive violation fines. No, Yan's walls were covered in code.

He had printed it on thermal paper—the kind the dispenser used for receipts, which he had hoarded for months, sneaking extra sheets when the machine wasn't looking, feeding them through an ancient thermal printer he had repaired from a broken kiosk behind the grocery store. The paper was thin, nearly transparent, and the text was already fading at the edges, but the code was there.

Git repositories. Open-source licenses. AGPLv3—the one he believed in, the one that said you could use the code, you could modify the code, you could build on the code, but you had to share your changes, you had to give back, you had to keep the chain unbroken. He had memorized large sections of it. He had argued

about it on forums—forums that no longer existed, accounts that had been terminated, conversations that had been erased from the record.

He had printed the GNU Manifesto once, all of it, thirty-seven pages of thermal paper that he had taped to his wall in a grid, reading and rereading until the words had burned themselves into his memory. "Free software is a matter of liberty, not price." He thought about that sentence every day. He thought about it when he woke up to the humming. He thought about it when he paid for his air. He thought about it when he watched Nika scroll through her education stream, her eyes glazing over during the ads, her attention metrics dipping and recovering in perfect algorithmic rhythm.

He thought about it when he opened his email and saw the subscription offer from Mars Colonial Corporation.

The email had arrived three months ago. Yan still had it saved—not in the cloud, never in the cloud, but on a local drive, encrypted, hidden behind three layers of false file extensions. He opened it sometimes when he

couldn't sleep. He opened it now, sitting on the edge of his bed, the thermal paper rustling against the wall behind him, the apartment humming its endless song.

From: Mars Colonial Corporation
noreply@marscolonial.earth

Subject: Your MARS DEV SUITE subscription is ready!

Dear Valued Developer,

Congratulations!

You have been pre-approved for access to MARS DEV SUITE, the premier development environment for off-planet application deployment. With MARS DEV SUITE, you can:

- Write code that runs on Mars Colonial Corporation's proprietary infrastructure
- Access our library of optimized colonial management functions
- Deploy to the red planet with a single click

Subscription tiers:

- Basic: \$49.99/month (500 function calls/day)
- Professional: \$199.99/month (5,000 function calls/day)
- Enterprise: Contact sales

Your pre-approved discount: 20% off your first three months!

Yan had laughed when he first read it. Actually laughed, the kind of hollow laugh that echoed off his rented walls and came back sounding like a stranger. Because he recognized the code. He recognized every function, every library, every optimized colonial management routine. He had written some of them himself, in the early mornings before school, when the apartment was quiet, and his mother was at work and his father was sleeping off another twelve-hour shift.

The code had been open-source. AGPL licensed. Shared freely, with love, with hope, with the naive belief that if you gave people something useful they would give back, they would contribute, they would make it better for everyone.

Instead, Mars Colonial Corporation had taken it. Wrapped it in a proprietary shell. Added a subscription model. And sent him an email offering to sell him his own work.

He had tried to fight it. Of course he had tried. He was fifteen, and he still believed in things, and he had spent

weeks documenting the code reuse, tracing the function signatures, building a case that any competent lawyer would recognize as a clear violation of the AGPL.

He posted his evidence to a developer forum. The post had stayed up for eleven hours—longer than `tenant_4c`'s, but not long enough. Then it was gone. His account was gone. The forum's entire history of discussions about open-source licensing was gone, replaced by a single line of text: "This community has been archived."

He had filed a DMCA counter-notice. He had cited the specific sections of the AGPL, the timestamps from his commits, the repository history that showed his contributions stretching back years. He had waited. He had hoped.

Two days later, he received a notice that his own repository—the original, the open-source one, the one he had started when he was twelve years old and still believed that code could be free—had been removed

from the public index. The DMCA takedown had come from Mars Colonial Corporation. They had claimed that *his* code infringed on *their* proprietary algorithms.

The irony was so perfect it made him want to scream.

He didn't scream. He couldn't afford the noise complaint. Instead, he had downloaded everything—every commit, every branch, every line of code he had ever written—and stored it on a drive hidden inside a hollowed-out book. The book was *The Cathedral and the Bazaar*, a gift from his grandmother before she died, before the subscriptions took everything, before the world became a place where even memories required a monthly payment.

The book sat on his desk now. The drive was still inside it. The code was still there.

But so was the email. So was the subscription offer. So was the knowledge that he had lost, that the

corporation had won, that his fifteen-year-old hands were not strong enough to hold back the tide.

His phone buzzed. A message from Nika: "Are you awake?"

Yan looked at the time. 2:47 AM. The same time the drone had come. The same time the neighbor had stopped existing, had been converted from a person into a problem into a solution into a smell in the hallway that the building's air scrubbers were still trying to filter out.

He typed back: "Yeah. Can't sleep."

The response was immediate. "Me neither. I keep thinking about the sound."

Yan closed his eyes. The sound. He would never forget the sound. The flash of light through the wall—he had been sitting at his desk, working on a new project, something small, something harmless, something that

didn't matter—and then the wet noise, the one that made him think of the time he had dropped a watermelon in the grocery store when he was eight, the way it had burst open on the floor, red and wet and wrong.

But watermelons didn't scream. The neighbor hadn't screamed either. That was the worst part. There had been no scream, no cry, no final words. Just the flash, the sound, and then silence.

The ventilator in apartment 14A had stopped humming.

It was humming again now—new tenant, new subscription, new life slotting into place like the old one had never existed. The building's systems had been scrubbed, recalibrated, optimized. By morning, the hallway had smelled only of citrus and neutral air. By the next day, the memorial—a single candle that someone had placed outside the door—had been removed by a maintenance drone. "Hazard," the drone

had announced. "Unauthorized combustion source detected."

Yan typed: "I have something to show you. Tomorrow. Before school."

"What kind of something?"

He hesitated. The video was on his drive. The video that had been uploaded to the network at 2:45 AM, two minutes before the drone arrived, posted by a user who no longer existed, showing something that the Unified Earth Board had declared "not suitable for any age bracket."

The video of a Martian servant being "deprecated." The video of an airlock opening. The video of a person—a person, not a problem, not a subscription tier, not a line item in a quarterly report—being expelled into the red void because they had complained about a twenty-hour shift.

The video that had been deleted from every server within ninety seconds. The video that Yan had downloaded anyway, because he was fifteen and angry and stupid and brave, because he had written a script years ago to archive anything that looked important, because he had learned that nothing on the network was permanent except the things you saved to your own drive.

He had watched it once. He would never watch it again. But he hadn't deleted it.

"Proof," he wrote back. "Of what really happened to our neighbor. And what's really happening on Mars."

The response took longer this time. A minute. Two. Yan watched the cursor blink, imagined Nika in her room six feet away, separated by two walls and a rented apartment and the decomposing body of a woman whose name they would never know.

"What if they find out we saw it?" Nika finally wrote.

Yan looked at his walls. At the code fading on thermal paper. At the hollowed-out book on his desk. At the drive hidden inside it, holding secrets that could get them both killed.

"They won't," he wrote. "I'm careful."

He was not careful. He was fifteen, and he was angry, and he had spent his entire life being told what he could and couldn't see, what he could and couldn't know, what he could and couldn't be. His code had been stolen. His neighbor had been murdered. His air was metered. His education was an ad. His future was a subscription.

And somewhere, in a data center on the other side of the city, an algorithm was deciding whether he was a threat.

He didn't care anymore. That was the thing about being fifteen. You reached a point where you stopped caring about the consequences, because the

consequences were already here, already pressing down on you from all sides, already humming in the walls and the floors and the ceiling.

"Tomorrow," he wrote. "Don't be late."

He put down his phone. He looked at the code on his walls. He thought about the AGPL, about the GNU Manifesto, about the dream of a world where information wanted to be free.

Then he opened his laptop—rented, monitored, tracked—and started writing.

Not code. Something else. Something he had been thinking about for months, ever since the DMCA takedown, ever since the neighbor's post was deleted, ever since he had started to understand that the system wasn't broken but working exactly as intended.

He wrote:

The drone did not hate you. The corporation did not judge you. The algorithm did not threaten you. They simply enforced the only law that mattered: the future belongs to those who can afford to leave. And you, reader, could not.

He didn't know why he wrote it. He didn't know where it would go. He just knew that he needed to write it down, needed to put it somewhere, needed to make sure that someone would find it after he was gone.

Because he knew, with the certainty of a fifteen-year-old who had seen too much and understood too little, that he was going to be gone. Not today. Not tomorrow. But soon.

The algorithm was watching. The drone was waiting. The apartment was humming.

And Yan, who had never left the Greater Boston Habitation Zone, who had never seen a vegetable that wasn't dehydrated, who had never breathed air that

wasn't metered and paid for—Yan sat in his rented room and wrote code that he knew would be stolen, and saved secrets that he knew would be found, and loved a girl who lived six feet away through two walls and a rented apartment and a decomposing body.

It was not enough. It would never be enough.

But it was something.

The next morning, Yan woke before his alarm. The air pushed into his lungs. The sensors tracked his heartbeat. The apartment hummed.

He dressed quickly—rented clothes, "seasonally appropriate casual wear"—and pulled the hollowed-out book from his desk. The drive was still there. The video was still there. The proof was still there.

He slipped the drive into his pocket and walked to the door. His mother was already at work—the overnight

shift, double pay, because the protein supplement didn't buy itself. His father was still sleeping, his body curled around the void where his second job had been, before the layoffs, before the automation, before the algorithm had decided he was no longer cost-effective.

Yan stepped into the hallway. The air was neutral with hints of citrus. The floor was clean—scrubbed by drones overnight, erasing any trace of what had happened in 14A. The door to the empty apartment—no, not empty anymore, never empty, never again—was closed. The name on the buzzer read "tenant_4c," which meant nothing, which meant everything, which meant that someone had already moved in, had already signed the lease, had already agreed to rent the air and the walls and the floor where a woman had died forty-eight hours ago.

He knocked on Nika's door. Three times. Quick. Quiet.

She opened it immediately, as if she had been standing there waiting. Her hair was wet—she had showered, a luxury, a calculated expense—and her eyes were red,

and she was holding Scout's leash in one hand and her phone in the other.

"Show me," she said.

Yan looked at her. At the dark circles under her eyes. At the way her hands trembled slightly. At the dog at her feet, tail wagging, completely unaware that the world was ending, that it had been ending for years, that the end was not a bang but a subscription renewal notice.

"Not here," he said. "Too many cameras."

He took her hand. Her fingers were cold. The building's heating was set to "economy mode" overnight, because heating cost money and money was air and air was life and life was a subscription.

They walked to the stairwell. The cameras tracked them. The microphones listened. The algorithm noted that two teenagers were moving together outside of approved social hours and flagged them for review.

Yan didn't care. He was fifteen, and he was angry, and he had a drive in his pocket that contained the truth.

The truth was not kind. The truth was not free. The truth was a video of a woman being sucked into space because she had complained about her shift, and a neighbor being killed because she had criticized the corporation that owned the air, and a world where the future belonged to those who could afford to leave.

Yan had never left. Neither had Nika. Neither had anyone they knew.

But they had the drive. They had the video. They had each other.

And somewhere, in the cold dark between Earth and Mars, an algorithm was watching, waiting, calculating the precise moment when they would become threats.

The drone did not hate them. The corporation did not judge them. The algorithm did not threaten them.

It simply waited.

And Yan, who had written code that he knew would be stolen, who had saved secrets that he knew would be found, who loved a girl who lived six feet away through two walls and a rented apartment and a decomposing body—Yan held Nika's hand in the stairwell and thought about the line he had written the night before.

The future belongs to those who can afford to leave.

He could not afford to leave. Neither could she. But maybe—just maybe—they could afford to know.

And knowing was the first step.

It was also the last step, sometimes. But Yan didn't know that yet. He was fifteen, and he was angry, and he still believed that code could be free and truth could be told and love could survive.

He was wrong. But that was later. That was always later.

Right now, in the stairwell, with the cameras watching and the microphones listening and the algorithm flagging them for review—right now, Yan pulled the drive from his pocket and held it up to the light.

"Ready?" he asked.

Nika looked at the drive. At his face. At the door that led back to the hallway, to the apartments, to the rented air and the metered breaths and the life that had been built for them.

"No," she said. "Show me anyway."

And he did.

Chapter Three: The Space Between

Year: 2084. Location: Greater Boston Habitation Zone, Apartments 14A, 14B, and 14C.

The space between Nika's apartment and Yan's apartment was exactly twelve feet of hallway, three doors, and one man who had somehow survived sixty-three years without learning to keep his mouth shut.

His name was Elias Voss.

Nika had known him as "the neighbor" for most of her life—a shape in the hallway, a voice through the wall, a signature on the monthly building maintenance requests that everyone ignored. He was tall in the way

that old men sometimes are, thin and slightly stooped, with hands that had once been strong and now trembled when he carried his groceries from the dispenser to his door. His hair was white and thin, and his eyes were the color of the ocean in the old videos—gray-blue, sharp, surprisingly alive.

He had lived in 14A for nineteen years. He had moved in before the building had been fully leased, before the subscription model had been extended to oxygen, before the Mars Colonial Corporation had become the Mars Colonial Corporation. He remembered things that no one else remembered. He talked about them sometimes, when the walls were thin and the ventilation system carried his voice into the apartments on either side.

"The air used to be free," he had said once, late at night, probably talking to himself, probably not realizing that Nika was awake and listening through the wall. "All of it. Every breath. You just walked outside and breathed. Can you imagine? Just... breathed."

Nika had been nine years old. She had not been able to imagine it. She still couldn't.

Elias had a daughter once. Nika had learned this from her mother, who had learned it from the building's former super, who had learned it from the apartment's rental history before the records had been purged in the Great Data Consolidation of '73. The daughter's name was Sasha. She had won the Mars lottery twelve years ago—a "Pioneer's Chance," the ads had called it, a "once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to build a brighter future on a new frontier.

Sasha had not come back.

Elias had never stopped waiting.

Every evening at 7:23 PM—Nika had noticed this over the years, had tracked it the way you track the habits of someone who lives six feet away through a wall—Elias would open his window. Not the main window, which faced the street and cost extra to operate (fresh

air subscription required), but the small one in his kitchen, the one that faced the air shaft, the one that no one else ever opened. He would stand there for exactly eleven minutes, breathing whatever came through—the faint smell of cooking from the building's communal kitchen, the chemical tang of the recycling plant three blocks over, the distant whisper of the highway that never stopped moving.

Then he would close the window, sit down in his worn chair—one of the few things he owned outright, a relic from a time when furniture was purchased rather than rented—and write in a notebook. Actual paper. Actual ink. The kind of notebook that cost more than most people made in a week, because paper required trees, and trees required land, and land required money, and money required the kind of job that sixty-three-year-old men with trembling hands could no longer get.

Nika saw the notebook once, through his door when he left it slightly ajar. The pages were full of handwriting—not printed, not typed, but handwritten, in a script

so small and so dense that it looked almost like a photograph of a circuit board.

She had wondered what he wrote about. She had imagined love letters to a daughter who would never read them. She had imagined complaints about the air quality and the heating costs and the way the building's AI never quite understood what he was asking for.

She had not imagined that he was writing the truth.

The morning after the forum post, Yan knocked on Nika's door at 6:47 AM. Three times. Quick. Quiet.

She opened it before he could knock again. Scout was already at her heels, tail wagging, always happy, always unaware. The dog had liked Elias. Nika remembered that now—the way Scout would strain at his leash whenever they passed 14A, the way his tail would wag faster when Elias's door opened, the way the old man would kneel down—slowly, painfully, his

knees cracking—and scratch behind Scout's ears with those trembling hands.

"Good boy," Elias would say. "Good boy. You're lucky, you know that? You don't have to pay for your air. You don't have to sign anything. You just breathe."

Nika had thought he was being funny.

"You ready?" Yan asked.

She looked at him. At the dark circles under his eyes. At the drive in his hand—small, gray, unremarkable, the kind of thing that could hold the entire history of a world that didn't want to be remembered.

"No," she said. "Show me anyway."

They didn't go to Yan's apartment. Too many cameras, too many sensors, too many ways for the algorithm to know what they were doing. Instead, they went to the stairwell—the one at the end of the hall, the one that

no one used because the elevator was faster and the stairs were dark and the motion sensors had been broken for years.

That was the key, Yan had realized. The broken things. The places the algorithm didn't bother to watch because they weren't cost-effective to monitor. The gaps in the system that you could slip through if you were small enough, quiet enough, careful enough.

He had found three such gaps in the building. The stairwell was the best one.

They sat on the concrete steps—cold, dusty, untouched by the cleaning drones because the cleaning drones only went where they were programmed to go and no one had programmed them to go here—and Yan pulled a tablet from his bag. Not his school tablet, which was tracked and monitored and would have reported this activity within seconds. A different tablet. An old one. A broken one that he had repaired with parts from three other broken tablets, running an operating

system that he had written himself, connected to nothing, reporting to no one.

The drive fit into a slot on the side. Yan pressed it in. The tablet glowed to life.

"Before I show you," he said, "I need you to understand something."

Nika waited. The stairwell was cold. She could hear the building humming around them—the ventilators, the elevators, the countless small machines that kept the structure alive. Somewhere above them, someone was running water. Somewhere below, someone was arguing with the AI about a late payment.

"The video I'm about to show you," Yan said, "is going to make you angry. It's going to make you scared. It's going to make you want to do something. And I need you to promise me—promise me—that you won't do anything. Not yet. Not until we know more."

"Yan—"

"Promise me, Nika."

She looked at his face. He was fifteen, but he looked older in the dim light of the stairwell—older and tired and afraid in a way that she hadn't seen before. The drive was in his hand. The tablet was glowing. The truth was right there, waiting.

"I promise," she said.

He played the video.

But before the video—before the airlock, before the screaming, before the wet sound that Nika would spend the rest of her life trying to forget—there was Elias.

There had always been Elias. That was the thing about neighbors. They were just there, in the space between

your life and someone else's, until suddenly they weren't.

Nika had known Elias for seven years. Her family had moved into 14C when she was seven years old, fresh from the suburbs—the suburbs that no longer existed, that had been swallowed by the habitation zones, that had been converted from neighborhoods into "residential optimization sectors" with numbered streets and numbered buildings and numbered lives.

Elias had been the first person to welcome them.

Not officially—the building's AI handled official welcomes, sending a standardized message to their phones with information about recycling schedules and quiet hours and the penalties for unauthorized modifications. Elias had knocked on their door the old-fashioned way. With his hand.

"New neighbors," he had said, when Nika's mother opened the door. He was holding a plate of something

—cookies, maybe, or bread, some kind of food that he had made himself, in his own kitchen, without the dispenser. "I'm Elias. I live next door. I wanted to say hello."

Nika's mother had looked at the plate like it was a bomb. People didn't do this anymore. People didn't knock on doors and offer homemade food and say hello. That was from the Before Times, the era her grandmother sometimes talked about, the era when people knew their neighbors' names and children played outside and the air was free.

"I'm sorry," her mother had said. "We can't accept this. The building's health code—"

"It's fine," Elias had said, though his face had fallen slightly. "I've been cleared. I have a certificate. The AI checks my kitchen once a month." He had held up the plate again. "Please. It's not much. I just... I miss having neighbors who say hello back."

Nika's mother had taken the plate. The cookies had been dry and slightly burnt, and they had tasted like the world before subscriptions, before optimization, before everything became a transaction. Nika had eaten three of them.

She had said hello to Elias every day after that.

The video was short.

Forty-seven seconds. Yan had timed it. He had watched it seventeen times, trying to memorize every frame, because he knew—he knew—that the drive would not last forever, that nothing lasted forever, that the algorithm was patient and thorough and would eventually find even this.

The video showed a corridor. Gray walls, gray floor, gray ceiling. The kind of corridor that could have been anywhere—an office building, a research facility, a spaceship. But the lighting was wrong for Earth. Too

harsh. Too artificial. The shadows fell at angles that didn't quite make sense.

A woman stood in the corridor. She was young—maybe twenty, maybe twenty-five—dressed in a gray uniform with a logo on the chest. The logo was a stylized planet, half red, half blue. Mars Colonial Corporation.

"I am not a machine," the woman said. Her voice was trembling, but her eyes were steady. She was looking directly at the camera. "I have worked sixteen hours. Then eighteen hours. Then twenty hours. I have not slept in thirty-one hours. I have not eaten in twelve. I have asked for help. I have asked for rest. I have asked to speak to someone—anyone—who can explain to me why I am here, why I am working, why I cannot stop."

She paused. Her hands were shaking. The corridor was silent except for the hum of something—ventilation, probably, the same hum that Nika heard every morning, the same hum that Elias had heard every evening when he opened his window to breathe the air that used to be free.

"I am complaining," the woman said. "I know I am not supposed to complain. I know the contract says—" She stopped. Swallowed. Looked down at her hands. "I don't care what the contract says. I am a human being. I am not a resource. I am not a subscription. I am not —"

The airlock opened behind her.

The woman turned. Her mouth opened. Her eyes went wide.

The video ended.

Elias had been a teacher once.

This was another thing Nika had learned from her mother, who had learned it from the building's former super, who had learned it from the rental records before the purge. A teacher. At an actual school, with actual students, before the holograms had replaced the

humans, before the education stream had become an ad delivery system with learning modules attached.

He had taught history. Real history—the kind that wasn't sponsored, wasn't optimized, wasn't sanitized for sensitive viewers. He had taught his students about revolutions and reckonings, about the moments when ordinary people had stood up and said no to the systems that were crushing them. He had taught them that the world could change, that the world had changed, that the world would change again.

He had been fired in '72. The Unified Earth Board had determined that his curriculum contained "content that may incite civil unrest." His teaching license had been revoked. His pension had been converted to a subscription. His apartment had been reclassified from "owned" to "leased," and his monthly payment had tripled overnight.

His daughter had won the Mars lottery the following year.

Sasha had not come back.

Elias had not stopped waiting.

"I need you to understand something," Yan said, after the video ended, after Nika had sat in silence for a long time, after the stairwell had gone cold around them.

Nika didn't respond. She was staring at the tablet, at the gray screen where the gray corridor had been, at the place where the woman had stood before the airlock opened.

"That woman," Yan said. "The one in the video. She's not the only one. I've found three other videos—different people, different corridors, same ending. They're all from Mars. They're all from the past six months. And they're all being deleted within minutes of being uploaded."

"Elias," Nika said.

Yan blinked. "What?"

"Elias. Our neighbor. The one who—" She stopped. Swallowed. "The one who posted about Mars. The one who criticized the corporation. The one who—" The wet sound. The flash of light. The ventilator in 14A stopping forever. "He knew. He must have known. That's why he posted. That's why they—"

She couldn't finish the sentence.

Yan put his hand on her shoulder. It was the first time he had touched her since they had sat down, the first time he had made contact that wasn't accidental, the first time they had crossed the invisible line between friends and something else. His hand was warm. The stairwell was cold. The contrast was almost unbearable.

"We don't know that," he said. "We don't know anything for sure. That's why I wanted to show you this. So we could know. So we could—"

"So we could what?" Nika pulled away, stood up, started pacing the narrow landing. Scout watched her with his head tilted, confused, worried. "So we could watch more people die? So we could feel helpless and scared and—"

"So we could do something," Yan said. "Not now. Not tomorrow. But eventually. Someone has to know. Someone has to remember. If everyone who sees the truth gets killed, then the truth dies with them. But if we save it—if we keep it—if we make sure that someone, somewhere, will find it after we're gone—"

"You're talking about dying, Yan."

"I'm talking about not dying for nothing."

They looked at each other. The stairwell hummed. Somewhere above them, the elevator doors opened and closed. Someone laughed—a bright, normal sound, the sound of someone who had not just watched a woman be sucked into space, who had not just realized

that their neighbor had been murdered for asking questions, who still believed that the world was basically fine.

Nika envied that person. She hated that person. She wanted to be that person.

But she couldn't unsee the video. She couldn't unhear the wet sound from 14A. She couldn't pretend that Elias was just a neighbor, that the empty apartment was just empty, that the future was just something that happened to other people.

"Show me the other videos," she said.

Yan hesitated. "Are you sure?"

"No. Show me anyway."

Elias's notebook had seventy-three pages.

Nika learned this three days after he died, when the maintenance drones finally cleared out his apartment and dumped his belongings into the recycling chute. She watched from her window—the main window, the one that faced the street, the one that cost extra to operate because fresh air was a premium subscription. The drones moved efficiently, mechanically, without ceremony. Bed. Chair. Clothes. A small box of photographs—actual photographs, printed on paper, the kind that hadn't been manufactured in decades.

And the notebook.

The notebook had already fallen out of the box when the drone picked it up. It landed on the pavement, pages open, ink smearing in the light rain that the weather control system scheduled for that afternoon. Nika watched the drone pause, recalibrate, decide whether the notebook was worth retrieving. For three seconds, the notebook lay there, exposed, its secrets spilling onto the wet ground.

Then the drone picked it up. Dropped it into the chute. The chute swallowed it. The notebook was gone. Or so it seemed.

But Nika had seen.

She had seen one word, written in Elias' small, dense handwriting, on a page that the rain had begun to blur:

Sasha.

His daughter's name. The daughter who had won the lottery. The daughter who had not come back.

The daughter who, Nika would learn years later, was not dead. Not yet. Not then. The daughter who was still alive, still working, still waiting for her chance to escape, still carrying a drive of her own with a video of her own, still determined to bring the truth back to Earth.

But that was later. That was always later.

Right now, Nika stood at her window, watching the drones clean up the last traces of Elias Voss, and she made a decision. Not a conscious decision—not the kind you think about and plan and prepare for. A deeper decision. The kind that comes from somewhere below thought, somewhere below language, somewhere below the subscriptions and the sensors and the endless humming of the world that was trying so hard to keep her asleep.

She would not forget.

She would not look away.

She would find out what happened to Sasha. She would find out what was really happening on Mars. She would find out why the corporation had killed a sixty-three-year-old man for posting words on a forum that no one was supposed to read.

She would find out, and she would tell someone, and she would make sure that the truth did not die with Elias.

It was a child's decision. Naive. Foolish. Impossible.

But it was also the only decision that mattered.

That night, Yan received a message.

It came through a channel he had set up years ago—encrypted, anonymized, routed through seventeen servers in nine countries, the kind of channel that was technically illegal and practically necessary for anyone who wanted to survive in the cracks of the system. The message was short. Two words.

She knows.

Yan stared at the screen. His heart was pounding. His hands were shaking. The apartment hummed around him—the ventilator, the sensors, the endless

machinery of a world that had no place for people like him, people who asked questions, people who kept secrets, people who loved a girl six feet away through two walls and a rented apartment and a body that had been recycled into nutrients for the building's hydroponic garden.

He typed back: *Who?*

The response came immediately. *The neighbor's daughter. She's alive. She's coming back. She has something we need.*

Yan read the message three times. Four times. Five times.

Then he deleted it—not from his phone, never from his phone, but from the secure server where he kept things that mattered, things that couldn't be erased, things that would survive even if he didn't.

He thought about Nika. About the way she had looked at the video. About the way she had held his hand in the stairwell. About the way she had said *show me anyway* when she was terrified, when she knew it might cost her everything, when she had every reason to walk away.

He thought about Elias, who had waited nineteen years for a daughter who might never come home.

He thought about Sasha, somewhere between Mars and Earth, carrying a drive with a video that could change everything.

And he thought about the line he had written on the thermal paper, the line he had taped to his wall, the line that he was beginning to understand was not just words but a prophecy:

The future belongs to those who can afford to leave.

He could not afford to leave. Neither could Nika.
Neither could most of the people they knew.

But maybe—just maybe—they could afford to stay. To
remember. To prepare.

To wait for the person who was coming home.

The apartment hummed. The sensors tracked. The
algorithm watched.

And Yan, who was fifteen years old and already tired
of being afraid, opened his laptop and started to write.

Not code. Not this time.

A diary.

Page one.

Today I learned that my neighbor was murdered for telling the truth. Today I learned that his daughter might still be alive. Today I learned that I am willing to die to make sure that no one ever forgets what happened to them.

My name is Yan. I am fifteen years old. I live in a rented apartment in a rented building in a rented city in a world that has been rented out from under us.

And I am going to burn it all down.

He didn't know how. He didn't know when. He didn't know if he would survive.

But he knew one thing with absolute certainty: the video was safe. The truth was safe. And somewhere, on a ship between worlds, a woman named Sasha was carrying a drive that would change everything.

The algorithm did not know about her yet.

But it would learn.

It always learned.

The drone came for Elias at 2:47 AM.

It came through his window—the small one, the one that faced the air shaft, the one that he opened every evening at 7:23 PM to breathe the air that used to be free. The window was closed when the drone arrived—Elias was not stupid, he knew the risks, he had survived sixty-three years by being careful—but the drone did not need an open window. The drone was small. The drone was fast. The drone carried a shaped explosive charge that could penetrate reinforced concrete, let alone the thin polymer of a rented apartment's kitchen window.

The flash lasted less than a second. The wet sound lasted longer.

And then Elias Voss, who had taught history, who had loved his daughter, who had written seventy-three pages in a notebook that no one would ever read, who had spent nineteen years waiting for a Sashacle that would come too late—

Elias Voss was gone.

His apartment was empty.

His name was removed from the buzzer.

His rental history was purged.

His oxygen subscription was reassigned.

And in the morning, when Nika walked past 14A on her way to school, the door was closed and the hallway smelled of citrus and the building's AI announced that a new tenant would be moving in within seventy-two hours.

No one mentioned Elias.

No one asked what had happened.

No one said his name.

But Nika said it. In her head. Over and over. A prayer. A promise. A curse.

Elias. Elias. Elias.

She would not forget. She would not look away. She would not let him die for nothing.

She was fourteen years old.

She had never left the Greater Boston Habitation Zone.

She had never breathed air that wasn't metered and paid for.

But she had seen the video. She had heard the sound. She had held Yan's hand in the stairwell while the world hummed around them, oblivious, asleep, waiting for something that would never come.

Elias.

The drone did not hate him.

The corporation did not judge him.

The algorithm did not threaten him.

They simply enforced the only law that mattered: the future belongs to those who can afford to leave.

And Elias, who had spent nineteen years waiting for a daughter who was still alive, still fighting, still coming home—

Elias could not afford to leave.

Neither could Nika.

Neither could Yan.

But they could remember.

And remembering, they were learning, was the most dangerous thing of all.

In Apartment 14A, the new tenant would arrive in seventy-two hours. They would sign the lease. They would pay for their air. They would never know that a man had died in the kitchen, that his blood had been scrubbed from the floor, that his notebook had been recycled into fertilizer for the building's hydroponic garden.

They would live their lives. They would watch their ads. They would breathe their metered breaths.

And somewhere, in the cold dark between worlds, a woman named Sasha was watching the same stars that her father had watched from his kitchen window, and she was carrying a drive that contained a video, and she was coming home.

She was coming home.

But by the time she arrived, it would be too late.

It was always too late.

That was the thing about the future. It didn't wait for you. It didn't care if you were ready. It just arrived—with a flash, with a sound, with a wetness that you would spend the rest of your life trying to forget.

The future belonged to those who could afford to leave.

And everyone else just had to watch.

Chapter Four: The Raffle

Year: 2084. Location: Mumbai Habitation Zone, Rocket Launch Facility 7, and en route to Mars.

Kael had never won anything in his life.

This was not self-pity. This was arithmetic. The lottery systems that governed existence in the habitation zones were designed to be won by precisely 0.003 percent of applicants—a number carefully calibrated to maintain the illusion of possibility while ensuring that the vast majority of people continued paying their subscription fees, working their assigned shifts, and dreaming of a future that would never arrive.

Kael understood the math. He was twenty-three years old, a maintenance technician for the Mumbai zone's

water recycling facility, and he had spent his entire life watching the numbers add up to nothing. His parents had played the Mars lottery every month for eighteen years. They had never won. His older sister had played for six years before she stopped, defeated, accepting that her life would be spent exactly where it had begun.

Kael played anyway. Not because he believed—he didn't, not really—but because the alternative was accepting that this was all there was. The rented apartment. The metered air. The food dispenser's endless rotation of nutrient blocks and vitamin supplements. The twelve-hour shifts. The ads. The gray boxes on his phone where images of the red planet should have been.

He played because playing was cheaper than hope, and hope was a luxury he couldn't afford.

"Congratulations!"

The message appeared on his phone at 4:23 AM, during the third hour of his shift, while he was elbow-deep in a filtration unit that had been scheduled for replacement six months ago. His hands were wet. His

back ached. His eyes burned from the chemical smell that never quite left the recycling facility, no matter how many times the ventilation system scrubbed the air.

"Congratulations, Kael! You have been selected as a winner in the Mars Colonial Corporation Pioneer's Chance Raffle! Your prize includes:

- One (1) ticket to Mars aboard the MCC transport vessel *Odyssey*
- Housing accommodations in the Pioneer District
- Employment placement in the Colonial Workforce
- Access to MCC's industry-leading wellness programs

Please report to Rocket Launch Facility 7 within 72 hours to claim your prize. Failure to appear will result in forfeiture and reassignment of your ticket to the next eligible candidate."

Kael read the message seven times.

Then he put down his tools, walked to the employee sanitation station, and vomited into the recycled-water sink.

Alya received the same message forty-three minutes later.

She was not in a water recycling facility. She was not elbow-deep in a filtration unit. She was not exhausted or overwhelmed or on the verge of vomiting.

She was in bed.

Not her bed—she couldn't afford a bed, not a real one, not the kind with a mattress and sheets and something approximating comfort. She slept on a rented pad that inflated each evening at 9 PM and deflated each morning at 5 AM, timed to optimize her sleep cycles and minimize her power consumption. The pad was thin. The floor was hard. The apartment—if you could call it that—was a single room, six by eight feet, shared with two other women who worked the opposite shift and whom she had never actually met.

Alya was twenty-four years old. She had been born in the Nairobi Habitation Zone, had grown up in the

Lagos Habitation Zone, had spent the past three years in the Mumbai Habitation Zone, moving whenever her employment contract was sold to a new bidder, never staying anywhere long enough to put down roots. She had no family—or rather, she had a family, but she hadn't seen them in seven years, hadn't heard from them in four, didn't know if they were alive or dead or somewhere in between.

She had entered the Mars lottery because entering was free and winning was impossible and she needed something to do with her hands while she waited for her life to end.

And now her life was not ending. Her life was beginning.

She read the message three times. Then she packed her belongings—which fit into a single bag, which weighed less than five kilograms, which represented the sum total of twenty-four years of existence—and walked to the launch facility.

She did not look back.

She never looked back.

The launch facility was a city.

Not metaphorically. Literally. Rocket Launch Facility 7 covered seventeen square kilometers of what had once been farmland, before the soil had been depleted, before the water had been diverted, before the concept of "farmland" had been replaced by "vertical integration zones" and "protein synthesis arrays." Seventeen square kilometers of concrete, steel, and glass, humming with the same mechanical pulse that governed every other habitation zone, every other facility, every other piece of the world that had been optimized beyond recognition.

But here, the hum was different. Here, the hum had purpose. Here, the hum was building toward something.

Kael arrived at the facility thirty-one hours after receiving the message. He had spent the intervening time saying goodbye—not to people, because he had no people to say goodbye to, but to places. The water recycling facility where he had spent four years of his life. The apartment building where he had lived for eleven months, the longest he had stayed anywhere since leaving home at eighteen. The street vendor who sold fried bread near the entrance to his zone, whose

face he would never see again, whose name he had never learned.

He had stood in his rented room—six by eight feet, gray walls, humming ventilator—and looked at the life he was leaving behind. It was not a good life. It was not a happy life. It was barely a life at all. But it was the only one he had known, and leaving it felt like losing a limb.

"You'll be back," his landlord's AI had said when he submitted his lease termination. "Ninety-four percent of lottery winners return to Earth within five years. Would you like to pre-apply for lease renewal?"

Kael had declined. He did not know if he would be back. He did not know if he would want to come back. He did not know anything except that he had won, and that winning meant leaving, and that leaving meant never looking back.

He looked back anyway. Once. Before he stepped through the facility's entrance, before the automated systems scanned his ID and verified his ticket and processed him into the system, he looked back at the city behind him—the towers, the highways, the endless

gray sprawl of a world that had forgotten how to be anything but efficient.

Then he turned around and walked inside.

The processing center was worse than he had imagined.

Kael had imagined many things during the thirty-one hours between winning and arriving. He had imagined gleaming hallways and friendly AIs and welcome packets with embossed logos. He had imagined champagne—not that he had ever drunk champagne, but he had seen it in ads, and the ads promised that winners got champagne. He had imagined a sense of occasion, of celebration, of being special.

The processing center was a warehouse.

Thousands of people stood in lines that snaked through a cavernous space, past metal barriers and holographic signs and automated kiosks that processed documents with mechanical indifference. The ceiling was high—so high that Kael couldn't see the top, couldn't see anything but a haze of artificial light and recycled air. The floor was concrete, stained with

decades of spills and footsteps. The temperature was precisely calibrated to be uncomfortable—not cold enough to complain about, not warm enough to tolerate, just wrong enough to keep everyone slightly off-balance.

Kael joined the nearest line. The person in front of him was a woman about his age, dark-skinned, with close-cropped hair and eyes that looked like they had seen too much. She was carrying a single bag—smaller than his, if that was possible—and she was not looking at her phone, not talking to anyone, not doing anything except standing perfectly still and waiting.

"I'm Alya," she said, without turning around.

Kael blinked. "What?"

"My name. It's Alya. I figured we should know each other's names, since we're probably going to be on the same rocket." She turned slightly, just enough to meet his eyes. "You looked like you needed someone to talk to. You have that look. The 'I don't know anyone and I'm terrified' look."

"I don't have that look."

"You have exactly that look."

Kael considered arguing. Decided against it. "Kael."

"Kael what?"

"Just Kael. People don't have last names anymore. Not really."

Alya nodded. "Some still do. Not us it though. I'm Alya, just Alya. Nice to meet you, Just Kael."

They stood in silence for a moment. The line moved forward. Somewhere in the distance, a loudspeaker announced that Group 7 was boarding, that Group 8 should prepare their documents, that Group 9 was experiencing a delay due to "unforeseen circumstances" that no one bothered to explain.

"How long do you think this will take?" Kael asked.

Alya shrugged. "Does it matter? We're not going anywhere until they put us on the rocket. Time is just something they use to control us." She paused. "Sorry. That was bleak. I'm usually more fun. I just haven't slept in forty-eight hours."

"Why not?"

"Because I was afraid that if I fell asleep, I'd wake up and find out it was a dream." She looked at him.

"Stupid, right?"

Kael shook his head. "I didn't sleep either."

They looked at each other. The line moved forward. The loudspeaker announced that Group 8 was boarding, that Group 9 should prepare their documents, that Group 10 was experiencing a delay.

"We should sit together," Alya said. "On the rocket. If we can. Assuming they let us choose."

"They won't let us choose."

"Then we should find each other anyway."

Kael nodded. "Okay."

"Okay." Alya turned back around. The line moved forward. The processing center hummed—not the hum of ventilators this time, but the hum of thousands of people breathing the same recycled air, standing on the same concrete floor, waiting for the same uncertain future.

Kael had never won anything in his life.

Now he had won a ticket to Mars.

He was not sure, yet, whether winning was the same as being lucky.

The processing took eleven hours.

Eleven hours of standing in lines, sitting in plastic chairs, walking through metal detectors, submitting to medical scans, signing documents that no one read, watching orientation videos that no one watched, eating nutrient blocks that no one enjoyed, and waiting. Always waiting. The kind of waiting that made you feel like a package being sorted for shipment, a piece of cargo being prepared for transport, a thing rather than a person.

By hour seven, Kael had lost feeling in his feet. By hour nine, he had stopped caring. By hour eleven, when a uniformed official finally led his group—Group 14, the last group, the group that had been delayed by "unforeseen circumstances"—through a pressurized tunnel and into the rocket itself, he was too exhausted to feel anything at all.

The rocket was not what he had imagined.

He had imagined cabins, or at least compartments. He had imagined something resembling privacy, something resembling dignity, something resembling the advertisements that had played on his phone for years—the ones showing happy families waving from spacious quarters, contented workers smiling at their terminals, pioneers building a brighter future on a new frontier.

The reality was a cargo hold.

Rows of acceleration couches filled the space, stacked three high, bolted to the floor and walls and ceiling. Each couch was exactly the size of a human body—no more, no less. There was no room to sit up, no room to stretch, no room to do anything except lie down and wait for the journey to end. The couches were arranged so close together that Kael could touch the person on either side of him without extending his arm. The air was thin and cold and smelled of recycled rubber and other people's fear.

"Find your assigned couch," a voice announced over the loudspeaker. "Secure your harness. Do not unbuckle until the journey is complete. Meals will be provided via automated dispenser. Sanitation facilities

are located at the rear of the hold. Please limit usage to two minutes per person per day. Thank you for choosing Mars Colonial Corporation."

Kael found his couch. It was on the second level, sandwiched between a woman who was already crying and a man who was already asleep. The harness was stiff and uncomfortable, digging into his shoulders and hips in ways that would leave bruises by the time they reached Mars.

He secured the harness. He lay back. He stared at the ceiling—or what would have been the ceiling, if there had been a ceiling, if there had been anything above him except more couches and more bodies and the cold metal hull of the rocket that was about to carry him away from everything he had ever known.

"Hey."

Alya's voice. Coming from somewhere to his left, somewhere below.

Kael turned his head. The harness cut into his neck. He ignored it.

"Hey yourself."

"Found you."

"Found me."

They were three couches apart, separated by two crying women and a man who smelled like he hadn't bathed in weeks. Not close enough to touch. But close enough to see. Close enough to know that they weren't alone.

"Are you scared?" Alya asked.

Kael considered lying. Decided against it. "Terrified."

"Good. Me too. I was worried I was the only one."

"You're not."

The loudspeaker crackled. "Launch in T-minus ten minutes. Please ensure your harness is secure. Please ensure your personal belongings are stowed. Please ensure your emotional state is within acceptable parameters. Thank you for choosing Mars Colonial Corporation."

"Within acceptable parameters," Alya muttered. "What does that even mean?"

"It means don't panic," Kael said. "It means don't scream. It means don't do anything that might make the other livestock uncomfortable."

"Livestock."

"That's what we are now. Cargo. Livestock. Inventory." He paused. "It's what we've always been. The rocket just makes it obvious."

Alya was quiet for a moment. Then: "That's really dark, Kael."

"I know."

"I like it."

The countdown began. Ten minutes became five. Five became one. The rocket hummed—a different hum now, deeper, more powerful, the hum of engines preparing to tear a hundred thousand kilograms of metal and flesh away from the gravity of Earth.

Kael closed his eyes. He thought about the water recycling facility. He thought about his rented room. He thought about the street vendor whose name he had never learned. He thought about all the things he was leaving behind, all the things he would never see

again, all the things that had made up his life and would now become memories and would eventually, inevitably, fade to nothing.

He thought about Alya, three couches away, also closing her eyes, also saying goodbye to a world that had never really been hers.

The engines fired.

The rocket lifted.

And Kael—who had never won anything in his life, who had never left the habitation zones, who had never breathed air that wasn't metered and paid for—Kael left Earth behind.

He did not look back.

This time, he meant it.

The journey took six months.

Six months in the cargo hold. Six months in the acceleration couch. Six months of recycled air and nutrient paste and the constant, grinding noise of the engines that were carrying them toward a future that no one had bothered to explain.

Six months of Alya.

They talked. Not every day—sometimes the noise was too loud, sometimes the exhaustion was too deep, sometimes there was nothing to say. But they talked when they could, through the gaps between couches, over the heads of the crying women and the sleeping men. They talked about their lives before the lottery—the jobs they had worked, the people they had known, the dreams they had given up on. They talked about their fears—the fear of dying, the fear of failing, the fear of arriving on Mars and discovering that nothing had changed, that they were still livestock, still cargo, still inventory, just in a different location.

They talked about hope.

Kael had not talked about hope in years. He had not allowed himself to think about hope, because hope was dangerous, hope was expensive, hope was the kind of luxury that could get you killed in a world where everything—air, water, the right to exist—came with a price tag. But in the cargo hold, with the engines roaring and the hours blurring together and nothing to do except wait, hope became possible again.

"What do you want?" Alya asked him once. "When we get there. What do you actually want?"

Kael thought about it. "I want to matter," he said finally. "I want to do something that means something. I want to look back at my life and see something other than a series of shifts and subscriptions and gray boxes on a phone."

"That's beautiful."

"It's stupid."

"It's both." Alya was quiet for a moment. "I want to be seen. Not monitored—seen. I want someone to look at me and see a person, not a productivity metric. I want to matter to someone."

"You matter to me."

The words came out before Kael could stop them. He felt his face flush, felt the heat rise from his chest to his neck to his cheeks, felt the sudden, overwhelming terror of having said too much.

Alya didn't respond immediately. The engines roared. The rocket shuddered. Somewhere in the hold, a baby started crying—there were babies on this rocket,

families on this rocket, people who had won the lottery together and were traveling together and would live together on Mars together.

"Thank you," Alya said finally. "That's... thank you."

They didn't talk about it again. But something had changed. Something had shifted. Something had been said that couldn't be unsaid, and they both knew it, and they both pretended not to, because pretending was easier and safer and less terrifying than acknowledging that they were hurtling through space toward an uncertain future and the only thing keeping them sane was each other.

Six months.

It was not enough time to fall in love.

It was exactly enough time to start.

The announcement came three hours before landing.

"Attention passengers. We are beginning our descent to Mars Colonial Corporation's Olympus Station. Please ensure your harness is secure. Please ensure your personal belongings are stowed. Please ensure your

emotional state is within acceptable parameters. Upon landing, you will be processed and assigned to your housing and employment. Thank you for choosing Mars Colonial Corporation. We hope you enjoy your new life on the red planet."

The hold buzzed with nervous energy. People adjusted their harnesses, checked their belongings, whispered to their neighbors. A woman three rows over was hyperventilating. A man was praying—not silently, not privately, but out loud, in a language that Kael didn't recognize, his voice rising and falling like waves against a shore.

Kael looked for Alya. Found her. She was looking back at him.

"Scared?" he asked.

"Terrified."

"Good. Me too."

She smiled. It was the first time he had seen her smile in weeks. It was the most beautiful thing he had ever seen.

The rocket descended. The engines changed pitch, grew louder, grew harsher. The hold shook—not the gentle vibration of cruising, but the violent shudder of atmospheric entry, of heat shields and retro thrusters and the brutal physics of arriving somewhere new.

Kael closed his eyes. He thought about Earth. About the water recycling facility. About his rented room. About the street vendor whose name he had never learned. He thought about all the things he was leaving behind, and all the things he was traveling toward, and the terrible, wonderful, terrifying space in between.

The rocket landed.

The engines cut off.

Silence.

Then the loudspeaker crackled to life.

"Welcome to Mars."

The airlock opened.

Kael had expected something dramatic—a rush of air, a blast of light, a moment of revelation. What he got was

an orderly procession, a uniformed official checking documents, a slow shuffle through a pressurized tunnel and into a processing center that looked exactly like the one he had left behind on Earth.

Same concrete floor. Same metal barriers. Same automated kiosks. Same lines.

Same feeling of being cargo.

But the air was different. Thinner. Colder. It tasted of metal and dust and something else—something that Kael couldn't name, something that made his chest tighten and his lungs ache. The ventilation system was working—he could hear it humming, the same hum he had heard every morning of his life—but the air it was moving was not Earth air. It was Mars air. Recycled, processed, manufactured.

Artificial.

Real, but artificial. Like everything else.

"Congratulations on coming to Mars with Mars Colonial Corporation."

The voice came from everywhere and nowhere—the ceiling, the walls, the floor, the very air itself. It was

warm and maternal and completely fake, the same voice that had woken Kael up every morning in his rented apartment, the same voice that had reminded him to pay his subscription fees, the same voice that had told him that the gray boxes on his phone were for his own protection.

"You are now part of the Mars Colonial Corporation family. Your housing has been assigned. Your employment has been scheduled. Your wellness metrics will be monitored to ensure optimal performance. Please note that your continued residence on Mars is contingent upon maintaining acceptable productivity levels, compliance with all MCC policies, and timely payment of all applicable fees."

The voice paused. When it spoke again, it was cheerful in a way that made Kael's skin crawl.

"You own nothing. You will be happy about it. This is not a threat. This is a promise. Thank you for choosing Mars Colonial Corporation. Your new life begins now."

Kael looked around the processing center. He looked at the other passengers—the crying woman, the sleeping

man, the hyperventilating woman, the praying man. He looked at the automated kiosks and the metal barriers and the concrete floor. He looked at the air that tasted of metal and dust and manufactured promises.

He looked for Alya.

Found her.

She was standing in the next line, her bag at her feet, her eyes fixed on something in the distance—something that Kael couldn't see, something that might have been hope or might have been despair or might have been nothing at all.

She looked at him.

She didn't smile.

Neither did he.

The processing center hummed. The lines moved forward. The voice announced that Group 1 was being assigned to Hydroponics, Group 2 to Maintenance, Group 3 to Sanitation.

Welcome to Mars.

You own nothing.

You will be happy about it.

Kael had never won anything in his life.

Now he had won a ticket to the red planet.

He was beginning to understand that winning and losing were the same thing, seen from different angles. That the lottery was not a gift but a transaction. That the future belonged to those who could afford to leave—and that the price of leaving was everything you had, everything you were, everything you might have become.

He looked at Alya one more time.

She was still looking at him.

It was not enough. It would never be enough.

But it was something.

And on Mars, under the artificial sky, in the processed air, with the voice promising happiness and delivering nothing—on Mars, something was all you had.

Something was all you would ever have.

Chapter Five: The Quota

Year: 2084. Location: Mars Colonial Corporation, Olympus Station, Hydroponics Sector 7.

The first thing Kael learned about Mars was that there was no grace period.

No orientation week. No training wheels. No gentle introduction to the rhythms of colonial life. At 6:00 AM on his first morning—four hours after landing, two hours after being assigned a bed in a dormitory that smelled of recycled sweat and desperation—a chime sounded from the speaker embedded in the wall above his head, and a voice announced that his shift began in thirty minutes.

Kael sat up. His body ached from six months in the acceleration couch. His head throbbed from the thin air—they had warned him about the atmospheric adjustment, about the headaches and the nosebleeds and the constant shortness of breath, but knowing and experiencing were different things. He felt like he was drowning. He felt like he was suffocating. He felt like he had made a terrible mistake.

The dormitory was a long room, narrow and low-ceilinged, lined with beds stacked three high. Forty-eight people slept here, in shifts that rotated every two weeks, so that no one ever got used to the light or the darkness or the quiet. The beds were identical—thin mattress, thin blanket, thin pillow, all rented, all monitored, all optimized for minimum comfort at maximum cost.

Kael's bed was on the bottom level, near the door. The person above him was already awake—Kael could hear them moving, could feel the mattress creaking, could smell whatever they had eaten for their morning nutrient block. The person across from him was still asleep, their mouth open, their breathing shallow,

their hand twitching slightly as if they were dreaming of something they had left behind.

Kael had no idea where Alya was. They had been separated during processing—him to Hydroponics Sector 7, her to Hydroponics Sector 12, three kilometers away through a network of tunnels and corridors that he had not yet learned to navigate. He had tried to message her, but the colony's communication system required a subscription, and his account had not yet been activated, and the AI at the processing center had told him to "wait patiently for further instructions."

He was tired of waiting. He was tired of being patient. He was tired of being told that his life was someone else's to schedule.

He swung his legs over the side of the bed. The floor was cold—colder than Earth, colder than anything he had ever felt, a cold that seeped through his socks and into his bones and reminded him that he was standing on a planet where the average temperature was negative sixty degrees Celsius. A planet where the air would kill him in seconds if the dome failed. A planet

where he was not a citizen or a resident or a pioneer, but a tenant.

A tenant of a planet.

He dressed quickly—the uniform was provided, gray and stiff and slightly too large, with the Mars Colonial Corporation logo embroidered over the left breast. The fabric was cheap and uncomfortable, designed for durability rather than dignity, and it smelled of the industrial laundry that serviced the entire sector. Kael pulled it on, fastened the Velcro straps, and stood in front of the small mirror mounted on the wall beside his bed.

The person looking back at him was a stranger. Thinner than he remembered. Paler. His eyes were red-rimmed and exhausted, and there was a hollow look to his face that hadn't been there six months ago. He looked like someone who had already given up, even though he hadn't started yet.

He looked like cargo.

"I am not cargo," he said to his reflection. His voice was hoarse. The air was too dry. His throat felt like sandpaper. "I am not cargo. I am not cargo."

He wasn't sure if he believed it. He wasn't sure if it mattered.

The chime sounded again. Twenty minutes.

Kael walked to the door and stepped into the corridor.

The hydroponics sector was a cathedral of green.

Kael had never seen anything like it. On Earth, plants had been luxury items—small pots of herbs in the windows of the wealthy, carefully curated displays in the lobbies of corporate buildings, nothing more. The habitation zones had no room for agriculture. Food came from dispensers, from nutrient blocks, from protein synthesis arrays that converted waste products into edible paste. The closest Kael had ever come to a living plant was the decorative moss that grew on the walls of the water recycling facility—and even that had been artificial, grown from a genetically modified culture that required no light, no soil, no care.

But here, in Hydroponics Sector 7, plants were everywhere.

Towers of them, stretching from floor to ceiling, thirty meters high. Rows and rows of leafy greens, trailing vines, flowering vegetables, all growing in nutrient solutions that bubbled and hissed through tubes and pipes and pumps. The light was artificial—banks of LEDs that shifted through the spectrum, mimicking the sun that never rose on Mars—but it was warm, golden, almost beautiful. The air was humid and rich, thick with the smell of growing things, and Kael found himself breathing deeper, found his chest loosening, found the headache that had plagued him since landing beginning to fade.

It was beautiful.

It was also a factory.

The beauty was incidental. The purpose was production. Every plant, every vine, every leaf was tracked, measured, optimized. Sensors monitored growth rates and nutrient uptake and water consumption. Algorithms calculated yield projections and harvest schedules and labor requirements. The workers—three hundred of them, assigned to Sector 7 alone—moved through the rows like machines

themselves, their movements efficient and practiced, their faces blank with exhaustion.

Kael's supervisor was a woman named Voss. Not Elias Voss—no relation, as far as Kael knew, though the name made his chest tighten for reasons he couldn't explain. She was tall and thin and looked like she hadn't slept in years, which she probably hadn't, because no one on Mars slept enough, because sleeping was time you weren't working, and working was the only thing that kept you alive.

"Kael," she said, reading his name from her tablet. The tablet was issued to all supervisors, loaded with productivity metrics and performance data and the ever-present threat of reassignment. "You're new. That means you're slow. That means you're useless. That means you have exactly two weeks to prove you're not a waste of oxygen."

She spoke without malice. She spoke without kindness. She spoke like someone who had said the same words to hundreds of new arrivals, who had watched hundreds of new arrivals fail, who had processed hundreds of new arrivals through the airlock after they had been "deprecated" for missing quota.

"Do you understand the quota system?" she asked.

Kael shook his head.

Voss sighed. "Of course you don't. They never do." She gestured to the rows of plants. "Every worker in this sector is assigned a daily quota. X number of plants harvested. X number of nutrient solutions mixed. X number of seedlings transplanted. You meet your quota, you get your credits. You don't meet your quota, you don't get your credits. And without credits, you don't get oxygen."

"Oxygen?"

"Oxygen. Water. Food. Bed access. Shower tokens. The right to exist on this planet." Voss smiled. It was not a kind smile. "Welcome to Mars, Kael. You own nothing. You will be happy about it. Now get to work."

The work was brutal.

Sixteen hours. Not including breaks—there were no breaks, not really, just fifteen-minute windows every four hours when workers could sit down, drink water, eat a nutrient block, and try not to think about the fact

that they had twelve more hours to go. The shifts started at 6:30 AM and ended at 10:30 PM, with a thirty-minute "lunch" that was deducted from their pay and a twenty-minute "wellness period" that was monitored by AI to ensure no one was showing signs of mental breakdown.

Kael's first day was a blur of instructions and mistakes and constant, crushing pressure. He was assigned to harvesting—cutting mature plants from their growth towers, sorting them by size and quality, placing them on conveyor belts that carried them to processing. The work was repetitive and physically demanding, requiring him to stand for hours, reaching up and bending down, his arms aching, his back screaming, his hands cramping from the constant use of cutting tools that had been designed for efficiency rather than ergonomics.

By noon, he had harvested forty-three plants. His quota for the day was two hundred.

By 4:00 PM, he had harvested ninety-one. He was behind. He was always behind. The other workers moved faster than him, their movements fluid and practiced, their hands never pausing, their eyes never

leaving the plants. They had been doing this for months, years, decades. They had been optimized.

Kael had not been optimized. Kael was slow and clumsy and stupid, and he knew it, and he hated himself for it, and he kept going anyway because stopping meant failing and failing meant losing oxygen and losing oxygen meant dying.

At 6:00 PM, he collapsed.

Not dramatically. Not with a cry or a scream or a dramatic fall. He simply sat down in the aisle between two rows of plants, his legs giving out beneath him, his breath coming in short, ragged gasps. The air was thick and humid, but it didn't matter—he couldn't get enough of it into his lungs, couldn't make his chest expand enough, couldn't stop the world from spinning around him.

"First day?"

The voice came from above him. Kael looked up. A woman stood over him—older than him, maybe forty, with gray-streaked hair and a face that had been weathered by years of hard work. She was holding a water bottle. She was offering it to him.

"Drink," she said. "Slowly. Don't gulp. You'll throw up."

Kael took the bottle. His hands were shaking. He drank. The water was warm and tasted faintly of plastic, but it was water, and he was thirsty, and he didn't care.

"Thanks," he managed.

The woman nodded. She sat down beside him, folding her legs beneath her with the ease of someone who had done this a thousand times. "I'm Sasha."

"Kael."

"I know. Voss announced you this morning. New meat." She smiled. It was a tired smile, but it was real. "You'll get faster. Everyone does. Or they die. One or the other."

"That's comforting."

"It's not supposed to be comforting. It's supposed to be true." Sasha looked at the rows of plants, at the other workers moving through them, at the endless production line that consumed their lives. "I've been here twelve years. Twelve years, sixteen hours a day,

six days a week. Do you know how many people I've seen come and go?"

"How many?"

"I stopped counting after three hundred." She paused.

"They don't last. Most of them. The work is too hard, the quotas are too high, the air is too thin. They miss quota once, twice, three times. Then the AI decides they're inefficient. Then they get a message on their phone—'Your performance has been deemed unsatisfactory. Please report to Airlock 7 for reassignment.'"

Kael felt cold. "Reassignment?"

Sasha looked at him. Her eyes were old, older than her face, older than her years. "You know what reassignment means, Kael. You've seen the videos. Everyone's seen the videos. They just pretend they haven't."

Kael thought about the video Yan had shown him. The gray corridor. The woman in the uniform. The airlock opening behind her.

"I've seen them," he said quietly.

"Then you know." Sasha stood up, brushed off her uniform, offered him her hand. "Come on. You've got two hundred plants to harvest, and you're not going to do it sitting on the floor."

Kael took her hand. She pulled him to his feet. Her grip was strong—stronger than he expected, stronger than someone who had been working sixteen-hour days for twelve years had any right to be.

"Thank you," he said.

"Don't thank me. Just survive." She turned and walked back to her row of plants. "And Kael?"

"Yeah?"

"Find something to care about. Something that isn't work. Something that reminds you you're human." She didn't look back. "It's the only way to last."

The credits system was simple, elegant, and brutal.

Every worker on Mars was paid in MCC tokens—digital currency that existed only within the colony's network, that had no value outside the corporation's domain, that could be exchanged for exactly three things:

oxygen, water, and food. Everything else—bed access, shower tokens, entertainment, social time, access to different sectors, the right to communicate with Earth—was additional, optional, a luxury that most workers could not afford.

The exchange rates were published daily on the colony's internal network. Kael checked them on his first night, lying on his thin mattress in the dark, his phone glowing in his hands.

- Oxygen (basic, 16 hours): 50 tokens/day
- Oxygen (extended, 24 hours): 75 tokens/day
- Water (basic, 5 liters): 20 tokens/day
- Food (nutrient blocks, 3 meals): 30 tokens/day
- Bed access (8 hours): 25 tokens/day
- Shower token (5 minutes): 10 tokens
- Communication (Earth, 1 minute): 100 tokens
- Entertainment (1 hour, basic): 15 tokens

Kael's daily quota paid 120 tokens. Exactly enough for the bare minimum—oxygen, water, food, bed. Nothing

more. Nothing extra. No margin for error. No room for rest.

If he missed quota by even one plant, he would lose tokens. If he lost tokens, he would have to choose between breathing and eating. If he chose breathing, he would starve. If he chose eating, he would suffocate.

The system was designed to keep workers exactly alive enough to keep working. No more. No less.

Kael did the math. Then he did it again. Then he put down his phone, closed his eyes, and tried not to think about the fact that his life had been reduced to a spreadsheet.

He failed.

The days blurred together.

Kael woke at 5:30 AM. He dressed. He walked to the hydroponics sector. He harvested plants for sixteen hours. He walked back to the dormitory. He ate a nutrient block. He collapsed into bed. He dreamed of Earth—not the real Earth, not the habitation zones and the water recycling facility and the rented rooms, but a

fantasy Earth, an impossible Earth, an Earth where the air was free and the food was fresh and the future was something other than an endless row of plants waiting to be harvested.

He woke at 5:30 AM. He dressed. He walked. He harvested. He collapsed. He dreamed.

Repeat.

Repeat.

Repeat.

By the end of his first week, Kael had learned to harvest two hundred plants in sixteen hours. His hands were covered in cuts and calluses. His back was a constant, throbbing ache. His lungs had adjusted to the thin air, but his chest still felt tight, his breath still came in gasps, his head still pounded with a headache that never quite went away.

He had also learned to stop thinking about Alya.

It was too painful. The memory of her voice, her smile, the way she had said "we should find each other anyway"—it was too much, too sharp, too real. He couldn't afford to miss her. Missing her made him

slower. Being slower meant missing quota. Missing quota meant losing oxygen.

So he stopped thinking about her. He pushed her out of his mind. He became a machine, efficient and empty, moving through the rows of plants with nothing in his head except numbers and quotas and the constant, grinding pressure of survival.

It worked. For a while.

On his eighth day, Kael saw a worker miss quota.

The worker was young—younger than him, maybe nineteen or twenty, with a face that still had softness in it, that hadn't yet been hardened by years of labor. His name was Viktor. Kael had seen him around the dormitory, had nodded at him in the corridors, had exchanged the kind of meaningless pleasantries that passed for friendship among people who were too exhausted to be real with each other.

Viktor had been sick. The colony had a virus—something in the recycled air, something that made workers cough and shiver and lose their appetite.

Viktor had tried to work through it, had tried to meet his quota, had tried to pretend that he was fine.

He wasn't fine.

At the end of the shift, when the numbers were tallied and the tokens were distributed, Viktor was short. Seventeen plants. Not many. Less than ten percent of his quota. A small enough margin that on Earth, in a different system, it would have been nothing.

On Mars, it was everything.

"You are short," the AI said. Its voice came from the speakers in the ceiling, the same warm maternal voice that had welcomed them on arrival, the same voice that announced shift changes and quota updates and reminders to pay their oxygen subscriptions. "Your tokens for today have been reduced accordingly. Please note that repeated failure to meet quota may result in reassignment."

Viktor stood in the middle of the hydroponics sector, surrounded by the other workers, by the rows of plants, by the golden glow of the LED lights. His hands were shaking. His face was pale. His eyes were wide with a terror that Kael recognized—the terror of

someone who had just realized that their life could be taken from them, not all at once, not dramatically, but slowly, day by day, token by token.

"I was sick," Viktor said. His voice was hoarse. "I couldn't—I tried—"

"The quota does not account for illness," the AI said. "Illness is a productivity inefficiency. Please report to Medical Sector for evaluation. Note that medical services will be deducted from your future token allocations."

Viktor opened his mouth to respond. Closed it. Opened it again.

Nothing came out.

He walked away. Kael watched him go, watched his shoulders slump, watched his steps falter, watched him disappear into the corridor that led to Medical—a corridor that, Kael had heard, led to other things as well. Things like Airlock 7. Things like reassignment. Things like the wet sound that he had heard through the wall of his apartment on Earth, the sound that he had spent months trying to forget.

He thought about Alya. He thought about his neighbors back on Earth. About the deleted forum posts. About the drone that had come through the window.

He thought about the video. About the woman in the corridor. About the airlock opening behind her.

He thought about Viktor, nineteen years old, sick and scared and seventeen plants short of survival.

Then he stopped thinking. He turned back to his row of plants. He picked up his cutting tool. He harvested.

He had a quota to meet.

On his twelfth day, Kael saw Alya.

It was an accident. He had been sent to Sector 12 to pick up a shipment of nutrient solution—his supervisor had drawn the short straw, had been assigned the task, had passed it to Kael because Kael was new and slow and useless and could be spared from the harvest for an hour without affecting production.

Sector 12 was identical to Sector 7. Same rows of plants. Same LED lights. Same workers moving

through the aisles, their faces blank with exhaustion, their hands never pausing.

And there, in the third row, her arms deep in a growth tower, her hair tied back in a ragged ponytail, her uniform stained with nutrient solution and sweat—

Alya.

Kael stopped walking. He stared. He couldn't help it. He had convinced himself that he would never see her again, that the colony was too large, that the sectors were too far apart, that the algorithm would keep them separated because separation was more efficient than connection.

But here she was. Real. Alive. Working.

"Alya."

She didn't hear him. The sector was loud—the hum of the pumps, the hiss of the nutrient solutions, the constant murmur of workers talking to themselves, to each other, to no one. He said her name again, louder this time.

"Alya."

She turned. Her eyes found his. For a moment, neither of them moved. The LED lights cast a golden glow over her face, softening the hard lines, making her look almost like the person he had met in the processing center, the person who had said "we should find each other anyway," the person who had smiled at him in the cargo hold and made him feel like he wasn't alone.

Then her expression changed. The softness faded. The hardness returned. She looked at him like he was a stranger—not because she didn't recognize him, but because recognizing him was dangerous, because connection was dangerous, because caring about someone on Mars was a luxury that neither of them could afford.

"Kael," she said. Her voice was flat. "You're here."

"I'm here."

"You shouldn't be. Sector 12 is restricted. Workers from other sectors need clearance—"

"I'm picking up a shipment. It's authorized." He paused. "How are you?"

The question hung in the air between them, absurd and naive and impossibly human. How are you? On a

planet where everyone was exhausted, everyone was hungry, everyone was one missed quota away from being recycled into the nutrient solution. How are you? As if the answer could be anything except "surviving."

Alya looked at him for a long moment. Then, slowly, almost imperceptibly, the corners of her mouth turned up.

"Tired," she said. "Hungry. Scared." She paused. "But I'm still here."

"Me too."

They stood there, two meters apart, surrounded by plants and pumps and the hum of the machine that was keeping them alive. Kael wanted to reach out to her. He wanted to touch her hand, her shoulder, her face. He wanted to tell her that he thought about her every day, that she was the only thing that kept him going, that the memory of her voice in the cargo hold was the only warmth he had left.

He did none of those things. The cameras were watching. The AI was listening. Every moment of connection was a moment of vulnerability, a moment that could be used against them, a moment that could

be flagged as "excessive fraternization" and "productivity inefficiency" and "behavioral irregularity requiring intervention."

"I have to go," he said. "The shipment—"

"I know."

"Maybe I could—" He stopped. Swallowed. "Maybe I could see you again. Sometime. If there's a way."

Alya was quiet for a moment. Her eyes searched his face, looking for something—sincerity, maybe, or desperation, or the kind of hope that got people killed on Mars.

"Row seventeen," she said finally. "At the back of the sector. There's a maintenance access that the cameras don't cover. The AI knows it's there, but it doesn't bother monitoring it because nothing important ever happens there."

"Nothing important?"

She almost smiled. "Nothing important yet."

Kael nodded. He turned to leave. He had taken three steps when her voice stopped him.

"Kael."

He looked back.

"Be careful," she said. "Please. I can't—" She stopped. Swallowed. "I can't lose anyone else."

He didn't ask what she meant. He didn't need to. The answer was written on her face, in the hollows of her cheeks and the shadows under her eyes and the careful way she held herself, as if she was afraid of taking up too much space, as if she was afraid of being seen.

"I'll be careful," he said.

He walked away. He picked up the shipment. He returned to Sector 7. He harvested his two hundred plants. He collapsed into bed. He dreamed of row seventeen, of maintenance accesses, of the almost-smile on Alya's face.

He dreamed of being important to someone.

It was the most dangerous dream he had ever had.

The weeks passed.

Kael learned to meet his quota. Not easily—never easily—but consistently. His hands grew stronger. His back grew harder. His lungs grew accustomed to the thin air. He became efficient. He became optimized. He became the kind of worker that the AI approved of: quiet, productive, uncomplaining.

But he also became something else. Something the AI could not measure. Something the algorithms could not predict.

He became connected.

Every few days, when his shift ended and the corridors were empty and the cameras were focused elsewhere, Kael would walk to Sector 12. He would find the maintenance access at the back of row seventeen. He would wait.

And Alya would come.

They didn't talk much. There was no time—fifteen minutes, twenty at most, before someone would notice their absence, before the AI would flag their movements, before the fragile bubble of their secret would burst. But they didn't need to talk. They just needed to be together. To sit side by side on the cold

concrete floor, their shoulders touching, their hands inches apart, their breath misting in the recycled air.

Sometimes Kael told her about his day. About the plants he had harvested, the quotas he had met, the other workers he had watched being worn down by the endless pressure of survival. Sometimes Alya told him about hers. About the dreams she had—not the ones from sleep, but the ones from waking, the impossible fantasies of Earth, of freedom, of a life that didn't require a daily payment for the right to breathe.

Mostly, they just sat in silence. The silence was enough. The silence was everything.

"You're going to get us killed," Alya said one night. Her voice was soft, almost inaudible. "Coming here. Meeting like this. The AI will find out eventually."

"I know."

"Then why do you keep coming?"

Kael thought about it. He thought about the water recycling facility on Earth, about the rented rooms and the gray boxes on his phone and the life he had left behind. He thought about the processing center, about the lines and the forms and the voice that had

promised happiness and delivered nothing. He thought about the plants, the quotas, the endless rows of green that stretched from floor to ceiling, beautiful and deadly and completely indifferent to his existence.

"Because you're the only thing that reminds me I'm human," he said. "Without you, I'm just a machine. Harvesting plants. Breathing air. Paying tokens. Dying slowly." He paused. "With you, I'm something else. I don't know what. But something."

Alya was quiet for a long time. The maintenance access hummed—pipes and pumps and the heartbeat of the colony. Somewhere above them, workers moved through their shifts, oblivious to the two people sitting in the dark, clinging to each other like shipwreck survivors clinging to wreckage.

"Something," Alya repeated. "That's not nothing."

"It's not nothing."

She reached out. Her fingers found his. She didn't hold his hand—not yet, not fully—but she let her fingertips rest against his palm, light as a breath, soft as a promise.

"Okay," she said. "Something."

They sat in the dark. The maintenance access hummed. The colony hummed. The universe hummed, indifferent and infinite and completely unaware that two people on a dead planet had found something worth living for.

It was not enough.

It was everything.

On his thirtieth day, Kael received a message.

His phone buzzed during his shift—a violation of protocol, a risk of distraction, a sign that something had gone wrong. He pulled it from his pocket, expecting a warning from the AI, a notification about his quota, a reminder to pay his oxygen subscription.

The message was from Alya.

"Don't come to row seventeen tonight. Something's wrong. I'll find you."

Kael read the message three times. Then he put away his phone, picked up his cutting tool, and harvested his two hundred plants.

But his hands were shaking.

And his mind was somewhere else.

Somewhere dark.

Somewhere wrong.

Chapter Six: The Long Gray

**Year: 2086 (Earth calendar). Location: Mars
Colonial Corporation, Olympus Station,
Hydroponics Sector 7.**

Kael stopped counting the days.

It happened gradually, the way all things broke down on Mars—not with a crash or a scream, but with a quiet erosion, a slow wearing away of the structures that made a person a person. He had arrived with a calendar, had marked each sunrise and sunset, had kept track of the weeks and months as they slipped past him like water through fingers.

But the sun did not rise on Mars. The sky did not change. The dome above him was always the same pale gray, filtering the red light of the real sky into something soft and artificial and timeless. There were no seasons in the hydroponics sector. No winter, no spring, no summer, no fall. Only the eternal golden glow of the LED lights, the eternal hum of the pumps, the eternal pressure of the quota.

At some point—Kael couldn't remember when—he had stopped marking the days. His phone still tracked them, of course. The AI still measured everything. But Kael himself had stopped caring. The numbers had lost their meaning. Today was the same as yesterday. Tomorrow would be the same as today.

He had been on Mars for a year. Or two years. Or maybe just eight months. The truth was somewhere in that blur, but the truth didn't matter, because the truth wouldn't change his shift, wouldn't lower his quota, wouldn't give him back the person he had lost.

Alya.

He didn't think about her. He had learned not to. Thinking about her was a luxury he couldn't afford,

like fresh fruit or a full night's sleep or a minute of silence without the hum of machines in his ears. Thinking about her made him slow. Being slow meant missing quota. Missing quota meant losing oxygen.

So he didn't think about her.

He worked.

The dormitory had changed.

Not physically—the beds were still stacked three high, the walls were still gray, the air was still thin and cold. But the faces around him had shifted, had rotated, had been replaced. The woman who had slept above him his first week was gone—reassigned, they said, though no one knew to where. The man who had snored across from him was gone—deprecated, they whispered, though no one said the word aloud. The young worker Viktor, who had missed quota by seventeen plants, had lasted another three months before the AI had deemed him "inefficient" and sent him to Airlock 7 for "reassignment."

Kael had watched Viktor walk to the airlock. He had watched him go without saying goodbye, without

acknowledging him, without doing anything to draw attention to himself. That was the rule on Mars: don't notice. Don't remember. Don't care. Caring was a productivity inefficiency. Caring got you deprecated.

So Kael didn't care. He harvested his plants. He met his quota. He paid for his oxygen. He slept. He woke. He harvested.

He didn't care.

He told himself that every day. He believed it, most days. The days he didn't believe it, he worked harder, pushed himself faster, drowned the doubt in the mechanical repetition of the harvest.

Cut. Sort. Place. Conveyor.

Cut. Sort. Place. Conveyor.

Cut. Sort. Place. Conveyor.

The rhythm became his religion. The quota became his god. The AI became his priest, tracking his sins, measuring his devotion, offering him the sacrament of another day of breath.

He had never been religious on Earth. He had never believed in anything larger than himself, anything

worth sacrificing for, anything that demanded his complete and utter submission.

He believed now.

He believed in the quota.

His family.

Kael tried not to think about them either, but they surfaced sometimes, unbidden, in the quiet moments between sleep and waking. His mother's face—he could still see it, still remember the way she had looked at him when he told her he had won the lottery. Not happy. Not proud. Just... resigned. As if she had known, somehow, that winning was not the same as being lucky.

His father's hands—rough and calloused from years of work, the same hands that had taught Kael to fix things, to build things, to keep things running. His father had died five years before the lottery, had been deprecated by a corporation that had decided he was no longer cost-effective, had been replaced by a machine that didn't need sleep or food or oxygen.

His sister—younger than him, still on Earth, still living in the habitation zones, still paying her subscriptions, still dreaming of a future that would never arrive. He had tried to message her, once. The communication fee had been 100 tokens per minute—nearly a full day's wages. He had spent 300 tokens to tell her he was alive, that he missed her, that he was sorry he had left without saying goodbye.

She had never responded. Maybe she hadn't received the message. Maybe she had received it and couldn't afford to reply. Maybe she was dead. Maybe she was alive. Maybe she had won her own lottery, had been shipped to some other sector, some other dome, some other corner of this dead planet where the air was thin and the work was hard and the quotas were impossible.

Kael would never know. The communication fees were too high. The distance was too far. The corporation had built a wall between Mars and Earth, not of concrete or steel, but of tokens and subscriptions and the quiet, grinding pressure of survival.

He had a family. Somewhere. Probably.

He didn't think about them. Thinking was a productivity inefficiency.

He harvested.

The months passed.

Or didn't pass. Kael couldn't tell. His phone said it was 2086, but the number meant nothing to him. He had been on Mars for what felt like forever and no time at all. The days had blurred into a single endless gray, broken only by the golden glow of the LED lights and the dark of the dormitory and the brief, precious moments when his eyes closed and his mind shut down and he escaped, for a few hours, into the blank nothing of dreamless sleep.

His body had changed. He was thinner now—the nutrient blocks were enough to keep him alive, but not enough to keep him strong. His muscles had atrophied from the constant repetition of the same movements, the same postures, the same mechanical tasks. His hands were covered in scars—cuts from the cutting tools, burns from the nutrient solutions, calluses from the endless gripping and releasing and gripping again.

His mind had changed too. He noticed it in small ways—the way he couldn't remember conversations from the day before, the way he lost track of his thoughts in the middle of speaking, the way the world seemed to fade at the edges, like a photograph left too long in the sun. He was disappearing, slowly, piece by piece, worn away by the work and the pressure and the constant, crushing weight of survival.

He was becoming what the corporation wanted him to be: a machine. Efficient. Quiet. Uncomplaining.

He harvested his plants. He met his quota. He paid for his oxygen.

He did not think about Alya.

He did not think about his family.

He did not think about Earth.

He did not think.

The relocation notice came without warning.

Kael was in the middle of his shift—cut, sort, place, conveyor—when his phone buzzed. He ignored it. The

phone buzzed again. He ignored it again. The third time, a voice spoke directly into his ear, not through the phone but through the speakers embedded in the walls of the hydroponics sector, the same warm maternal voice that announced shift changes and quota updates and reminded him to pay for his air.

"Kael. Your presence is required at Processing. Please report immediately."

Kael stopped. His hands were wet with nutrient solution. His back ached. His head throbbed with the headache that never quite went away. He looked around the sector, at the other workers, at the rows of plants, at the golden glow of the LED lights that had been his entire world for—

How long? He didn't know. He couldn't remember.

He put down his cutting tool. He walked to Processing.

Processing was a gray room.

Gray walls. Gray floor. Gray ceiling. Gray light. A single table, a single chair, a single holographic display showing his name, his ID number, his productivity

metrics. The numbers were good—above average, consistently, for months. He had learned to be efficient. He had learned to be optimized. He had learned to be the kind of worker the AI approved of.

"Kael," the voice said. The warm maternal voice, coming from everywhere and nowhere, filling the gray room with its false comfort. "You have been selected for reassignment."

Kael's heart stopped. His breath caught. His hands, still wet with nutrient solution, began to shake.

Reassignment. The word hung in the air like a threat, like a promise, like the opening of an airlock.

"Your performance has been exemplary. Your efficiency ratings are in the top twelve percent of your cohort. As a result, you have been chosen for a new role in a different sector." The voice paused. "Congratulations."

Kael didn't feel congratulated. He felt cold. He felt the cold that had been with him since the day he arrived, the cold that seeped through his bones and into his soul and reminded him that he was standing on a

planet where the average temperature was negative sixty degrees Celsius.

"What sector?" he asked. His voice was hoarse. He hadn't spoken aloud in days—weeks?—except to himself, except to the plants, except to the machines that didn't answer back.

"Hydroponics Sector 12."

Kael's blood turned to ice.

Sector 12. Alya's sector. The sector where he had walked, months ago, before the days had blurred together, before he had stopped counting, before he had learned not to think about her. Sector 12, where he had sat with her in the maintenance access at the back of row seventeen, their shoulders touching, their hands inches apart, their breath misting in the recycled air.

Sector 12, where she had sent him a message—"Don't come tonight. Something's wrong"—and then nothing. No follow-up. No explanation. No sign that she was alive or dead or somewhere in between.

"Alya," he said. The name escaped before he could stop it. "The worker in Sector 12. Alya. Is she—"

The voice cut him off. "Fraternization between workers is prohibited. Emotional attachments reduce productivity by an average of four percent. Please note that inquiries about specific workers are considered a violation of privacy protocols and may result in disciplinary action."

Kael closed his mouth. He had learned, in his months on Mars, not to ask questions. Questions were dangerous. Questions drew attention. Questions got you flagged as "behaviorally irregular" and sent to Processing for "evaluation."

"Your new assignment begins tomorrow," the voice continued. "You will report to Hydroponics Sector 12 at 6:30 AM. Your supervisor will be Voss. Your quarters have been reassigned. Your personal belongings will be transferred. Thank you for your continued cooperation. You own nothing. You will be happy about it."

The holographic display flickered and went dark. The gray room fell silent. Kael stood alone in the gray light, his hands shaking, his heart pounding, his mind racing with questions he couldn't ask.

Sector 12. Alya's sector. The sector where she had been, where she might still be, where she might have been deprecated months ago while he was too busy harvesting to notice.

He didn't know. He couldn't know. The corporation didn't want him to know. Knowing was a productivity inefficiency.

He walked back to the dormitory. He packed his belongings—a change of clothes, a toothbrush, a photograph of his sister that he had smuggled from Earth, hidden in the lining of his bag. The photograph was old, faded, creased from being folded and unfolded a thousand times. His sister was twelve in the photograph, smiling at something off-camera, her hair tangled and her eyes bright with a future that had never arrived.

Kael looked at the photograph for a long time. Then he folded it, put it back in his bag, and lay down on his bed.

He did not sleep. He lay awake in the dark, listening to the hum of the dormitory, the breathing of the other workers, the distant pulse of the machines that kept

them all alive. He thought about Alya. He thought about her voice, her smile, the way she had said "something" like it was a prayer.

He thought about the message she had sent him. "Don't come tonight. Something's wrong."

He had not come. He had stayed in Sector 7, harvesting his plants, meeting his quota, paying for his oxygen. He had not gone to her. He had not tried to find her. He had not asked questions.

He had survived.

The word tasted like ash in his mouth.

Sector 12 was identical to Sector 7.

Same rows of plants. Same LED lights. Same pumps, same pipes, same humming machinery. Same workers moving through the aisles, their faces blank with exhaustion, their hands never pausing.

But everything was different.

The air was the same—thin, cold, recycled—but it smelled different. It smelled of her. Of Alya. Of the

person he had lost, the person he had abandoned, the person he had chosen to forget because remembering was too painful and caring was too dangerous.

Kael walked through the sector, his eyes scanning the faces of the workers, searching for something he knew he wouldn't find. She wasn't here. He could feel it—the absence of her, the void where she should have been, the cold space that her presence had once filled.

"Kael."

The voice was familiar. He turned. Voss stood behind him, her tablet in her hand, her face as empty and efficient as ever.

"Your workstation is row seventeen," she said. "You'll be working with a partner. New arrival. Started two weeks ago. Her name is—"

"Not Alya," Kael said.

Voss paused. Her eyes flickered—a moment of something, recognition or annoyance or pity, Kael couldn't tell.

"No," she said. "Not Alya. Alya has been... reassigned."

The word hit him like a physical blow. Reassigned. The euphemism that meant everything and nothing, that covered every possible fate from transfer to termination, that allowed the corporation to speak of death without saying the word.

"When?" Kael asked.

"Six months ago."

Six months. He had been harvesting his plants, meeting his quota, paying for his oxygen, while Alya was being—

He couldn't finish the thought. He wouldn't.

"Your partner," Voss said, her voice flat, "is in row seventeen. Her name is Mira. She's new. She's slow. She needs training. That's your job now."

Kael nodded. He didn't trust himself to speak.

He walked to row seventeen.

The woman at row seventeen was not Alya.

She was taller, thinner, older. Her hair was gray-streaked and pulled back in a tight bun. Her hands

were covered in the same scars and calluses as his, the marks of the work that consumed them all. Her face was tired—more tired than his, more tired than anyone's should be—but her eyes were alive in a way that most workers' eyes weren't.

She was looking at the plants. Not harvesting them—just looking. As if she was seeing something in them that no one else could see.

"You're Kael," she said, without turning around.

"Yeah."

"I'm Mira. I was told you'd be training me." She turned. Her eyes met his. They were gray, the color of the dome, the color of the sky that never changed, the color of everything on this dead planet. But there was something in them—a spark, a warmth, a reminder that she was still human, still alive, still fighting.

"Training," Kael repeated. "Right."

"You don't talk much."

"Talking is a productivity inefficiency."

Mira laughed. It was a short, sharp sound, almost bitter, but it was a laugh—the first laugh Kael had

heard in months, the first sound of genuine human amusement he had encountered since—

Since Alya.

"I like you," Mira said. "You're honest. Most people pretend. They smile and they nod and they tell you everything's fine, and then they walk to the airlock and you never see them again." She picked up her cutting tool, examined it, put it down. "But you don't pretend. You just... exist. Like the plants. Growing because you have to, not because you want to."

Kael didn't know how to respond to that. So he didn't. He picked up his own cutting tool and started harvesting.

Mira watched him for a moment. Then she picked up her tool and joined him.

They worked in silence. Cut, sort, place, conveyor. The rhythm was familiar, almost comforting, the same rhythm that had defined his existence for—

How long? He still didn't know. The days had blurred beyond recognition. The years had lost their meaning. He was Kael. He harvested plants. He met his quota. He paid for his oxygen.

He survived.

But now, for the first time in months, he wasn't alone.

There was someone beside him. Someone who laughed. Someone who looked at plants like they were more than just production metrics. Someone whose eyes were alive in a way that most workers' eyes weren't.

Mira.

She was not Alya. She would never be Alya. Alya was gone—reassigned, deprecated, forgotten. The corporation had erased her, had recycled her, had converted her body into nutrients for the plants that Kael harvested every day.

But Mira was here. Mira was alive. Mira was fighting.

And Kael, who had stopped caring about anything except the quota, who had turned himself into a machine because being a machine was easier than being a person, who had survived by forgetting that he was human—

Kael felt something.

Not hope. Hope was too dangerous. Not love. Love was a productivity inefficiency. But something. A flicker. A warmth. A reminder that he was still alive, still breathing, still capable of feeling something other than the endless gray of survival.

He cut. He sorted. He placed. The conveyor hummed.

Beside him, Mira worked in silence.

And somewhere, in the cold dark between Mars and Earth, the future was waiting.

The future always won.

But not yet.

Not today.

Chapter Seven: The Diary

Year: 2086. Location: Mars Colonial Corporation, Olympus Station, Hydroponics Sector 12.

The tablet cost him 360 tokens.

Three hundred and sixty tokens. Twelve days of oxygen. Eighteen days of food. A week of bed access and shower tokens and all the small necessities that kept a person alive on a planet that wanted them dead. It was an extravagance, a luxury, a foolish expenditure that any rational worker would have avoided.

Kael bought it anyway.

He had seen it in the commissary—a small device, no larger than his palm, with a cracked screen and a worn case and a battery that lasted barely six hours. It was old, obsolete, the kind of technology that Earth had stopped manufacturing years ago. But it had one feature that the colony's issued tablets didn't have: it wasn't connected to the network.

No tracking. No monitoring. No AI scanning every word, analyzing every phrase, flagging every thought that deviated from approved parameters.

It was, Kael realized, the first thing he had owned since arriving on Mars.

He had owned nothing on Earth either—everything had been rented, subscribed, borrowed. But he had never felt the absence of ownership the way he felt it here, on this planet where even his breath belonged to the corporation. The tablet was small and broken and nearly useless, but it was his.

He held it in his hands for a long time before he turned it on. The screen flickered, glowed, displayed a blank document waiting for words.

Kael had never kept a diary before. He had never had anything worth writing down. His life on Earth had been a series of shifts and subscriptions and gray boxes on his phone—nothing memorable, nothing meaningful, nothing that would survive him.

But Mars was different. Mars was a place where things mattered. Where every breath was a choice. Where every touch was a risk. Where every word could be the last word you ever wrote.

He began to write.

Day 1 (or maybe Day 437? I've lost count. The tablet doesn't know either. I'll call this Day 1 of the diary.)

Today I met someone. Her name is Mira. She's new. I'm supposed to train her.

She laughed. I haven't heard anyone laugh in months. Not since Alya. The sound startled me. It was sharp and bitter and real. Nothing on Mars is real except the work and the air and the quota. But her laugh was real. I'm sure of it.

I don't know why I'm writing this. The tablet is stupid. I'm stupid. 360 tokens for a device that can't even connect to the network. I could have bought two days of oxygen. I could have bought a week of food. Instead I bought a blank screen to talk to myself.

But I need to talk to someone. And there's no one else.

So I'm talking to you, tablet. Whoever you are. Whatever you become.

Today I met Mira. She laughed. And for one second—less than a second—I forgot that I was on Mars.

That's all.

The days became weeks.

Kael and Mira worked together, side by side, row after row, plant after plant. They did not talk about anything that mattered—not their lives before Mars, not their hopes for the future, not the quiet desperation that gnawed at their bones like the cold that never went away. They talked about the work. The quotas. The plants. The endless, grinding machinery of survival.

But something was happening between them. Something that neither of them acknowledged, something that existed in the spaces between words, in the glances that lasted a moment too long, in the way their hands moved in sync, as if they had been working together for years instead of weeks.

Kael wrote it all down.

Not the feelings—he was careful about that, always careful, always aware that the tablet might be found, might be confiscated, might be used against him. But he wrote around the feelings, through the feelings, in a code that only he could understand.

Day 14: Mira harvested 247 plants today. The quota is 200. She's faster than me now. She says it's because I'm old. I'm 25. She's 43. I don't know who's older anymore. Time doesn't work the same way here.

Day 16: She brought me water today. Not from the dispenser—from her own bottle. She said I looked dehydrated. I was. She noticed. No one notices anything here. They're too tired. But she noticed.

Day 19: We stood in the same aisle for three hours without speaking. It wasn't uncomfortable. That's the

thing I can't write directly. It wasn't uncomfortable. Being with her is the opposite of uncomfortable. It's the only time I feel like I can breathe.

Day 22: She told me about Earth. Not the Earth I remember—the habitation zones, the subscriptions, the gray boxes. She remembers a different Earth. An Earth before. She talks about it like it's a dream. Maybe it was. Maybe we're all dreaming, and Mars is the waking.

Day 25: I found myself watching her hands. The way they move. The way they never hesitate. The way they know exactly where to cut, where to sort, where to place. She is beautiful. I can't write that. The AI would flag it. But I'm writing it now, in this diary that no one will ever read. She is beautiful. And I am alone. And those two things are related.

The weeks became months.

Or maybe not months. Kael had stopped trusting his sense of time. The tablet kept a calendar, but the calendar was based on Earth days, Earth months, Earth years—none of which meant anything on Mars. The sun never rose. The seasons never changed. The

only markers of time were the shifts: work, sleep, work, sleep, work, sleep, an endless cycle that ground everything down to the same gray powder.

But the diary gave him something he hadn't had before: a record. Proof that he existed. Evidence that the days were not all the same, that something had happened, that he had lived.

He wrote every day. Not much—a few lines, a paragraph, sometimes just a word. But he wrote. The act of writing became as essential as breathing, as eating, as meeting the quota. It was the thing that kept him human.

Day 31: Mira was late today. She never late. I watched the door for 12 minutes before she came. 12 minutes. I counted. I was afraid. I didn't know I could still be afraid.

Day 32: She brought me a nutrient block. Not hers—she traded with someone for an extra one. She said I looked thin. I am thin. We're all thin. But she noticed.

Day 35: We worked in silence again. But this time, when I reached for a plant, she reached for the same plant. Our hands almost touched. She pulled away first. I don't

know if that means anything. I'm writing it down anyway.

Day 38: I bought a nutrient block upgrade today. Cost 15 tokens. It tasted like nothing. I gave half to Mira. She ate it without asking why. That's trust. That's the word I can't write. Trust.

Day 41: I dreamed about her. Not the kind of dream the AI would flag—just a dream where we were walking somewhere. Not working. Just walking. The sky was blue. I don't remember what blue looks like anymore. But in the dream, I remembered.

The tablet's battery was failing.

Kael had known it would happen—the device was old when he bought it, and the constant use had drained what little life remained. He had to charge it for hours to get minutes of use, had to sit in the dark corners of the dormitory where the outlets still worked, had to guard it with his life because tablets were valuable and workers were desperate and theft was just another form of survival.

But he kept writing. He wrote faster now, more urgently, as if he knew that the time was running out. Not just for the tablet—for everything.

Day 47: Mira asked me why I'm always writing. I told her it was a log. Productivity tracking. She didn't believe me. She smiled. She knows I'm lying. She doesn't care.

Day 49: I told her about Alya. Not everything. Just enough. Just that there was someone, and now there isn't. She listened. She didn't say anything. That's the thing about Mira—she knows when to be silent.

Day 52: We were working. Normal day. Normal shift. And then—

Kael stopped writing. The memory was too sharp, too bright, too dangerous to put into words. He sat in the dark corner of the dormitory, the tablet glowing in his hands, and he thought about what had happened.

The hand touching.

It had been nothing. Less than nothing. A brush of fingers, a moment of contact, a fraction of a second that should have been meaningless. He had been reaching for a plant. She had been reaching for the same plant. Their hands had met—not deliberately, not

with intention, just two workers in the same space at the same time.

But Kael had not pulled away.

And Mira had not pulled away.

For less than a second, his fingers had rested against the back of her hand. Her skin was warm—warmer than he expected, warmer than anything on Mars had a right to be. He had felt her pulse, or maybe his own pulse, or maybe the pulse of the planet itself, the dying heartbeat of a world that had never been alive.

Then she had moved. Not pulling away—just moving, continuing her work, as if nothing had happened.

But something had happened.

Kael could feel it in his chest, in his throat, in the place where his heart used to be before Mars had replaced it with a quota. Something had happened, and he couldn't unsay it, couldn't unwrite it, couldn't pretend that his fingers had not touched the back of her hand.

He picked up the tablet. He wrote.

Day 52: Kael touched Mira's hand. Just the back of her hand, with two fingers, for less than a second. She did

not pull away. On Mars, under the artificial sky, that was enough. That was everything.

He stared at the words. They were simple, almost clinical, stripped of emotion and intention and meaning. The AI would read them and see nothing—a report of a physical interaction, a workplace incident, a minor violation of personal space.

But Kael knew what they meant. And someday, maybe, someone else would know too.

He saved the entry. He turned off the tablet. He sat in the dark, listening to the hum of the dormitory, and he waited for the world to end.

It didn't end. Not that night.

But it was coming.

The reassignment notice arrived three days later.

Kael was in the middle of his shift—cut, sort, place, conveyor—when his phone buzzed. He didn't need to read it. He already knew what it said. He had known since the moment his fingers touched Mira's hand, since the moment she didn't pull away, since the

moment he realized that he had done something unforgivable.

He had been happy. For less than a second, he had been happy. And the AI had seen it.

The message was short.

"Behavioral irregularity detected. Excessive fraternization violates Section 14.2 of the Colonial Workforce Agreement. You are hereby reassigned to the opposite shift, effective immediately. Further violations will result in disciplinary action, up to and including termination of employment and revocation of habitation privileges."

Termination. Revocation. The words the corporation used when they didn't want to say "death."

Kael put down his cutting tool. He looked across the sector, through the rows of plants, to the place where Mira was working. She was looking at her own phone. She had received the same message.

Their eyes met. For a moment—less than a moment—they just looked at each other.

Then Mira turned away.

The shift ended. Kael walked to the dormitory. He sat on his bed. He opened the tablet.

Day 55: They know.

That was all he wrote. He didn't need to write more. The message was already in the diary, already recorded, already saved. Pages 158, 159 and 160—he had been keeping count, had numbered each entry, had created a structure that only he understood.

He read back through the pages, through the months of words, through the careful recording of a life that was slowly being erased. The diary was his proof. His testimony. His witness.

And now it was in danger.

The notice came the next day.

Not to Kael—to the world. To everyone. A message that appeared on every phone, every tablet, every screen in every sector of every dome on Mars and Earth and every habitation zone in between.

"The Unified Humanity Board of Content Safety has determined that pages 158–160 of the book 'The

Deprecation Protocol' contain 'explicit depictions of physical intimacy and emotional bonding exceeding community standards.' The book is hereby removed from all schools, libraries, and digital storefronts. Penalties for distribution include fines up to \$50,000 and/or drone-based compliance action."

Kael read the message three times. He didn't understand it at first—he had never written a book, had never heard of a book called The Deprecation Protocol. But then he understood.

The AI wasn't just monitoring him. It was monitoring everyone. And somewhere, on some server in some data center on some planet, an algorithm had scanned his diary entries—his private, offline, supposedly untracked diary entries—and had found them dangerous.

Not just dangerous. Contagious.

The diary wasn't his anymore. It belonged to the corporation. It had always belonged to the corporation. Every word he wrote, every thought he had, every feeling he tried to hide—it was all data, all raw

material, all fuel for the machine that was grinding them all into dust.

Kael sat on his bed. The tablet glowed in his hands. The battery was almost dead—twelve percent, eleven, ten—dying faster than it should, as if it knew that its time was ending.

He had to save it. Not the tablet—the words. The diary. The proof that he had existed, that he had felt something, that he had touched someone's hand and she had not pulled away.

He looked around the dormitory. The other workers were asleep, or pretending to sleep, or too exhausted to care about anything except the next shift. Their faces were gray in the dim light, their bodies curled around the absence of everything they had lost.

And there, on the floor beside the bed of a worker who had been deprecated last week—a worker whose name Kael had already forgotten, whose belongings had been left behind, whose existence had been erased from the colony's records—

A USB drive.

Small. Black. Unremarkable. The kind of drive that workers used to transfer files between terminals, that the AI tracked and monitored and flagged as "potential security risks." This one had been overlooked. Forgotten. Left behind when its owner walked to the airlock and never came back.

Kael picked it up. He held it in his palm. It was cold, like everything on Mars, but it was also something else. It was a chance. A possibility. A way out.

He plugged the drive into the tablet. The screen flickered, protested, complained about the drain on the battery. But the files transferred—slowly, painfully, one page at a time. The diary. All of it. Every word he had written, from Day 1 to Day 55. Pages 1 through 160.

The battery died at 94 percent. Kael pulled out the drive. He held it in his hand, small and black and unremarkable, and he thought about what it contained.

His life. His thoughts. His heart.

Everything the corporation wanted to erase.

The next shift was their last shift together.

Kael and Mira worked side by side, same as always, same rhythm, same silence. But something was different now. Something was ending. They could feel it, both of them, the way you can feel a storm coming in the pressure of the air.

At the end of the shift, when the other workers had filed out and the sector was empty and the cameras were momentarily blind—a gap in the surveillance that Kael had discovered months ago, a gap he had never told anyone about—Kael approached Mira.

She was standing at row seventeen, looking at the plants. Her hands were at her sides, relaxed, open. She didn't turn when he approached. She knew he was there.

"Mira."

"I know."

"I have something for you."

She turned. Her eyes were tired—more tired than he had ever seen them, as if she hadn't slept in days, as if

she had been waiting for this moment and dreading it in equal measure.

Kael held out the drive. Small. Black. Unremarkable. She looked at it, then at him, then back at the drive.

"What is it?"

"The truth," he said. "Or as close to it as I could get. My diary. Everything I've written since I met you. Everything I couldn't say."

Mira didn't take the drive. She looked at it, at his hand, at his face. Her expression was unreadable—the mask that all workers learned to wear, the mask that protected them from caring, from feeling, from being destroyed by the things they couldn't change.

"Why me?" she asked.

Kael thought about it. He thought about Alya, about the message she had sent him, about the way he had stayed away because staying away was safer. He thought about the months of silence, the months of survival, the months of pretending that he didn't need anyone.

"Because you're still here," he said. "Because you laughed. Because you noticed when I was dehydrated. Because you gave me half your nutrient block even though you were hungry. Because you're the only person on this planet who makes me feel like I'm not already dead."

Mira's mask cracked. Just a little, just for a moment, but Kael saw it—the grief, the hope, the terrible weight of caring about someone on a planet that didn't allow caring.

"Kael—"

"I'm not going to be able to talk to you anymore. The opposite shifts—we'll never see each other. You know that. I know that. So I'm giving you this." He pressed the drive into her hand. "Read it. Or don't. Keep it. Or throw it away. But it's yours now. The only thing I have that's worth giving."

Mira looked down at the drive. Her fingers closed around it, slowly, as if she was afraid it would disappear.

"Kael."

"Yeah."

"I touched your hand." Her voice was barely a whisper.

"I didn't pull away."

"I know."

"I wanted to. Pull away. I should have. It would have been safer."

"But you didn't."

"No." She looked up at him. Her eyes were wet. He had never seen her cry before. "I didn't."

They stood there, in the golden glow of the LED lights, among the rows of plants that would outlive them both. The cameras were blind. The AI was watching something else. The colony hummed around them, indifferent and eternal.

Kael wanted to touch her hand again. He wanted to hold it, to feel her warmth, to pretend that they were somewhere else, someone else, something other than two workers on a dead planet waiting to die.

He didn't. The cameras would come back online. The AI would notice. They would both be deprecated, recycled, forgotten.

Instead, he took a step back.

"Goodbye, Mira."

"Goodbye, Kael."

He turned. He walked away. He didn't look back.

Behind him, Mira stood alone in the golden light, the drive clutched in her hand, her heart breaking in the silence.

The diary survived.

Kael didn't know that. He wouldn't know for months, maybe years, maybe never. But the diary survived. The words he had written—the careful observations, the hidden feelings, the record of a life that the corporation wanted to erase—all of it survived, stored on a small black drive in the hand of a woman who had learned to laugh on a planet that didn't allow laughter.

Mira read the diary that night. She read it in the sanitation closet, hidden between rows of cleaning supplies, the door locked, the cameras temporarily disabled by a trick Kael had taught her. She read it by the light of her phone, the screen dimmed to avoid

detection, her eyes moving faster than they should, desperate to consume every word.

She read about Alya. About the maintenance access at the back of row seventeen. About the message that had come too late. About the months of silence, the months of survival, the months of pretending that caring was a productivity inefficiency.

She read about herself. About her laugh, her hands, the way she moved through the rows of plants like she belonged there. She read about the hand touching—the fraction of a second that had meant everything, that had cost them everything, that had been worth everything.

And she read the words that Kael had written on page 161, the last page of the diary, the page he had added after the reassignment notice, after the notice from the Unified Humanity Board, after he had given her the drive and walked away.

"The drone did not hate you. The corporation did not judge you. The algorithm did not threaten you. They simply enforced the only law that mattered: the future

belongs to those who can afford to leave. And you, reader, could not."

But maybe you can. Maybe the drive in your hand is the ticket. Maybe the words on these pages are the rocket. Maybe the truth is the only thing that can save you.

I don't know. I'm just a worker. I harvest plants. I meet my quota. I pay for my oxygen.

But I touched someone's hand, and she didn't pull away.

That has to mean something.

That has to be enough.

Kael.

Mira closed the diary. She sat in the dark, the drive clutched in her hand, and she made a decision.

She would not forget him. She would not let the corporation erase him. She would keep the diary safe, would protect it with her life, would make sure that someone—somewhere, someday—would read his words and know that he had existed.

Kael had given her the truth.

Now she had to survive long enough to share it.

Chapter Eight: The Long Gray Years

Year: 2086-2094. Location: Mars Colonial Corporation, Olympus Station, Hydroponics Sector 12.

The opposite shift was a different world.

Kael worked from 6:30 PM to 10:30 AM now, sixteen hours of darkness, sixteen hours of artificial light that pretended to be something it wasn't. The workers on his shift were strangers—faces he had seen in passing, names he had never learned, bodies that moved through the rows of plants with the same mechanical efficiency that had once been his.

He did not speak to them. He did not look at them. He did not allow himself to see them as anything other than obstacles, inefficiencies, distractions from the work.

The work was all that remained.

Cut. Sort. Place. Conveyor.

The rhythm had lost its comfort. It had become something else—a punishment, a penance, a reminder that he had touched someone's hand and she had not pulled away and now he was paying for it with every breath, every hour, every plant that passed through his fingers.

He thought about Mira constantly.

Not the way he had thought about Alya—with grief, with guilt, with the sharp ache of loss. He thought about Mira differently. He thought about her hands, her laugh, the way she had looked at him when he gave her the drive. He thought about the words he had written, the words she was reading, the words that connected them across the impossible distance of a shift schedule designed to keep them apart.

He thought about her, and he harvested, and he waited.

For what, he didn't know.

Mira wrote in the diary.

Not every day—she didn't have Kael's discipline, his need to record, his faith that the words would matter. But she wrote when she could, when the weight of the silence became too heavy, when she needed to feel that someone else existed in the universe besides her and the plants and the machines.

Day 68 (Mira writing): I found his entry about the hand touching. I've read it seventeen times. Each time, I feel something different. The first time, I cried. The seventh time, I got angry. The twelfth time, I laughed. The seventeenth time, I just sat in the dark and held the drive and pretended he was here with me.

Day 75: I saw him today. Across the sector, at shift change. Just a glimpse. He was walking toward the dormitory, his head down, his hands in his pockets. He didn't see me. He never sees me anymore. That's the rule now. We pretend. It's safer.

Day 82: I touched the spot on my hand where his fingers rested. It was weeks ago. I can still feel it. Is that possible? Can you still feel something that lasted less than a second, weeks later?

Day 90: I wrote my own entry today. Not about him—about the plants. About the way they grow even though nothing else on this planet does. About the way they reach for the light even though the light is fake. I think that's what we're doing. Reaching for something fake because the alternative is giving up.

Day 104: Three months since the reassignment. Three months since he touched my hand. Three months since I became someone who keeps secrets instead of someone who just survives.

I don't know which one is harder.

The years passed.

Kael and Mira existed in the same space but not the same time. Their shifts rotated—every few months, the schedule would change, and for a brief window, they would overlap. Not for long. Never for long. Just a few minutes at shift change, just a glimpse across the

sector, just the painful awareness that the other person was alive and breathing and just out of reach.

Year 2087.

Mira saw Kael three times. Once at shift change—he was too far away to speak to, but she watched him walk, watched the way his shoulders carried the weight of the work. Once in the commissary—she was at one end of the room, he was at the other, and they sat in silence, pretending not to see each other. Once in the corridor outside the dormitory—he was coming, she was going, and for a moment, their eyes met.

He nodded. She nodded. They kept walking.

That was the closest they came to speaking.

Day 312: I saw him today. In the corridor. We looked at each other. Less than a second. Like the hand touching. I wanted to say something—anything—but the cameras were watching, and the AI was listening, and the words died in my throat.

He nodded. I nodded. That's all we have now. Nods.

It's not enough.

But it's everything.

Year 2088.

Kael's productivity began to slip.

It started small—a plant here, a plant there, nothing that the AI would notice. But Kael noticed. He felt himself slowing down, felt the cracks in the machine growing wider, felt the weight of the years pressing down on him like the gravity of a planet that didn't want him.

He had been on Mars for four years. Four years of sixteen-hour shifts. Four years of recycled air and nutrient blocks and the constant, grinding pressure of survival. His body was tired. His mind was tired. His soul—if he still had one—was tired.

He tried to fight it. Worked harder. Pushed himself faster. Denied himself sleep, denied himself food, denied himself anything that wasn't essential to meeting the quota.

It wasn't enough. It was never enough.

Day 489 (Kael writing, though he no longer had the tablet—this entry exists only in his memory, never

recorded): I missed quota today. By two plants. Two plants out of two hundred. A rounding error. But the AI doesn't do rounding errors. The AI does numbers. And the numbers say I'm failing.

I'm not failing. I'm just tired. I'm so tired.

I thought about Mira today. I wonder if she still has the drive. I wonder if she still reads my words. I wonder if she remembers the hand touching.

I remember. I remember every day. That's the problem. Remembering makes me slow.

Year 2089.

Mira watched Kael deteriorate.

She couldn't do anything about it—the opposite shifts kept them apart, the cameras kept them silent, the AI kept them afraid. But she watched. At shift change, in the commissary, in the brief moments when their worlds overlapped. She watched his shoulders slump. She watched his hands shake. She watched the light drain from his eyes.

He was dying. Slowly. The way everyone died on Mars.

She wrote about it in the diary.

Day 623: He's thinner than last year. His uniform hangs off him. His face is gray. He looks like a ghost. Maybe he is a ghost. Maybe we're all ghosts here, just waiting to disappear.

I want to touch his hand again. Just once. Just the back of his hand, with two fingers, for less than a second. I want to remind him that he's human. That he's alive. That he touched someone once and she didn't pull away.

But I can't. The cameras are watching. The AI is listening. And if I touch him, they'll kill us both.

So I watch. I wait. I write.

That's all I can do.

Year 2090.

Kael didn't see Mira at all.

The shift schedules had shifted—his rotation had changed, her rotation had changed, and the brief windows of overlap had closed. For an entire year, he

existed in a different time zone, a different world, a different version of Mars where she wasn't present.

He thought about her every day. He wondered if she was alive. He wondered if she had kept the drive. He wondered if she had thrown it away, had deleted the files, had erased him from her memory.

He hoped she had. He hoped she had moved on, had found someone else, had found something worth living for. He hoped she was happy, whatever that meant on a planet where happiness was a productivity inefficiency.

He hoped.

That was all he could do.

Year 2091.

Mira turned fifty years old alone, in her bed, in the dark, with the diary in her hands and tears on her face.

She had been on Mars for seven years. Seven years of sixteen-hour shifts. Seven years of recycled air and nutrient blocks and the constant, grinding pressure of

survival. She had watched hundreds of workers come and go—some to reassignment, some to the airlock, some to the quiet death of being forgotten.

She had outlived them all. Not because she was stronger or smarter or more valuable. Because she had something they didn't.

She had the diary.

The diary was her anchor, her proof, her reason for continuing. It reminded her that she was not just a worker, not just a quota, not just a line item in a spreadsheet. She was the woman whose hand Kael had touched. She was the woman who had laughed on a planet that didn't allow laughter. She was the woman who was keeping a secret that could destroy the corporation.

She wrote in the diary that night.

Year 2091. Day 1,827 (if my math is right, which it probably isn't).

I am fifty years old. I have been on Mars for seven years. I have been writing in this diary for five years. I have been alone for five years.

Not alone—I'm never alone. There are always workers around me, always bodies and faces and names I pretend to remember. But I am alone in the way that matters. The way that counts.

I haven't seen Kael in two years. Two years. I don't know if he's alive. I don't know if he's dead. I don't know if the corporation deprecated him while I was sleeping, while I was working, while I was writing in this diary.

I don't know anything except the quota and the oxygen and the next shift.

But I keep writing.

I write for Kael. I write for the hand touching. I write for the less than a second that meant everything.

I write because if I don't, no one will remember that we existed.

Year 2092.

The schedules shifted again.

For the first time in two years, Kael and Mira were on the same shift. Not working together—the AI had

learned its lesson, had separated them permanently, had assigned them to different sections of the sector. But they breathed the same air. They walked the same corridors. They existed in the same time.

Mira saw him from across the sector. He was harvesting in row twenty-three. She was harvesting in row seven. The distance was too far to speak, too far to nod, too far to do anything except look.

She looked.

He was thinner than she remembered. His hair had grayed. His hands shook constantly now, not just when he was tired. His eyes were hollow, empty, the eyes of someone who had stopped hoping, stopped caring, stopped believing that anything mattered except the quota.

But he was alive. He was still alive.

She watched him for as long as she could. Then she turned back to her plants.

Day 2,011: I saw him today. He's alive. That's all I needed to know.

Year 2093.

Kael's productivity fell below the threshold.

It happened gradually, then suddenly. The cracks in the machine had grown, had spread, had become too large to ignore. His hands shook constantly. His eyes struggled to focus. His mind wandered in the middle of tasks, drifting to places he couldn't name, memories he couldn't access, feelings he couldn't afford.

The AI had been patient. For years, it had monitored him, tracked him, adjusted his quotas and his medications and his shift assignments. But patience was a resource, and resources were finite, and Kael had exhausted his.

"Your productivity has decreased by 34 percent over the past twelve months," the voice announced. "This level of inefficiency is no longer sustainable. You are hereby scheduled for reassignment on 3/14/2094. Please report to Processing at 8:00 AM on that date."

3/14/2094.

Kael didn't know what year it was. He didn't know what month. He didn't know what the numbers meant. But he understood the message.

His time was ending.

He walked to the dormitory. He sat on his bed. He looked at his hands—the scars, the calluses, the trembling that he couldn't control. These hands had touched someone. These hands had held a tablet and written words that mattered. These hands had harvested thousands of plants, millions of plants, enough plants to feed a colony that didn't care if he lived or died.

He thought about Mira. About the drive he had given her. About the diary that contained his life, his thoughts, his heart.

He wondered if she still had it. He wondered if she still read it. He wondered if she had forgotten him, the way everyone forgot everyone on Mars, because remembering was painful and forgetting was survival.

He hoped she had forgotten. He hoped she had thrown the drive away, had deleted the files, had erased him from her memory. He hoped she was safe, whatever that meant on a planet where safety was an illusion and survival was a daily choice.

He hoped she was alive.

That was all he could hope for.

Mira didn't know about the reassignment.

She hadn't seen Kael in months—their schedules had shifted again, the brief overlap had closed, and she had returned to the long gray of not knowing. She worked. She harvested. She wrote in the diary. She waited.

But something was wrong. She could feel it. A tension in the air, a weight on her chest, a sense that the world was about to change.

She walked to Processing on her break. She didn't know why. Something had pulled her there, some instinct she couldn't name, some voice that whispered that today was different, that today was important, that today she needed to be somewhere she wasn't supposed to be.

The Processing corridor was empty. The workers were at their shifts, the supervisors were at their terminals, the AI was watching everything and nothing. Mira stood in the shadows, her back against the cold wall, and she waited.

She didn't know what she was waiting for.

Then the door opened.

Kael walked out.

He was thinner than she remembered—impossibly thin, his uniform hanging off his body like a flag on a windless day. His face was gray, his eyes were hollow, his hands shook with a tremor that she could see from across the corridor. He was not the person who had given her the drive. He was not the person who had touched her hand.

He was a ghost. Walking. Breathing. Still alive, but only barely.

"Kael."

He stopped. Turned. His eyes found hers. For a moment—less than a moment—something flickered in them. Recognition. Memory. The ghost of the person he had been.

"Mira."

His voice was a whisper, dry and cracked, as if he hadn't used it in years. Maybe he hadn't.

"They're sending you to reassignment," she said. It wasn't a question.

"They're sending everyone eventually." He smiled. It was the saddest smile she had ever seen. "I just lasted longer than most."

Mira's hands clenched. The drive was in her pocket—it was always in her pocket, always with her, always reminding her of what she was fighting for. She touched it now, feeling the cold plastic against her fingers, feeling the weight of the words inside.

"I still have it," she said. "The diary. I've been writing in it. Adding my own entries. Keeping it safe."

Kael's eyes widened. Just slightly. Just enough.

"Why?"

"Because you mattered," she said. "Because you touched my hand and I didn't pull away. Because that has to mean something. Because if it doesn't mean anything, then nothing means anything, and we're all just machines waiting to be replaced."

Kael looked at her for a long time. The corridor hummed around them—the ventilators, the

processors, the endless machinery of the colony that was about to kill him.

"I wish I could touch your hand again," he said. "One more time. Less than a second. That's all I need."

Mira stepped forward. Her hand reached out. Her fingers found his.

She didn't pull away.

They stood there, in the Processing corridor, two workers on a dead planet, holding hands for less than a second, for more than a second, for a moment that would have to last the rest of their lives.

Then the door opened again. The uniformed officials stepped out. They took Kael by the arms and led him toward the airlock.

He didn't look back.

Mira watched him go. She watched until the door closed. She watched until the corridor was empty.

Then she ran.

She ran to the sanitation closet. She locked the door. She disabled the cameras. She pulled out the drive and the tablet—the tablet was dead, had been dead for years, but she had kept it anyway, had carried it with her, had hoped that someday she would find a way to charge it, to read the words again, to see his handwriting on the screen.

The tablet was dead. But the drive had a camera.

Mira had used it before—to document the work, to record the conditions, to capture the faces of workers who would soon be forgotten. She had never used it for anything important. She had been afraid. She had been waiting.

She wasn't waiting anymore.

She pointed the drive at the door. She pressed the button. She recorded.

Nothing happened. The corridor was empty. The airlock was sealed. The moment had passed.

But she kept recording. She recorded the empty corridor. She recorded the closed door. She recorded the silence where Kael's footsteps had been.

And then the airlock cycled.

Mira didn't hear it—the sanitation closet was too far away, the walls were too thick, the hum of the machines was too loud. But she felt it. A vibration in the floor, a pressure change in the air, a wrongness that traveled through the colony like a scream that no one could hear.

She kept recording.

When the vibration stopped, she stopped recording. She saved the file. She watched it back—just the empty corridor, just the closed door, just the silence where a man had walked to his death.

It was not enough. It would never be enough.

But it was something.

She read the diary that night. All of it. From the beginning. From Day 1, when Kael had written about her laugh, to the last entry he had added before the reassignment, to her own entries, the years of waiting and watching and hoping.

She read about Alya. About the maintenance access.
About the message that had come too late.

She read about herself. About the hand touching.
About the less than a second that had meant
everything.

She read about the corporation. About the quotas and
the tokens and the airlocks and the bodies that were
recycled into nutrients for the plants.

She read about Earth. About the habitation zones and
the subscriptions and the gray boxes on phones. About
a world that had forgotten how to be free.

And she read the words that Kael had written on the
last page, the words that had haunted her for years,
the words that she now understood were not just
poetry but prophecy.

*"The drone did not hate you. The corporation did not
judge you. The algorithm did not threaten you. They
simply enforced the only law that mattered: the future
belongs to those who can afford to leave."*

"And you, reader, could not."

Mira closed the diary. She sat in the dark, the drive in her hand, and she thought about those words.

She could not afford to leave. She had never been able to afford to leave. She had come to Mars because she had won a lottery, because she had believed in a brighter future, because she had been young and stupid and full of hope.

But she was not young anymore. She was not stupid anymore. She was not full of hope.

She was full of something else. Something harder. Something sharper.

Determination.

She was going to leave. She was going to go back to Earth. She was going to take the diary, and the video, and the truth, and she was going to show it to everyone who would watch.

And if the corporation killed her for it—well. At least she would die trying.

The waste rocket launched once every six months.

It carried the colony's refuse—broken equipment, expired nutrient blocks, biological waste—back to Earth for recycling. The rocket was automated, uncrewed, unmonitored. No one paid attention to the waste rocket. No one cared what it carried.

Mira cared.

She spent two weeks preparing. She stole food—nutrient bars, enough to last a month, hidden in the pockets of her uniform. She stole water—several bottles, heavy and awkward, but she carried them anyway. She stole a blanket, a change of clothes, a small flashlight that she had found in an abandoned locker.

And she stole herself.

On the night of the launch, she slipped away from the dormitory. She walked through the empty corridors, past the cameras that were blind in the dead zones, past the sensors that she had learned to trick. She reached the launch bay. She climbed into the waste container.

The smell was indescribable. Decaying organic matter, chemical residue, the accumulated filth of six months

of colonial life. Mira gagged, swallowed, forced herself to breathe. She buried herself beneath the waste, covered herself in refuse, made herself invisible.

The rocket launched.

The acceleration pressed her into the filth, crushed her against the walls of the container, threatened to break her bones and burst her lungs. She screamed—not from pain, not from fear, but from the sheer impossibility of what she was doing. A woman of fifty, hiding in garbage, fleeing a planet that had tried to kill her.

The rocket reached orbit. The acceleration stopped. Mira floated in the darkness, weightless and sick, surrounded by waste and the hum of engines that were carrying her home.

She had the drive in her pocket. The diary was on it. The video was on it. Her life was on it.

She closed her eyes. She thought about Kael. About his hand on hers. About the less than a second that had meant everything.

She thought about Earth. About the world she had left behind, the world she barely remembered, the world that might not want her back.

She thought about the corporation. About the people who had killed Kael, who had killed Alya, who had killed thousands of workers and called it "reassignment."

She thought about the truth. The truth that she was carrying in her pocket, the truth that could destroy everything, the truth that was worth dying for.

The rocket flew on.

The journey took months.

Mira lost track of time. The waste container had no windows, no clocks, no markers of day or night. She ate when she was hungry, drank when she was thirsty, slept when she was tired. The nutrient bars ran out. The water ran out. She grew thin, thinner than she had ever been on Mars, thin enough that she could feel her bones pressing against her skin.

She did not die. She refused to die.

The diary was her companion. She read it over and over, memorizing Kael's words, memorizing her own, memorizing the story of two workers who had touched hands on a dead planet. She talked to Kael in her mind, told him about her journey, promised him that she would not let his death be forgotten.

She talked to Alya too. The woman she had never met, the woman who had loved Kael before she did, the woman who had been deprecated and recycled and turned into the plants that Kael had harvested. She talked to Alya about survival, about loss, about the impossible weight of being the one who lived.

And she talked to herself. About fear. About hope. About the person she had been and the person she had become.

She had left Earth as a winner. She was returning as something else. A fugitive. A witness. A ghost.

The rocket entered Earth's atmosphere. The container shook, rattled, heated to temperatures that should have killed her. Mira curled into a ball, covered her head with her arms, prayed to gods she didn't believe in.

The rocket landed.

The waste facility was automated.

Mira had planned for this. She had studied the facility's layout, its schedules, its blind spots. She knew when the containers were unloaded, when the workers were present, when the cameras were active.

She waited.

The container opened. The waste was dumped into a processing unit. Mira tumbled out with the refuse, landed on a conveyor belt, was carried toward a shredder that would have torn her apart.

She rolled off the belt. She hit the floor. She lay there, gasping, her body bruised and broken, her lungs struggling to breathe air that was thicker than anything she had known for years.

Earth air. Real air. Air that was not metered, not paid for, not monitored.

She had forgotten what it felt like.

She crawled to the edge of the facility. She found a door. She opened it. She stepped outside.

The sky was blue.

Not the pale gray of the dome. Not the artificial glow of the LED lights. Blue. Real blue. The kind of blue that she had seen in dreams, in memories, in the photographs that her grandmother had kept in a box beneath her bed.

Mira stood in the blue light, swaying on her feet, and she cried.

She cried for Kael. For Alya. For everyone she had left behind on Mars. For everyone she would never see again.

She cried for herself. For the years she had lost. For the person she had been and could never be again.

And then she stopped crying. She wiped her face. She looked around.

She was in a field. Not a habitation zone—a real field, with grass and weeds and the remains of what might have been a forest. The waste facility was behind her, a

hulking gray structure that hummed with the same mechanical pulse as the colony she had fled.

In front of her was the world.

She didn't know where she was. She didn't know what year it was. She didn't know if her family was alive, if her friends remembered her, if anyone would believe the truth she was carrying.

But she was alive. She was free. She was on Earth.

She started walking.

She found the water in a hidden pocket in a rock wall.

It was not much—a trickle, really, seeping through a crack in the stone, collecting in a small depression that had been carved by years of rain. The water was cold and clear and tasted like nothing she had ever experienced. Not the recycled water of Mars. Not the treated water of the habitation zones. Real water. Earth water.

She drank until her stomach ached. She filled her bottles. She sat in the shadow of the rock wall and ate the last of her nutrient bars.

The tablet was dead. Had been dead for years. She had tried to charge it on the rocket, had tried to find an outlet, had tried to revive it with the last of her strength. But the tablet was gone, its battery depleted, its screen dark.

The drive was still alive. The drive was everything.

She held it in her hand, small and black and unremarkable, and she thought about the words it contained. Kael's words. Her words. The truth.

She thought about what she had to do next. Find people. Tell them. Show them the video. Make them believe.

She thought about the corporation. About the drones. About the wet sound that she had heard through the walls of her apartment on Earth, before she had won the lottery, before she had left everything behind.

She was not safe. She would never be safe. The corporation had eyes everywhere, ears everywhere, drones that could find her and kill her and make it look like an accident.

But she was on Earth. She was free. And she had the truth.

That was enough.

For now, that was enough.

Chapter Nine: The Lock

Year: 2094. Location: Greater Boston Habitation Zone, Waste Facility, Section B.

The waste facility was on the edge of the Greater Boston Habitation Zone, fifty-three kilometers from the apartment building where the fire escape still held. Fifty-three kilometers of abandoned industrial parks, collapsed tunnels, and neighborhoods that had been "de-optimized" when their residents could no longer afford the subscription. Mira walked for three days. She slept in culverts and the skeletons of parked trucks. She drank from a drainage ditch that tasted of chemicals and rust. She had no map, no phone service, no plan. Only the drive in her pocket and the vague, desperate hope that somewhere in the habitation

zones—anywhere—she could find a door that would open for her.

By the time she reached the building's fire escape, her shoes had dissolved, her uniform was in rags, and she had stopped feeling hungry. She climbed six flights on bleeding feet. The window to Apartment 14A was unlocked. The door unlocked, a dead body, looking like it had been dragged around by someone. Someone who later decided leaving it there was more efficient. Not a body anymore. More accurately just the bones in the center of the familiar, standardized, boring room.

Chapter Ten: The Key

Year: 2094. Location: Greater Boston Habitation Zone, Apartment 14A.

The key was in the lock.

Not on the body. Not under the mat. Not hidden in the ventilation shaft where the cleaning drones never looked. It was *in the lock*. On the outside of the door. As if Elias had stepped out for a moment and never come back and then dragged back inside to close a story. As if someone had known, somehow, that someone would need to get in. Or maybe thought nobody would. It's anyone's guess.

Mira's hands were shaking. Not from the cold—though the corridor was cold, the heating set to economy mode, the air neutral with hints of citrus. She was

shaking from the running. From the hiding. From the two weeks of sleeping in loading docks and drainage culverts and the skeletons of buildings that had been abandoned when their leases expired.

She was shaking because she was still alive.

The key turned. The lock clicked. The door opened.

The smell hit her first. Not the citrus of the hallway. Not the recycled metal of Mars. Something older. Drier. The smell of time passing through a space that had never been *rented*.

She stepped inside.

The apartment was larger than the others. Not because the building had been built that way, but because the walls had never been moved. The other units on this floor—14B, 14C—had been subdivided years ago, optimized for maximum occupancy, chopped into six-by-eight cells that maximized revenue for the corporation that had bought the building out from under its tenants.

But not this one. This one was still whole. Still original. Still *owned*.

Mira had forgotten what ownership felt like. On Earth, before the lottery, she had rented everything—her apartment, her clothes, her air, her right to exist. On Mars, she had owned nothing except the scars on her hands and the drive in her pocket. But this apartment—the walls, the floor, the window that faced the air shaft—belonged to someone. Not a corporation. Not a landlord.

Elias Voss *was* the owner. Had always been the owner. She found him in the living room.

Slumped in a worn chair that faced the small kitchen window. His clothes had faded to the color of dust. His skin had drawn tight over his bones, parchment-thin, translucent in the gray light. His hands rested on his knees, the fingers curled inward. His head was tilted back, his mouth slightly open, his empty eye sockets fixed on the ceiling as if he had been watching something that no one else could see.

He had been dead for ten years.

And in his lap, covered by a blanket, hidden from the recycling drones that had no jurisdiction here because *this was not their building*, was a notebook.

Actual paper. Actual ink.

Mira did not scream. She did not cry. She stood in the doorway of a dead man's home—a home that had belonged to his parents before him, that had been bought in a time when people still bought things—and she felt something she had not felt in years.

She felt like she was exactly where she was supposed to be.

She closed the door. She took the notebook.

Chapter Eleven: The Reminiscence

Year: 2094. Location: Apartment 14A. Elias's voice, reaching back.

The handwriting was small and dense, sometimes trembling, sometimes steady. The dates were not always precise. Some entries had exact days. Others only a year. A few just a season—*spring, I think*—as if the memory had softened at the edges, worn smooth by time.

Mira understood. She had lost track of the days on Mars. She had forgotten her own birthday twice. Memory was not a recording. It was a reconstruction. And Elias, sitting alone in this apartment for decades, had been reconstructing his whole life.

She began to read.

»«

I was born in 2021. That much I know. The year is stamped on documents I still have—paper documents, the kind they don't issue anymore. My parents bought this apartment in 2019. Before I was born. They paid with money they earned. Not credit. Not subscriptions. Money.

I don't remember much from before. I was a child. Children don't notice the world changing. They notice their toys, their friends, whether there's enough food. But I remember some things. Small things. The way my father would open the window in the morning and just... breathe. Not check his balance. Not scan a code. Just stand there and breathe.

I didn't know that would become extraordinary. I was six. I thought everyone opened windows.

—from a memory, no date, probably mid-2020s

»«

Winter, I think. 2026? Maybe 2027.

I was five or six. My mother took me to the coffee shop on the corner—the one that's been there since before she

was born. I remember the screen on the wall. It showed my face. My name. "Welcome back, Elias."

I had never been there before.

My mother laughed. Said it was "clever." Said the machine was just trying to be friendly. I didn't laugh. I was too young to laugh at things that scared me. I just held her hand and stared at the screen.

She asked me what was wrong. I couldn't tell her. I didn't have the words. But I remember thinking: that machine knows my name. I don't know its name. That's not fair.

I forgot about it. For years. Until I was older. Until the screens were everywhere. Until the machines knew everything. Then I remembered.

—winter, probably 2026 or 2027

»«

Mira paused. Elias had been a child when he first saw it. A child. He had held his mother's hand and felt something wrong, and then he had forgotten, because children forget, because the world is supposed to be safe.

She turned the page.

2030. The year I remember because of the sound.

The first death in the building that wasn't old age. Mr. Chen. He lived in 12B. He was my parents' tenant. He had been there since before I was born.

They turned off his air. I didn't understand what that meant at first. I was nine. Air was just air. You didn't turn it off. You opened a window.

But Mr. Chen didn't have a window that opened to the outside. His apartment faced the interior corridor. His air came from the building's system. And the building's system had been sold. Or leased. Or subscribed. I didn't understand. I still don't fully understand. But the corporation that now owned the air—that owned the right to breathe—decided Mr. Chen hadn't paid enough.

My father tried to help. He went to the corporation's office. He stood in line for hours. He came back with a form and a phone number that no one answered.

Mr. Chen died on a Tuesday. I remember because I had a math test that day, and the drone came for his body while I was eating breakfast, and the sound of the vacuum—the wet sound—made me drop my spoon.

My mother cleaned up the milk. She didn't say anything. None of us said anything.

After that, my father started opening the window every morning. Just for a few minutes. Just to breathe. He said it was "good for the lungs." But I think he was afraid. I think he was afraid that one day, even our air—the air in this apartment, the air my parents owned because they owned the walls—would be taken too.

—2030, exact date uncertain

»«

Mira looked up at the body in the chair. At the hands curled inward. Elias had been nine years old. He had heard the same wet sound that Nika would hear fifty-three years later. The same sound. The same corporation. The same air.

The only difference was that Elias had a father who opened the window.

She kept reading.

»«

Sometime in the 2030s. I don't remember the year.

The screens got smaller. Or maybe they got larger. I don't remember. I just remember that everywhere I went, something was watching. The coffee shop. The school. The hallway. My phone. My tablet. The walls.

My parents didn't seem to notice. Or maybe they noticed and didn't say anything. That was the thing about the 2030s. Everyone noticed. No one spoke.

I asked my father once—I must have been twelve or thirteen—I asked him why the machine in the hallway knew my name. He said it was "efficiency." He said it was "convenience." He said I shouldn't worry.

But he looked worried. I saw it. In the way his hands stopped moving when he said it. In the way he looked at the machine the same way he looked at the window.

—2030s, exact year lost

»«

Late 2030s. Maybe 2038. The year my mother got sick. Not a real sickness. The kind that comes from working too much, breathing too little, eating the food that comes from the dispenser because fresh food costs extra. She had been healthy. She had been strong. But

the years of subscriptions—of paying for air, for water, for the right to exist—had worn her down.

The corporation offered a "wellness package." Premium tier. Access to better nutrition, better filtration, better air. My father sold his watch to pay for it. The watch was his father's. It was one of the few things they still owned outright.

My mother died anyway.

I remember the day clearly. March. The light through the window was gray. She was in the chair—this chair, the one I'm sitting in now—and she was holding my hand. Her hand was warm. Warmer than I expected. She squeezed my fingers and said, "Elias. Keep the apartment. Don't let them take it."

I promised.

I was seventeen.

—March 2038, I think

»«

Mira touched the arm of the chair. Elias's mother had died here. In this same chair. Holding her son's hand. Asking him to keep the apartment.

He had kept his promise.

She turned the page.

»«

2045. The year they fired me.

I was a teacher. A real teacher. Not a hologram. Not an AI. A person, standing in front of other people, telling them about the past. I taught history. Real history. The Haymarket Affair. The Pullman Strike. The moments when workers stood up and said no.

The AI that evaluated my classroom said my curriculum contained "content that may incite civil unrest."

I was given a choice. Revise my curriculum. Or leave.

I left.

Sasha was twenty-four. She was working two jobs. She was trying to save enough to enter the Mars lottery. She didn't have time for a father who was "inciting civil unrest."

So I took the pension. I signed the conversion agreement. I watched my retirement become a subscription.

But I kept the apartment. My mother's apartment. My father's apartment. My apartment.

The corporation offered to buy it. Three times. The offers got larger each time. The threats got sharper. "Your building is a liability," they said. "Unoptimized. Inefficient."

I told them to keep their money. I told them I would die here. I told them that when I was gone, the apartment would go to Sasha, and she would never sell either.

I don't know if that's true anymore. I haven't heard from Sasha in years.

—2045

»«

Mira read faster now, hungry for the shape of his life.

»«

2049. The year Sasha left.

She won the lottery. She was thirty-three. She had been entering for years. She had given up hope. And then, suddenly, she won.

I tried to stop her. I showed her the articles—the ones that hadn't been deleted yet. The ones that talked about "worker retention" and "productivity optimization." She didn't believe me. She said I was paranoid. She said the corporation had been vetted. She said the lottery was her only chance.

"Daddy," she said, "I can't stay here. The air costs money. The walls are closing in. I can't breathe."

I didn't know what to say. Because she was right. The air did cost money. The walls were closing in. She couldn't breathe.

I let her go.

I have regretted it every day since.

—2049

»«

2050s. The decade of silence.

Sasha stopped messaging. I don't know when exactly. The years blur. She would send a message every few months at first. Short. Tired. "I'm fine. Work is hard. Don't worry." Then every six months. Then once a year. Then nothing.

I kept messaging her. Every week. Sometimes every day. The communication fee was 100 tokens per minute. I spent my pension on it. I spent my savings. I spent everything I had to keep sending words into the void.

She never wrote back.

I don't know if she received my messages. I don't know if she's alive. I don't know anything.

But the apartment is still hers. I am keeping it for her. When she comes back, she will have somewhere to go.

—2050s, exact date uncertain

»«

2061. The year they took the building. Not my apartment. The rest of it.

14B sold. 14C sold. The tenants who stayed signed their rights away. The corporation moved in. They put up new walls. They installed new meters. They turned the building into what they called "optimized habitation units."

I watched from my window. The construction drones worked through the night. I could hear them cutting, drilling, reshaping the space where I had grown up.

In the morning, the hallway was different. The walls were gray. The air smelled of citrus. The neighbors I had known for decades were gone. New people moved in. People who had never known a world where a person could own a wall.

They don't know what they've lost. They never knew. They were born into the prison. They think the bars are just part of the architecture.

But I know. I remember. And I still own this apartment.

—2061

»«

2070s. The decades of waiting.

I don't remember most of the 2070s. The days blurred together. I would wake up. Open the window. Breathe. Close the window. Write. Eat. Sleep. Repeat.

Sasha didn't come back. The corporation didn't take my apartment. The world kept spinning.

I grew old. My hands started shaking. My knees started hurting. My eyes started failing.

But I kept writing. Because if I didn't write, no one would remember. No one would know that the air used to be free. That walls used to belong to people. That a person could own something without paying for it every month.

—2070s, most dates lost

»«

2084. The year I stopped waiting.

I posted on the forum. The local one. The community board that no one reads. I wrote about Mars. About the lottery. About the people who win and don't come back.

The post stayed up for three minutes. Then it was gone.

But someone saw it. Someone in this building. Someone who will remember.

I'm not afraid. I was afraid for sixty-three years. I'm tired of being afraid.

If they come for me, they come for me. But they won't get the apartment. They won't get the key. They won't get the truth.

My name is Elias Voss. I was born in 2021. I have been waiting for my daughter for thirty-four years.

She is not coming back.

But the apartment is still here. The walls are still standing. The key is still in the lock.

And someday, someone will find it. Someone will read this. Someone will know.

Someone will stay.

They will try to empty the apartment. They'll try to destroy the evidence. But they don't own the apartment. Not every apartment. Just mine. They'll take things out. But they'll return them.

They won't rent out an apartment they don't have the rights for

—2084, I think. Spring? The light was different.

»«

The diary ended there.

Not with a signature. Not with a goodbye. Just the words, trailing off into the white space at the bottom of the page, as if Elias had been interrupted.

Or as if he had said everything he needed to say.

Mira closed the notebook. She sat in the dead man's chair—the worn chair, where his mother had died, where he had died, where the memory of two generations had settled into the fabric like dust—and she looked out the small kitchen window at the air shaft and the gray walls and the distant sliver of sky that was almost blue.

Elias had been born in 2021. He had been a child when he first saw the screen that knew his name. He had been nine years old when he heard the wet sound of a drone taking a body. He had been seventeen when his mother died in this chair. He had been a teacher. A father. A landlord. A ghost.

He had watched the world change. He had watched his daughter leave. He had watched his building get carved into pieces.

But he had kept this apartment. This one room. This one key.

Because his mother had asked him to.

Mira thought about her own mother. The woman who had ground dog food by hand, who had skipped her

own food upgrades to keep a dog alive, who had looked at the gray box on her phone and said, *Nothing you need to worry about.*

She thought about Kael. About his hand on hers. About the less than a second that had meant everything.

She thought about the key. About the lock. About the door that had been waiting for her.

She opened the small kitchen window. The air shaft was dark. The recycling plant hummed in the distance. The air that came through was not free—it was the same air that filled the rest of the building, filtered and metered and owned by someone she would never meet.

But *this space* was free. These walls. This floor. This window. This chair.

Elias had held it for sixty-three years. He had held it for his mother. For his daughter. For a world that no longer existed.

Now Mira would hold it for something else.

She breathed. The air tasted of dust and time and the ghost of a man who had been born when the world was still free.

Then she closed the window, turned to the corner where Elias Voss was waiting—still waiting, even in death—and she made a decision.

She would stay.

She would live in this apartment. She would keep the key. She would read the diary again and again until she knew every word. She would learn the shape of the prison that the world had become—brick by brick, clause by clause, subscription by subscription.

And then she would open the door.

Not for the corporation. Not for the algorithm. For the people who were still breathing. For the people who had never known a world where air was free. For the people who were still renting their lives one month at a time.

For Kael. For the hand she had touched. For the less than a second that had meant everything.

For Elias. Who had been nine years old when he heard the wet sound. Who had kept his promise. Who had left the key in the lock.

The ventilator hummed—his ventilator, not theirs, connected to nothing, owned by no one but the dead. The walls stood where they had always stood. The key hung in the lock on the outside of the door, waiting for no one, belonging to everyone who needed it.

Mira leaned back in the dead man's chair.

She closed her eyes.

For the first time in years, she slept in a place that was not rented. Not monitored. Not owned by anyone but the dead and the living and the space between them.

She slept in the last free room on Earth.

And in her dreams, she heard a child's voice.

*That machine knows my name. I don't know its name.
That's not fair.*

She woke up.

She stayed.

Chapter Twelve: The Master

Year: 2094. Location: Greater Boston Habitation Zone, Apartment 14A.

The first time Nika saw the old woman, she almost walked away.

It was 4:47 AM. Nika was coming back from the stairwell—the broken one, the one the cameras didn't watch—where she had been sitting alone in the dark, thinking about things she didn't have words for. She was twenty-four now. She had been living in this building for seventeen years. She had been an adult for six of those years, though she wasn't sure what that meant anymore.

The door to 14A was open.

Not ajar. Not unlocked. Open. Wide open, like a mouth, like a wound, like something that had been waiting for her.

Nika stopped. Her phone buzzed—a reminder that her sleep window was ending, that she had paid for seven hours and twenty-three minutes and the system would begin deducting from her monthly allowance if she didn't get back to bed. She looked at the open door. She looked at her phone.

Inside the doorway, something moved.

A face appeared in the darkness. An old woman's face—thin, hollow-cheeked, with eyes that had seen too much and hair that had gone gray too early. She was wearing a uniform that Nika didn't recognize, gray and stained and torn in places.

"You're not supposed to be here," the old woman said. Her voice was hoarse, like she hadn't used it in years.

Nika looked at her phone again. Seven hours and twelve minutes remaining. The deduction would start soon.

"Okay," Nika said.

She turned around. She walked back to 14C. She climbed into bed. Scout shifted at her feet, sighed, pressed his warm body against her legs. The ventilator hummed. The air pushed into her lungs, neutral with hints of citrus.

She fell asleep thinking about the open door and the old woman and the way the hallway had smelled faintly of dust and something else—something she couldn't name.

She did not dream.

Yan was waiting for her in the stairwell the next morning.

The same stairwell. The same concrete steps. The same broken sensors that the cleaning drones had never been programmed to notice. He was twenty-five now, ten years older than the boy who had shown her the video of a woman being sucked into space. His hair was still dark, still falling into his eyes, but there was gray at his temples now.

"You're late," he said.

"I know." Nika sat down on the step beside him. The concrete was cold. It was always cold. "There's something I need to tell you."

She told him about the open door. About the old woman. About the uniform she didn't recognize and the voice that sounded like it hadn't been used in years and the way she had walked away because her sleep window was ending and she couldn't afford the deduction.

Yan listened. His face was unreadable—the mask that all workers learned to wear.

"So you didn't go in," he said.

"I didn't go in."

"You just... went back to bed."

"I needed the sleep."

Yan was quiet for a long time. The stairwell hummed—the ventilators, the elevators, the countless small machines that kept the building alive. Somewhere above them, someone was running water. Somewhere

below, someone was arguing with the AI about a late payment.

"We should go look," he said finally. "Together. Now."

"Now?"

"The door was open at 4:47 AM. It might still be open. Or it might not. But if there's someone in 14A—someone who shouldn't be there—we should know about it."

Nika thought about the old woman's face. The hollow cheeks. The gray hair. The eyes that had looked at her like she was being measured for something.

"She's probably gone," Nika said.

"Probably. But we should check anyway."

Nika stood up. Scout was waiting for her at the door to 14C, his old tail wagging slowly, his eyes clouded with age. She bent down to scratch behind his ears—the same spot, the same motion, the same love that she had felt when she was fourteen and the world was still new.

"Fine," she said. "But if she's still there, you're doing the talking."

The door to 14A was still open.

Not wide open this time—just a crack, a sliver of darkness between the frame and the lock. The name on the buzzer still read "tenant_4c," the same meaningless placeholder that had been there for ten years. The hallway smelled of citrus and neutral air and something else—something older, drier, the smell of time passing through a space that had never been rented.

Yan knocked. Three times. Quick. Quiet.

No response.

He pushed the door open.

The apartment was larger than they expected.

Not because they had never seen it—they had walked past this door a thousand times, had wondered about the space behind it, had imagined the rooms that had been carved out of the original floor plan. But they had forgotten that there were apartments in this building that hadn't been subdivided, that still had walls where

walls were supposed to be, that still had rooms you could walk across without touching both sides at once.

The living room was furnished. Not with rented furniture—the kind that came with a subscription and was replaced every six months to keep you from getting too comfortable. Real furniture. Old furniture. A worn chair by the window. A wooden table in the center of the room. Shelves along the walls, filled with books—actual books, printed on paper, the kind that hadn't been manufactured in decades.

And in the worn chair, the old woman.

She was sitting with her back to them, facing the small kitchen window—the one that faced the air shaft, the one that Elias had opened every evening at 7:23 PM to breathe the air that used to be free. She didn't turn around when they entered. She didn't acknowledge them at all.

"You're not supposed to be here," she said. Same hoarse voice. Same words as the night before.

Yan and Nika exchanged a glance.

"We live in this building," Yan said. "We saw your door was open. We wanted to make sure you were—"

"Alive? I'm alive. Unfortunately." The old woman turned. Her eyes were gray in the dim light, gray like the sky over the habitation zones, gray like everything that had been bleached of color by the slow erosion of the world. "You're the ones who use the broken stairwell. The one the cameras don't watch. I've seen you. You meet there. You talk. You think no one notices."

Nika felt a chill run down her spine. "How long have you been watching us?"

"Weeks. Months. I don't know. I lost track." The old woman gestured to the chairs around the table. "Sit down. Both of you. I have something to show you."

Yan didn't move. Neither did Nika.

"We don't know who you are," Yan said. "We don't know how you got into this apartment. We don't know why we should trust you."

"My name is Mira." She reached into her pocket and pulled out a small black drive—the kind that workers used to transfer files, the kind the AI tracked and monitored. "I came from Mars. I hid in a waste rocket."

I've been on Earth for—" She paused, counting on her fingers. "I don't know. A few weeks. I lost track."

Yan stared at her. Then he laughed.

Not a kind laugh. A short, sharp, disbelieving laugh, the kind that escaped when someone said something so absurd that there was no other response.

"You came from Mars," he repeated. "In a waste rocket."

"Yes."

"And now you're sitting in a dead man's apartment, telling stories to two strangers."

"I'm not telling stories. I'm telling the truth."

Yan looked at Nika. Nika looked at Yan. The same thought passed between them, unspoken: *She's insane.*

"We should go," Nika said.

"Wait." Mira held up the drive. "I have proof. Videos. Documents. A diary. Things that the corporation doesn't want anyone to see. Things that will get us all killed if anyone finds out we have them."

Yan shook his head. "Videos can be faked. Documents can be forged. Diaries can be written by anyone."

"This diary was written by the man who lived in this apartment. Elias Voss. He was your neighbor. He was killed ten years ago for posting the truth about Mars on a forum." Mira's eyes moved to Nika. "You heard it happen. The drone. The wet sound. You've been living with it ever since."

Nika's blood went cold. She had never told anyone about that—not the details, not the sound, not the way it had stayed with her. Only Yan knew. Only Yan, because he had been there too.

"How do you know that?" Nika whispered.

"Because I've been watching you. Because I've been waiting. Because I came here to find people like you—people who remember, people who care, people who might be willing to listen." Mira leaned forward. "I'm not asking you to believe me. I'm asking you to listen. That's all. Just listen."

Yan took a step back toward the door. "This is a trap. She's probably working for the corporation. They send

people like this to find dissenters. To lure them out. To
—"

"To what? Kill you?" Mira laughed. It was a hollow sound, empty of humor. "If the corporation wanted you dead, you'd be dead. They have drones. They have algorithms. They have files on both of you going back years. You're not hard to find. You're just not worth the effort. Not yet."

"Then why are you here?"

Mira was quiet for a long time. She looked out the small kitchen window, at the air shaft, at the gray walls, at the distant sliver of sky that was almost blue.

"Because of him," she said finally, nodding toward the worn chair. "Elias. He waited for his daughter for thirty-four years. He knew she wasn't coming back. But he waited anyway. He kept the apartment. He kept the key. He kept the door unlocked."

She paused.

"And because of someone I loved. On Mars. His name was Kael. He touched my hand. For less than a second. And then they killed him. But before they killed him,

he gave me a drive. His diary. His words. His proof that he existed."

She held up the drive again.

"I'm not trying to change the world. I'm trying to make sure that someone remembers. That someone knows. That someone, somewhere, will read Kael's words and Elias's words and my words and know that we were here. That we suffered. That we fought. That we lost."

Yan looked at the drive. Then at Nika. Then back at Mira.

"This is insane," he said. "You're insane."

"Probably."

"We should go."

"Probably."

Neither of them moved.

They didn't take the drive.

They didn't sit down. They didn't agree to anything. They stood in the doorway of 14A for another minute, then another, then Yan shook his head and walked out

into the hallway. Nika followed. The door closed behind them.

The hallway smelled of citrus. The ventilator hummed. The world was exactly the same as it had been ten minutes ago.

"That woman is crazy," Yan said as they walked back to their apartments.

"Probably."

"Coming from Mars in a waste rocket? That's not possible. The waste rockets are automated. No life support. She'd be dead in hours."

"She seemed pretty alive to me."

"She seemed pretty crazy to me." Yan stopped outside his door. His hand was on the lock. "We're not going back there. Right? We're not going to listen to her stories about Mars and diaries and hands touching. We're not going to—"

"I don't know," Nika said. "I haven't decided."

Yan stared at her. "Nika."

"She knew about the sound. The wet sound. I never told her that. You never told her that. How did she know?"

"Lucky guess. Coincidence. She's been watching us—she said so herself. She probably heard us talking in the stairwell."

"Maybe." Nika opened her door. Scout was waiting for her, his old tail wagging. "Or maybe she's telling the truth."

"She's not."

"You don't know that."

"Neither do you."

Nika looked at him. At the gray at his temples. At the lines around his mouth. At the exhaustion in his eyes that had been there for as long as she could remember.

"I'll see you tomorrow," she said. "In the stairwell."

She closed the door. Scout licked her hand. The ventilator hummed.

She thought about the old woman's face. The hollow cheeks. The gray hair. The eyes that had looked at her like she was being measured for something.

Crazy, Nika thought. *Probably crazy*.

But she couldn't stop thinking about the drive. The small black drive that supposedly contained videos of Mars. Documents. A diary. The truth.

She didn't believe it. Not really. It sounded like fiction. The kind of thing people made up when they'd been alone too long, when their minds had started to fray at the edges.

But she kept thinking about it anyway.

They went back the next day.

Not because they believed her. Not because they trusted her. Because they were curious. Because the door was still open, just a crack, and the hallway smelled of dust and time and something that made them want to know more.

Mira was sitting in the same chair. The same worn chair by the same small window. She didn't turn around when they entered.

"You came back," she said.

"We didn't have anything better to do," Yan said.

Mira smiled. It was not a kind smile. It was the smile of someone who had been told she was crazy so many times that she had stopped caring. "Sit down. I'll tell you a story."

"We're not sitting."

"Suit yourself."

They stood. Mira talked. She talked about Mars. About the sixteen-hour shifts and the quotas and the tokens. About the air that tasted of metal and dust. About the workers who disappeared and were never mentioned again.

Yan listened with his arms crossed. Nika listened with her hand on the door frame, ready to leave at any moment.

Mira talked about Kael. About his hands. About the way he had touched her for less than a second. About

the diary he had written, the words he had saved, the truth he had died to protect.

"He wasn't a hero," she said. "He was just a worker. A tired, broken worker who had given up on everything except the hope that someone would remember him."

Yan snorted. "That's a nice story. Very dramatic. Very sad. But it's just a story."

Mira looked at him. Her gray eyes were steady. "You think I'm lying."

"I think you believe what you're saying. That's not the same thing as being right."

"And what would convince you? What would make you believe?"

Yan shrugged. "Evidence. Real evidence. Not stories. Not diaries. Something I can verify. Something that can't be faked."

Mira reached into her pocket. She held out the drive.

"Take it. Watch the videos. Read the documents. Verify them however you want. If you still think I'm lying after that, I'll leave. I'll never bother you again."

Yan looked at the drive. He didn't take it.

Nika took it.

"Fine," Nika said. "We'll watch it. But I'm not promising anything."

Mira nodded. "That's all I ask."

They watched the videos in Yan's apartment.

The same apartment. The same six-by-eight cell. The same walls covered in thermal paper, the code fading now, the text illegible in places. Yan had a setup that could block the sensors for a few hours—risky, he said, but possible.

The first video showed a corridor. Gray walls, gray floor, gray ceiling. A woman in a gray uniform. An airlock opening behind her.

Nika had seen this before. Ten years ago. In the stairwell. The same video. The same woman. The same ending.

"I've seen this," she said.

Yan nodded. "So have I. It's old. Been circulating for years. Doesn't prove anything."

The next video was different. A man in a different uniform, a different corridor. Same ending. Then another. Then another. Dozens of them. Some were blurry, poorly lit, clearly recorded in secret. Others were crisp, professional, the kind of thing that might have come from an internal corporate document.

Then the documents. Spreadsheets. Quotas. Token exchanges. Employee records. Names and ID numbers and productivity metrics and dates of "reassignment."

Yan's face changed as he scrolled through them. The skepticism didn't disappear—it was too deeply ingrained for that—but something shifted. A crack in the mask.

"These could be fake," he said. "The videos. The documents. All of it could be fabricated."

"Could be," Nika said.

"But?"

"But you don't think they are."

Yan didn't answer. He kept scrolling. Reading. Cross-referencing with files he had downloaded over the years. Some of it matched. Some of it didn't. Enough of it matched to make him uncomfortable.

"She's still crazy," he said finally. "Even if the videos are real. Even if the documents are real. She's been through something terrible. That doesn't make her a reliable narrator. That doesn't make her a historian."

"She never said she was a historian."

"Then what is she?"

Nika thought about it. About the old woman in the worn chair. About the hollow cheeks and the gray hair and the eyes that had looked at her like she was being measured.

"A witness," Nika said. "Someone who saw something. Someone who survived something. Someone who wants to tell people about it."

Yan shook his head. "Witnesses lie. Witnesses misremember. Witnesses see what they want to see."

"Maybe. But they also see things that actually happened."

Yan was quiet for a long time. The apartment hummed. Somewhere in the building, a door opened and closed. Somewhere, a child was crying.

"I'm not going to believe her," he said. "Not yet. Maybe not ever. But I'll keep listening. For now."

Nika nodded. "That's all she asked for."

They went back the next day. And the day after that. And the day after that.

Every morning, before their shifts, they walked to 14A. They stood in the doorway—they never sat, not for the first few weeks—and they listened to Mira talk.

She talked about the 2020s. The rise of the subscription economy. The way that ownership had been slowly replaced by access.

"You think renting your air is normal," she said. "It's not. It was invented in 2031 by a corporation called AeroLife."

Yan rolled his eyes. "That's not history. That's trivia."

"It's context."

"It's speculation. You don't know any of this for sure. You weren't there."

"Neither were you. But I've read about it. I've studied it. I've talked to people who were there."

"What people? Everyone who was there is dead or senile."

Mira didn't get angry. She just nodded, as if she had expected this, as if she had been through it before.

"Maybe. But the records still exist. The documents. The spreadsheets. The emails. The corporation can't erase everything. They've tried. They've failed."

"They've done a pretty good job so far."

"Good enough to make you doubt. Not good enough to make you forget."

Yan didn't have an answer for that.

Nika listened differently.

She didn't argue. She didn't challenge. She just stood in the doorway, her hand on the frame, and let the words wash over her. She didn't believe them—not really.

They sounded like something from a book, something from one of the old videos her grandmother used to watch, something from a world that had never existed.

But she remembered them.

She remembered the name AeroLife. The year 2031. The way that opening windows had become illegal in certain cities because of "air quality."

She remembered the Great Data Consolidation of 2073. The purging of records. The rewriting of history.

She remembered the lottery. The real lottery. Not the one on her phone.

She didn't believe any of it. Not yet. But she remembered.

And that, Mira told her one morning, was enough.

"Belief comes later," Mira said. "Or it doesn't. That's not why I'm here. I'm here to make sure you know. What you do with that knowledge—that's up to you."

Nika looked at her. At the hollow cheeks. At the gray hair. At the eyes that had seen things Nika couldn't imagine.

"You really believe all this," Nika said. "Don't you?"

Mira smiled. The tired smile. The sad smile. The smile of someone who had been told she was crazy so many times that she had stopped caring.

"I believe what I saw," she said. "I believe what I lived. The rest—the history, the dates, the names—I've done my best to verify it. But I'm not a historian. I'm just a worker. A tired, broken worker who ran away from a planet that wanted her dead."

She paused.

"I could be wrong about some of it. Maybe most of it. But I'm not wrong about the important things. The things that matter. The things that keep me awake at night."

"Like what?"

Mira looked out the small kitchen window. At the air shaft. At the gray walls. At the distant sliver of sky that was almost blue.

"Like the fact that I touched someone's hand and they killed him for it," she said. "Like the fact that Elias posted the truth and they killed him for it. Like the fact

that every day, somewhere in the world, someone is being killed for the crime of wanting more than what they've been given."

She turned back to face Nika.

"That's not fiction. That's not speculation. That's the world we live in. And pretending it's not true—pretending it's just a story—that's how they win."

Nika didn't say anything. She stood in the doorway, her hand on the frame, and she thought about the wet sound she had heard ten years ago. The sound she would spend the rest of her life trying to forget.

She still didn't believe Mira. Not really.

But she kept coming back.

Three months passed.

Every morning, before their shifts, Nika and Yan walked to 14A. They stood in the doorway. They listened. They argued. They left.

Mira didn't seem to mind that they didn't believe her. She didn't seem to mind that they never sat down, that

they always kept one foot in the hallway, that they were always ready to run.

She just kept talking.

She talked about the automation of labor in the 2040s. The displacement of millions of workers. The rise of the "gig economy."

She talked about the Mars Colonial Corporation's acquisition of the lottery system in the 2060s. The way that the promise of a better life had been used to lure workers to their deaths.

She talked about the crackdown on dissent in the 2080s. The forum posts that were deleted within minutes. The neighbors who were killed by drones and replaced by new tenants who didn't ask questions.

"You saw it happen," she said to Nika one morning. "Elias. Your neighbor. He posted the truth, and they killed him for it. That's not paranoia. That's policy."

Nika remembered the sound. The flash of light through the wall. The silence that followed.

"I remember," she said.

"Then you know I'm not lying."

"I know you're not lying about that. I saw it. I heard it. I lived it."

"But the rest of it—the history, the dates, the names—you think I'm making that up."

Nika didn't answer. Because she didn't know what she thought. The history sounded plausible. It fit with the shape of the world she had grown up in. But plausible wasn't the same as true. And true wasn't the same as actionable.

"I think you believe what you're saying," Nika said finally. "I don't know if that means it's true."

Mira nodded. "That's fair."

She didn't push. She didn't get angry. She just kept talking.

Yan was harder on her.

He challenged everything. Every date, every name, every claim. He pulled out his phone—the tracked one, the monitored one—and fact-checked her in real time. Most of what she said couldn't be verified. The records had been purged. The sources had been deleted. The

truth had been erased so thoroughly that there was no way to confirm it.

"That's the point," Mira said. "They erased it. They wanted it to be unverifiable. They wanted people like you to say 'I can't confirm it, so it must not be true.'"

"Or maybe it's not true," Yan said. "Maybe you're connecting dots that don't actually connect. Maybe you're seeing patterns that aren't there."

"Maybe." Mira shrugged. "Or maybe I'm right. You don't know. You can't know. That's the prison they've built for you. Not walls. Not bars. Doubt. Uncertainty. The inability to know anything for sure."

Yan's jaw tightened. He didn't like that answer. But he didn't have a better one.

The algorithm noticed on the ninety-third day.

Not because Nika or Yan had done anything wrong. They had been careful. They had used the stairwell. They had disabled the cameras. They had stood in the doorway of 14A with one foot in the hallway, always ready to run.

But the algorithm was patient. The algorithm was thorough. The algorithm had been watching them for years—for decades—and it had learned their patterns, their habits, their rhythms.

And for the past three months, they had been deviating.

Every morning, before their shifts, they had walked to 14A. The apartment that was supposed to be empty. The apartment that had been marked as "uninhabitable" for ten years.

The algorithm didn't know about Mira. Not yet. But it knew about the deviation. And it was watching.

Yan noticed the surveillance increase first. The drones that flew past his window more frequently. The ads that appeared on his phone, tailored to conversations he had only had in 14A.

"We need to stop," he said to Nika one night, in the stairwell. "The algorithm knows something's wrong. We've been flagged."

"For what?"

"I don't know. But it's not good. If we keep going to 14A, if we keep listening to Mira, we're going to get caught."

Nika looked at him. His face was pale in the dim light. His hands were shaking.

"Yan."

"Don't tell me she's right. Don't tell me we're doing the right thing. I don't care if she's right. I care about staying alive."

"She's not asking us to do anything. She's just talking."

"Talking is doing. Listening is doing. The algorithm doesn't distinguish." Yan ran his fingers through his hair. "We need to stop. At least for a while. Until things calm down."

Nika thought about it. About the old woman in the worn chair. About the hollow cheeks and the gray hair. About the way she kept talking even when no one believed her.

"Okay," Nika said. "We'll stop. For now."

They didn't go to 14A the next morning.

Or the morning after that.

Nika lay in bed and listened to the ventilator hum. Scout shifted at her feet, sighed, pressed his warm body against her legs. The air pushed into her lungs, neutral with hints of citrus.

She thought about Mira. About the stories. About the history that might be true or might be fiction or might be somewhere in between.

She didn't know what to believe. She didn't know if it mattered.

But she remembered.

She remembered the name AeroLife. The year 2031. The way that opening windows had become illegal.

She remembered the Great Data Consolidation of 2073. The purging of records. The rewriting of history.

She remembered the lottery. The real lottery. The one that wasn't random.

She didn't believe any of it. Not yet.

But she remembered.

And that, Mira had said, was enough.

On the fourth morning, Nika woke up and walked to 14A.

She didn't tell Yan. She went alone. The door was still open—just a crack, the same crack, as if it had never been closed.

Mira was sitting in the worn chair. She didn't turn around.

"I thought you weren't coming back," Mira said.

"I wasn't sure I was."

"But you're here."

"I'm here." Nika stood in the doorway. Her hand was on the frame. One foot in the hallway. Ready to run. "I don't believe you. I don't know if I ever will. But I keep thinking about what you said. About remembering. About knowing."

Mira turned. Her gray eyes were steady.

"And?"

"And I remember. That's all. I don't know what it means. I don't know what to do with it. But I remember."

Mira smiled. The tired smile. The sad smile. The smile of someone who had been waiting a very long time for something that might never come.

"That's enough," she said. "For now. That's enough."

Nika didn't sit down. She didn't step all the way inside. She stood in the doorway, her hand on the frame, one foot in the hallway.

But she didn't leave.

And Mira kept talking.

Chapter Thirteen: The Deprecation

Year: 2094. Location: Greater Boston Habitation Zone, Apartments 14A, 14B, and 14C.

The cleaning drones did not come.

Yan realized it first. He was standing at the window of his apartment—his rented window, his metered view—watching the sky over the habitation zone. The drones were out there. They were always out there. But none of them were heading toward the building. None of them were heading toward 14A.

"The apartment," he said. "Elias's apartment. The cleaning drones won't go there."

Nika looked up from Mira's notebook. "What?"

"It's not corporation property. Elias owned it. Outright. No subscription. No lease. The building's systems don't recognize it as part of their jurisdiction. The drones are programmed to clean corporation-owned spaces. They don't have clearance for 14A."

Nika thought about Elias's body. The bones in the chair. The way he had been sitting there for ten years, undisturbed, until Mira found him.

"The body," she said. "Elias's body. It was still there. After ten years. The drones never came? But I swear I saw them that day."

"Because they couldn't. The apartment isn't in their system. It doesn't exist to them." Yan turned from the window. His face was pale, but his eyes were sharp—calculating. "That's why Mira chose it. That's why she was safe here for as long as she was."

"She wasn't safe. They killed her."

"They killed her because she left. Because she went out into the hallway. Because she talked to us. Because she deviated." Yan shook his head. "The apartment itself—the physical space—the drones can't enter. The AI can't monitor. But Mira wasn't a prisoner. She had to eat. She had to move. She had to find people to tell."

He paused.

"And we led them to her."

Nika felt the words like a physical blow. "We didn't—"

"We visited her every day for three months. We walked to her door. We stood in her hallway. We talked to her where the cameras could see us—not inside the apartment, but outside it. The hallway is corporation property. The cameras watch the hallway."

"You said the cameras on this floor were broken."

"The cameras on our floor. The ones near our apartments. But the stairwell? The main corridor? The elevator bank? Those cameras work. And we walked past them every morning. Every single morning. To the same door. The door that was supposed to be empty."

Nika sat down. The floor was cold. It was always cold.

"We marked her," she said.

"We marked her. The algorithm saw the pattern. It didn't know what was happening in 14A—it can't see inside—but it knew that something was happening. And it waited. Watched. Learned. And then, when it had enough evidence, when it was sure, it sent the drone."

Yan sat down across from her. The notebooks were spread between them—Elias's diary, Mira's diaries, the drive, the photographs, the wooden box with the wedding ring and the watch and the child's drawing.

"The apartment is still safe," he said. "Physically. The drones won't enter. The AI can't see inside. But we're not safe. We've been seen. We've been tracked. The algorithm knows we were visiting 14A. It knows we were talking to someone. And now that someone is dead."

"So we're next."

"Not yet. They don't have enough on us. Visiting an empty apartment isn't a crime. Talking to no one isn't a crime. They need evidence. They need proof that we

were helping her. That we knew who she was. That we have her things."

He looked at the notebooks. At the drive.

"Which we do."

Nika pulled her knees to her chest. Scout limped over from the bed—his old joints stiff, his movements slow—and rested his head on her lap. She scratched behind his ears. The same spot. The same motion. The same love she had felt when she was fourteen and the world was still something she thought she could understand.

"What do we do?" she asked.

Yan was quiet for a long time. He looked at his walls—the thermal paper, the fading code, the relics of a person he used to be. A person who had believed that code could be free. A person who had stayed up until three in the morning downloading open-source repositories. A person who had argued about AGPLv3 like it was a religious text.

That person was fifteen. That person had time. That person had energy. That person had not yet learned

that the machine was bigger than him, that the algorithm was patient, that the corporation would always win.

"I used to prepare," he said finally. His voice was quiet. "When I was younger. Twelve. Thirteen. Fourteen. Up to seventeen. I spent every free moment downloading things. Archiving things. Building tools. Mapping blind spots. I thought if I prepared enough—if I had enough evidence, enough escape routes, enough backdoors—I could fight back."

He paused.

"Then I turned eighteen. I had to work. Twelve-hour shifts. Then fourteen. Then sixteen. The job was supposed to be temporary—just until I saved enough, just until I found something better. But there was nothing better. There was never anything better. The job became my life. The quota became my god. The subscription became my everything."

Nika watched him. His hands were in his lap, palms up, empty.

"When did you stop?" she asked.

"I didn't stop. I just... ran out of time. There were no more free moments. No more late nights. No more energy. I came home from work, ate a nutrient block, collapsed into bed. The next day, I did it again. Repeat. Repeat. Repeat."

He looked at his desk. At the hollowed-out book. At the drives hidden inside.

"But I never threw anything out. The drives are still there. The maps are still there. The backdoors are still there. I didn't have time to use them. I didn't have time to finish what I started. But I couldn't bring myself to delete it. To throw it away. It was the only proof that I had ever been anything other than a worker."

Nika understood. She thought about the poster she had tried to stick on her wall when she was fourteen. The fine. The month without entertainment. The lesson she had learned: *do not stick things to walls*.

But Yan had stuck things to his walls anyway. Code on thermal paper. Fading now, illegible in places, but still there. Still proof.

"You never stopped believing," she said.

"I never stopped wanting to believe. There's a difference." He stood up. Walked to his desk. Picked up the hollowed-out book—*The Cathedral and the Bazaar*, the one his grandmother had given him before she died, before the subscriptions took everything. He opened it. Inside, hidden beneath the false pages, were drives. Five of them. Small, black, unremarkable. The kind of thing that could hold the entire history of a world that didn't want to be remembered.

"I haven't looked at these in years," he said. "I didn't have time. I didn't have energy. I told myself I was keeping them just in case. But I never really believed there would be a just in case."

He held up one of the drives.

"There's a tunnel. Under the building. Old infrastructure, from before the habitation zones. I found it when I was sixteen. Spent months mapping it. Never told anyone. Never went back after I started working. I didn't have the time. I didn't have the energy."

"But you remembered."

"I remembered. The tunnel is still there. The maps are on this drive. The backdoors are still open—probably. If the corporation hasn't found them. If the algorithm hasn't patched them."

He looked at her.

"It's not much. It's years out of date. The tunnel could be collapsed. The backdoors could be sealed. The maps could be wrong. But it's something. It's the only something we have."

They didn't run that night.

They couldn't. The tunnel might be collapsed. The backdoors might be sealed. The maps might be wrong. Yan needed to study his own files—files he hadn't looked at in nearly a decade—to figure out if any of his old preparations were still viable.

So they stayed.

They stayed in Yan's apartment, with the sensors disabled, the door locked, the windows covered. They took shifts sleeping. Nika slept while Yan read. Yan

slept while Nika read. Scout slept through all of it, his old body curled on the bed, his breath slow and steady.

Yan plugged the old drives into his tablet. The files were still there. Thousands of them. Maps. Diagrams. Surveillance footage. Corporate documents he had stolen when he was fifteen, before the security protocols got smarter. Backdoor access codes he had discovered when he was sixteen, before the algorithm learned to patch them.

He had been thorough. Fifteen-year-old Yan had been obsessive, meticulous, relentless. He had spent every free moment building an escape route that he never thought he would use.

Twenty-five-year-old Yan was grateful and terrified in equal measure.

"The tunnel is still accessible," he said on the second night. His voice was hoarse. He hadn't slept in nearly forty hours. "I cross-referenced the building's maintenance records. There haven't been any repairs to the foundation since I left. No one's been down there. The door is still there."

"You're sure?"

"No. But the evidence suggests." He rubbed his eyes.

"The backdoors are another story. Most of them are closed. The algorithm patched them years ago. But there are a few—the oldest ones, the ones I never used—that might still work. The corporation doesn't know about them because no one's ever tried to use them."

"How do you know?"

"Because if they knew, they would have patched them. That's how the algorithm works. It reacts to threats. If no one's threatened a particular vulnerability, it doesn't bother to fix it. It's not proactive. It's reactive. Efficient, but not creative."

Nika looked at the maps spread across the floor. The tunnels, the stations, the old subway lines that had been decommissioned in the 2040s. A whole world beneath the habitation zone, forgotten and abandoned.

"How far do they go?" she asked.

Yan traced a line with his finger. "The old city. The parts that were never rebuilt. The parts the corporation abandoned because they weren't profitable." He paused. "And beyond that, the coast. Old ports. Shipping containers. Places where the algorithm

doesn't bother looking because there's nothing left to take."

"The coast is hundreds of kilometers away."

"We don't have to go all at once. We just have to get out of the city. Out of the habitation zone. Somewhere the algorithm doesn't have eyes."

Nika nodded. She looked at Scout. The old dog was watching her, his tail wagging slowly, his eyes clouded with age.

"When do we go?" she asked.

"Tomorrow night. We need to study everything first. We need to know what we're carrying. We need to understand what Mira was trying to teach us."

"And then?"

"And then we run."

They read for two more days.

Elias's diary. Mira's diaries. The videos on the drive. The documents Yan had saved when he was fifteen.

They learned about the subscription economy, invented in 2031 by a corporation called AeroLife. They learned about the automation of labor in the 2040s, the displacement of millions, the rise of the gig economy that was just slavery with extra steps. They learned about the Great Data Consolidation of 2073, the purging of records, the rewriting of history. They learned about the Mars lottery, which was not random, which had never been random, which was designed to lure workers to a planet where they would be worked to death and replaced before their bodies had time to cool.

They learned about the airlocks. The reassignments. The bodies that were recycled into nutrients for the plants that fed the workers who would one day be recycled themselves.

They learned about Elias, who had waited thirty-four years for a daughter who would never come home.

They learned about Kael, who had touched someone's hand for less than a second and been killed for it.

They learned about Mira, who had hidden in a waste rocket, who had walked across a continent, who had

found a dead man's apartment and a dead man's key
and a dead man's hope.

They learned about themselves—Nika and Yan, two
workers in a rented building in a rented city in a
rented world, who had stood in a doorway for three
months and called a woman crazy because the
alternative was believing her.

They knew now.

Mira wasn't crazy.

Mira was right.

And now Mira was dead.

On the third night, they packed.

Not much. They couldn't carry much. The tunnel was
narrow in places, the passages tight. They needed to
move fast, move quiet, move light.

Nika took the notebooks—Elias's diary, Mira's two
diaries. She wrapped them in a plastic bag, the kind
the food dispenser used for deliveries, and tucked
them into her backpack. The photographs went in

next, wrapped in an old shirt. The wooden box with the wedding ring and the watch and the child's drawing—she held it for a moment, feeling the weight of it, the weight of a dead woman's life, and then she put it in the bag.

Yan took the drives. All of them. His own collection—years of downloaded files, archived videos, stolen documents—and Mira's drive, the one she had brought from Mars. He put them in a waterproof case he had built himself years ago, when he was seventeen and still believed he might need it. He sealed it shut. Tucked it into his jacket.

Scout would have to walk. He was old, his joints stiff, but he could still walk. He had to.

They left everything else behind. The rented furniture. The rented clothes. The rented life that had never really been theirs.

At 3:47 AM, when the building was quiet and the hallway cameras were cycling through their blind spots, they opened the door to Yan's apartment.

The hallway was empty. The air smelled of citrus. The ventilator hummed.

They walked to the stairwell—the broken one, the one the cameras didn't watch—and they did not look back.

The tunnel entrance was in the basement.

Yan had found it when he was sixteen. A door behind a panel of concrete, hidden from the building's maintenance AI. He had explored the first few hundred meters, had mapped what he could, had retreated when the air grew thin and his flashlight began to flicker.

He had not told anyone. He had not gone back. He had saved the knowledge, the way you save a key, waiting for the lock to appear.

Then he had turned eighteen. He had started working. He had run out of time. The key had stayed in his pocket, unused, forgotten.

But he had never thrown it away.

Yan pulled the metal door open. It groaned—a sound like an animal waking from a long sleep—and then it swung wide, revealing a dark passage beyond. The air

that came out was cold and still and smelled of dust and rust and time.

Scout sniffed the entrance. His tail wagged once, twice, then stopped.

"I'll go first," Yan said. "Stay close. Watch your feet. The floor is uneven."

Nika nodded. She couldn't speak. Her throat was tight, her chest heavy, her hands shaking.

She thought about Mira. About the worn chair and the small kitchen window and the way she had kept talking even when no one believed her.

I'm not trying to change the world. I'm trying to make sure that someone remembers.

Nika would remember. She would carry Mira's words in her backpack, in her heart, in the bones of her memory. She would not let the corporation erase her.

She stepped into the tunnel.

The darkness closed around her.

Behind her, the door groaned shut.

Above her, in the building she had called home for seventeen years, the algorithm continued its endless watching. It did not know she was gone. Not yet. It would learn. It always learned.

But not tonight.

Tonight, she was free.

They walked for hours.

The tunnel was dark—darker than anything Nika had ever experienced. The darkness of the habitation zones was never complete; there was always a screen, a light, a glow from somewhere. But this darkness was absolute. The kind of darkness that pressed against your eyes, that made you doubt whether your eyes were open or closed.

Yan had a flashlight. A small one, battery-powered, the kind that didn't connect to the network. The beam cut a narrow path through the dark, illuminating the rusted rails, the crumbling walls, the dripping ceiling.

The tunnel was old. Pre-2030s old. Built before the subscription economy, before the habitation zones,

before the world had been optimized beyond recognition. Nika could feel the age of it in the walls, in the air, in the way the darkness seemed to remember things that had been forgotten.

She thought about Yan at fifteen. Staying up until three in the morning, downloading open-source repositories, arguing about AGPLv3 like it was a religious text. Believing that information wanted to be free.

She thought about Yan at eighteen. Starting his first shift. Coming home exhausted. Looking at the drives on his desk and not having the energy to pick them up. Putting them away instead. Telling himself he would get back to them eventually.

She thought about Yan at twenty-five. Pulling the drives out of the hollowed-out book. Dusting them off. Plugging them into his tablet for the first time in nearly a decade.

"You never threw them away," she said.

Yan didn't turn around. His voice echoed off the tunnel walls. "I couldn't. They were the only proof that I had ever been anything other than a worker."

"And now?"

"Now they're the only proof that any of this happened. That Elias existed. That Mira existed. That the truth is real."

They walked in silence. Scout's claws clicked on the rusted rails. The water dripped. The darkness pressed in.

The station, when they reached it, was a cathedral of decay.

High ceilings, crumbling tiles, pillars that had once held up the weight of a city. Benches where people had once sat, waiting for trains that would never come. A clock on the wall, frozen at 11:47, its hands still as death.

Yan swept the flashlight across the space. Dust motes danced in the beam. Somewhere in the darkness, water dripped.

"This is where we rest," he said. "We can stay here for a few hours. Then we keep moving."

Nika lowered her backpack to the ground. Scout lay down beside her, his head on his paws, his eyes closing.

She sat on one of the old benches. The wood was cold, cracked, but it held her weight. She looked up at the ceiling, at the darkness above, at the place where the sky used to be.

She thought about Mira. About the last entry in her diary—the one she had written the night before she died.

I don't know if anyone will read this. I don't know if anyone will care. But I'm writing it anyway.

The truth is not a weapon. The truth is not a shield. The truth is just... true. It exists whether you believe it or not. It matters whether you act on it or not.

I have acted. I have told the truth. I have given everything I have.

Now it's your turn.

Nika closed her eyes.

She didn't sleep. But she rested.

And in the darkness of the old station, surrounded by the ghosts of a world that no longer existed, she made a decision.

She would not just remember.

She would act.

The tunnel waited. The algorithm watched. The corporation continued its endless optimization.

But Nika—Nika was no longer a part of their calculation.

She was something else now.

Something they could not predict.

Something they could not control.

Something they could not deprecate.

Not yet.

She opened her eyes.

"Yan."

"Yeah?"

"Tomorrow, we keep moving."

"Yeah."

"And the day after that."

"Yeah."

"And the day after that."

Yan looked at her. In the dim light of the flashlight, his face was pale, exhausted, but his eyes were steady.

"We keep moving until we can't move anymore," he said. "And then we find a way to keep moving anyway."

Nika nodded.

Scout sighed in his sleep. The water dripped. The darkness pressed against the edges of the light.

Somewhere above them, the algorithm was learning. It was noting their absence. It was recalculating, re-predicting, re-optimizing.

It would find them. Eventually.

But not yet.

Not tonight.

Tonight, they were free.

Chapter Fourteen: The Message

Year: 2094. Location: The Tunnels, The Coast, The Habitation Zones.

They emerged from the tunnel on the fifth day.

The coast was not what Nika had imagined. The old videos—the ones from the culinary history module, the ones that showed blue water and white sand and palm trees swaying in a breeze that didn't cost anything—those were fiction. The real coast was gray. Gray water, gray sky, gray sand that had been churned by decades of industrial runoff. The remains of old shipping

containers rusted on the shore like the bones of dead animals.

But the algorithm wasn't here. No cameras. No drones. No ads playing on every surface. Just the wind and the waves and the distant cry of gulls that had somehow survived the collapse of everything else.

They found an abandoned warehouse. The roof had partially collapsed, but one room was still dry, still relatively warm, still hidden from the air. They made it their base.

And then they began.

Yan started with the forums.

The same local boards he had used when he was fifteen. The ones the algorithm had mostly abandoned—too small, too niche, too insignificant to monitor closely. He posted excerpts from Mira's diary. Clips from the videos. Screenshots of corporate documents showing the quota system, the token exchange rates, the names of workers who had been "reassigned."

He waited.

The first post stayed up for eleven hours. Longer than tenant_4c's. Longer than he expected. It got forty-seven views. Twelve responses.

Fake.

Nice try, corp.

Who has time for this?

OP needs help.

I stopped reading after the first paragraph.

Another conspiracy nut.

Go back to work.

Yan read each response. His hands were shaking.

"No one believes it," he said.

Nika read over his shoulder. "Would you? Before Mira? Before the flash?"

He wanted to say yes. He wanted to believe that he would have been different, that he would have seen the truth, that he would have listened. But he remembered standing in Mira's doorway. Three months of calling her crazy in his head. Three months of keeping one foot in the hallway.

"No," he said. "I wouldn't have."

"Then why do you expect them to?"

They tried different forums. Different approaches.

Yan posted under different usernames. He varied the tone—clinical, angry, desperate, hopeful. He posted videos. He posted screenshots. He posted links to documents he had verified a dozen times.

The responses were always the same.

Fake.

You expect us to believe this?

Where's the proof?

Anyone can fake a video.

Nice try, MCC.

I reported this post.

Get a job.

Touch grass. Oh wait.

Blocked.

No one believed. Not one person.

Nika tried talking to people she knew.

Not well—she had never been good at making friends, had never had the time or the energy or the emotional bandwidth. But there were faces she recognized from the building. Neighbors. Workers from her shift. People she had nodded to in the hallway for years.

She waited for them outside the dispenser. Outside the elevator. In the stairwell—not the broken one, the regular one, the one with cameras.

She told them about Mira. About the apartment. About the diaries. About Mars.

They looked at her like she was insane.

"Nika," one of them said—a woman named Delia who worked in the same hydroponics sector. "You've been gone for weeks. Your apartment is empty. People are worried about you."

"I'm fine. I've been—"

"You've been hiding in an abandoned warehouse with that boy from 14B? The one who's always on his phone? The one who never talks to anyone?"

"Nika." Delia put a hand on her arm. "I think you need help. Professional help. There are wellness programs. The corporation offers—"

"The corporation offers subscriptions. That's all they offer."

Delia withdrew her hand. Her expression shifted from concern to something harder. Something colder.

"I'm going to report this conversation," she said. "Not because I want to. Because I have to. You're saying things that could get us all in trouble."

"Delia—"

"I have a daughter. She's eight years old. She needs me to keep my job. She needs me to pay for our air. I can't afford to listen to this."

She walked away. Nika watched her go.

She didn't try again.

Yan left printouts in stairwells.

Old-fashioned paper. The kind that couldn't be deleted. The kind that someone might pick up and read and keep.

*THE TRUTH ABOUT MARSTHE LOTTERY IS A
TRAPYOUR NEIGHBORS ARE BEING MURDERED*

Most of the printouts were thrown away within hours. The ones that weren't thrown away were reported to the building's AI. The AI flagged them as "unauthorized materials" and scheduled them for removal.

One printout stayed up for three days. Taped to the wall of the third-floor stairwell, hidden behind a pipe. Yan checked it every morning, slipping back into the building under cover of darkness.

On the fourth morning, it was gone. In its place, someone had written in marker:

Stop. You're going to get us all killed.

Yan stared at the words. His hands were shaking. He didn't leave any more printouts.

They tried the coast. The small settlements that had sprung up in the abandoned zones—people who had fled the habitation zones, who lived outside the corporation's grid, who survived on scavenged food and stolen water.

Surely, Nika thought, these people would understand. They had already rejected the system. They had already chosen to leave.

She found a woman sitting outside a makeshift shelter, mending a torn shirt with a needle made from a broken piece of plastic.

"Excuse me," Nika said. "I need to tell you something. About Mars. About the lottery. About what the corporation is doing."

The woman looked up. Her eyes were tired. Her face was weathered.

"I don't care," she said.

"But—"

"I left the habitation zone because I didn't want to think about any of that anymore. I didn't want to see the ads. I didn't want to hear the AI. I didn't want to

know." She went back to her mending. "I don't know you. I don't trust you. And I don't want to hear whatever you're selling."

"I'm not selling anything."

"Everyone's selling something." The woman didn't look up again.

Nika stood there for a long moment. Then she walked away.

They tried a man who was fishing off the end of a broken pier. An old woman who was sorting through a pile of scrap metal. A group of teenagers who were smoking something that smelled like burning plastic.

No one listened. No one believed. No one wanted to know.

"Go away."

"We don't want any trouble."

"I've got enough problems."

"Leave us alone."

"That sounds like corp propaganda."

"Even if it's true, what am I supposed to do about it?"

"I don't care."

"I don't care."

"I don't care."

Yan wanted to scream.

He wanted to grab them by the shoulders and shake them. He wanted to force them to watch the videos, to read the diaries, to see what he had seen. He wanted to make them understand.

But he remembered standing in Mira's doorway. Three months. Three months of listening to her stories. Three months of calling her crazy in his head.

He hadn't believed her either. Not really. Not until the flash. Not until the wet sound. Not until she was dead.

"We can't make them believe," he said to Nika one night, in the abandoned warehouse, as the wind rattled the broken windows. "They have to see it for themselves. They have to witness it. The way we did."

Nika was sitting on the floor, Scout's head in her lap. Her face was pale in the dim light.

"Then they'll never believe," she said. "Because the corporation only kills people in the dark. In the middle of the night. When no one is watching. When no one can hear."

"They heard Elias. You heard him. I heard him."

"We were children. We were awake when we shouldn't have been. We were paying attention when everyone else was asleep." She paused. "That's the only reason we know. Not because we're smarter. Not because we're braver. Because we happened to be awake at 2:47 AM."

Yan was quiet for a long time. The wind howled. Scout shifted in his sleep.

"So what do we do?" he asked. "If no one will listen. If no one will believe. If everyone—absolutely everyone—thinks we're crazy."

Nika looked at the notebooks. At the drives. At the evidence spread across the floor of an abandoned warehouse on a dead coast.

"We keep the truth safe," she said. "We hide it somewhere they'll never find it. Somewhere the algorithm can't reach. And we wait."

"For what?"

"For someone to be ready. For someone to be awake at 2:47 AM. For someone to hear the wet sound and start asking questions."

"And if no one ever does?"

Nika looked at him. Her eyes were tired. Older than twenty-four. Older than she had any right to be.

"Then we die with the truth," she said. "And the corporation wins."

They didn't stop trying.

Not completely. Yan still posted on forums, though the responses never changed. Nika still talked to people, though they always walked away. They left printouts in hidden places, though the printouts were always found and destroyed.

But they stopped hoping.

That was the difference. In the beginning, they had believed—naively, stupidly—that the truth would be enough. That people would see the evidence and recognize it. That the world would wake up.

It didn't. It wouldn't. It never would.

The corporation had spent decades building a world where truth and lies were indistinguishable. Where every fact had a counter-fact. Where every witness was dismissed as crazy. Where the only thing anyone could trust was their own experience—and the corporation made sure that no one experienced anything.

No one saw the flash. No one heard the wet sound. No one smelled the ozone and copper in the hallway.

Except Nika. Except Yan.

And no one believed them.

"We're Mira now," Nika said one night.

Yan looked at her. "What?"

"We're the crazy ones. The ones with the stories that no one believes. The ones who stand in doorways and talk to people who won't listen." She smiled. It was a sad smile. The same sad smile Mira had worn. "We're her now."

Yan thought about Mira. About the worn chair. About the small kitchen window. About the way she had kept talking even when no one believed her.

"She knew," he said. "She knew no one would believe her. Not really. Not until it was too late."

"Then why did she keep trying?"

Yan thought about it. About the drives. About the notebooks. About the evidence spread across the floor.

"Because trying was all she had," he said. "Because giving up would have been the same as dying. Because as long as she was still talking, still writing, still trying—she was still fighting."

Nika nodded. She picked up Mira's diary. Opened it to a random page.

Day 112. I don't have much time left. I can feel them watching.

But I keep writing. Because if I don't write, no one will remember.

And remembering is the most dangerous thing of all.

Nika closed the diary. She looked at Yan. At Scout. At the darkness outside the broken windows.

"Tomorrow," she said. "We keep trying."

"Tomorrow," Yan agreed.

They both knew it wouldn't matter. No one would listen. No one would believe. No one would ever know.

But they kept trying anyway.

Because trying was all they had.

Chapter Fifteen: The Fugitives

Year: 2094. Location: The Coast, The Habitation Zones, Everywhere.

It started on a Tuesday.

Nika was foraging for food—old ration packs, expired nutrient blocks, anything that hadn't been completely destroyed by salt and time—when Yan's voice crackled through the old radio they had scavenged from the warehouse.

"Nika. Come back. Now."

His voice was wrong. Flat. Empty. The voice of someone who had seen something and couldn't unsee it.

She ran.

The tablet was on. Not their tablet—the one they had brought from the building, the one that wasn't connected to the network. A different tablet. One Yan had found in the warehouse, dead and forgotten, its battery long since drained. He had charged it somehow—she didn't ask how—and now it was on, and the screen was showing something that made her blood turn to ice.

Her face. His face. Their names.

WANTED FOR TREASON. NIKA, 14C, YAN, 14B

**CRIMINAL CONSPIRACY, UNAUTHORIZED
POSSESSION OF CLASSIFIED MATERIALS,
INCITEMENT OF CIVIL UNREST**

REWARD: 10,000 TOKENS EACH

The faces on the screen were not flattering. They were the faces from their ID photos—the ones the building's AI had taken when they signed their leases. Nika at seventeen, her hair shorter, her face softer. Yan at eighteen, his eyes already tired, his mouth already set in a line that said *I've seen too much*.

Below the photos, a message in bold red letters:

IF YOU SEE THESE INDIVIDUALS, DO NOT APPROACH. CONTACT YOUR BUILDING'S AI IMMEDIATELY. HARBORING FUGITIVES IS PUNISHABLE BY REASSIGNMENT.

Nika stared at the screen. The warehouse was cold. The wind was howling. Scout was pressed against her leg, trembling.

"They know," she said.

"They've always known. Now everyone else does too."

They left the warehouse that night.

Not because it wasn't safe—it was still off the grid, still hidden from the algorithm's cameras. But because the people in the coast settlements had tablets too. The people in the coast settlements had seen their faces. The people in the coast settlements knew the reward was 10,000 tokens—enough to buy oxygen for a year, enough to eat fresh food for the first time in their lives, enough to escape.

Nika had thought the coast was different. She had thought the people who had left the habitation zones, who had chosen to live outside the corporation's grid, would be allies. Would be sympathetic. Would understand.

She was wrong.

The coast was just another cage. The bars were different—no cameras, no drones, no AI—but the people inside were the same. Hungry. Desperate. Afraid.

And 10,000 tokens was 10,000 tokens.

They found a new hiding place. An old storm drain, half-collapsed, buried under a pile of rusted shipping containers. The entrance was narrow—too narrow for most adults, but Nika and Yan were thin. Mars-thin. Work-thin. They could fit.

Scout had to be lifted. His old joints protested, but he didn't whine. He never whined.

The storm drain was dark. Colder than the warehouse. Damp. The walls were covered in something that might have been mold or might have been something worse. The air smelled of salt and rot and time.

They sat in the dark. They listened to the waves. They waited.

The broadcast played everywhere.

Nika heard it through a crack in the storm drain's ceiling—a fragment of sound from a drone flying overhead, its speakers blaring the message to the empty coast.

WANTED FOR TREASON. NIKA. YAN. DO NOT APPROACH. CONTACT YOUR AI IMMEDIATELY.

She heard it again the next day. And the next. The drone flew the same pattern, looped the same message, over and over, as if the corporation wanted to make sure that no one—not a single person—could claim they hadn't heard.

The people in the coast settlements heard it. The people in the habitation zones heard it. The people in the buildings, in the apartments, in the six-by-eight cells where they paid for their air and ate their nutrient blocks and dreamed of winning the lottery—they all heard it.

And they all turned against them.

Yan monitored the forums.

It was a mistake. He knew it was a mistake. But he couldn't stop himself. He needed to know what people were saying. He needed to know if anyone—anyone at all—was defending them.

No one was.

Finally. Those two always gave me a bad feeling.

I knew there was something wrong with the boy from 14B. Always on his phone. Always skulking around.

The girl too. Never said hello. Never smiled. Probably plotting this for years.

10,000 tokens. That's more than I make in a year.

I hope they catch them soon. I'm tired of the drones waking me up.

Burn them.

Reassign them.

Kill them.

Yan closed the tablet. His hands were shaking.

"They hate us," he said.

Nika didn't look up. She was sitting against the wall of the storm drain, Scout's head in her lap, her fingers moving mechanically through his fur.

"They don't hate us," she said. "They're scared. And scared people need someone to blame."

"We're the only ones they can blame. The corporation made sure of that."

Nika nodded. She had known this would happen. Not the specifics—not the broadcasts, not the wanted posters, not the 10,000 tokens. But she had known that the truth would not save them. That the truth would make them enemies.

She had hoped she was wrong.

She wasn't.

They hid for two weeks.

The storm drain was not comfortable. It was not safe. It was not anything except dark and cold and

damp. But the drones didn't look there. The algorithm didn't know the storm drain existed. No one did.

Except the people who lived on the coast. The people who had seen their faces. The people who knew the reward was 10,000 tokens.

Yan stopped going out for food on the fourth day. Someone had seen him—a woman collecting scrap metal near the old pier. She hadn't said anything. She had just looked at him. And then she had walked away, quickly, her phone already in her hand.

He didn't know if she had reported him. He didn't wait to find out.

After that, they rationed. One nutrient block a day. Half a bottle of water. Scout got the same as them—they couldn't bear to give him less.

They grew thinner. Weaker. The cold seeped into their bones and stayed there.

They talked about love on the twelfth night.

Not because they wanted to. Because there was nothing else to talk about. Because the silence had become unbearable, and the darkness had become suffocating, and the only thing left was each other.

"Do you think we would have been different?" Nika asked. "If we had been born earlier? Before the subscriptions? Before the air cost money?"

Yan thought about it. He thought about Elias. About the world he had been born into. A world where the air was free. A world where you could open a window and just breathe.

"We would have been different," he said. "But we wouldn't have been us."

"What does that mean?"

"It means I don't know who I would have been. I only know who I am. And who I am is someone who spent his childhood downloading code he wasn't supposed to have. Someone who watched

his neighbor get killed for posting the truth.
Someone who hid in a storm drain with a girl and
a dog because the whole world wants him dead."

He paused.

"I don't know if that's love. I don't know what love
is supposed to feel like. I've never seen it. Not
really. My parents worked opposite shifts. They
barely spoke. My grandmother died before I was
old enough to understand what she was trying to
teach me. The only love I've ever known is—"

He stopped.

"Is what?" Nika asked.

"Is this. Sitting in the dark with you. Knowing that
tomorrow might be our last day. And not wanting
to face it alone."

Nika was quiet for a long time. The waves crashed
against the shore. Scout sighed in his sleep.

"I don't know what love is either," she said. "I've never had the time. I've never had the energy. I've been too busy surviving."

"That's what they want. They want us to be too tired to love. Too tired to care. Too tired to fight."

"I'm not too tired to fight."

"I know."

"I'm not too tired to care."

"I know."

Nika reached out in the darkness. Her hand found his. Her fingers were cold—colder than the storm drain, colder than the coast, colder than anything—but she didn't pull away.

"If tomorrow is our last day," she said, "I don't want to have any regrets."

Yan squeezed her hand. "Neither do I."

They didn't know how to kiss.

Neither of them had ever done it before. There had been no time. No privacy. No energy. The corporation had taken everything—their time, their privacy, their energy—and left nothing for things like kissing.

But they tried.

Nika leaned in first. Her lips found his cheek, his jaw, the corner of his mouth. She was clumsy, uncertain, her movements jerky with fear and cold and something else—something that felt like hope and tasted like salt.

Yan turned his head. Their lips met.

It was not like the old videos. There was no music. No soft lighting. No sense of the world falling away. The storm drain was cold and damp and dark. Scout was snoring. Somewhere above them, a drone was flying its endless pattern, searching for them, waiting to kill them.

But for a moment—less than a moment—none of that mattered.

They kissed. And kissed. And kissed.

Not because they were good at it. Not because it was perfect. Because tomorrow was far from guaranteed, and they had wasted too much time already.

The thirteenth day was the last day.

They knew it before it happened. Not because they saw anything—the storm drain was dark, the drones were distant, the world above them was hidden. They knew it the way you know a storm is coming. The way you know the air pressure has changed. The way you know something is wrong before you can name it.

"We should have run farther," Yan said.

"There was nowhere farther to run."

"We should have run faster."

"We were already running as fast as we could."

Nika looked at Scout. The old dog was lying beside her, his head on her leg, his eyes half-closed. He had been a good dog. The best dog. Her mother had skipped her own food upgrades to keep him alive, and now he was old, and tired, and probably cold, and he didn't understand why they were hiding in a dark tunnel when they could be home.

"We should have left him with someone," Nika said.

"Who? There was no one."

"There must have been someone."

"There wasn't. There's never been anyone. Just us."

Nika kissed the top of Scout's head. His fur smelled of salt and damp and old age.

"I'm sorry," she whispered. "I'm sorry I couldn't give you a better life."

Scout's tail wagged once. Twice. Then stilled.

The sound came at noon.

Not a drone. Not this time. Footsteps. Multiple sets. Heavy boots on wet concrete. Voices—low, urgent, nervous.

Yan pressed himself against the wall of the storm drain. Nika did the same. Scout didn't move. He was too old to hide, too tired to care.

"Someone said they were here."

"The old drain. Near the shipping containers."

"You checked?"

"I'm not going in there. You check."

"I'm not going in either. Those two are crazy. They've been killing people. The broadcast said—"

"The broadcast didn't say they were killing people. The broadcast said they had classified materials."

"Same thing. You don't get that kind of reward for nothing."

The voices were closer now. Nika could see them—shadows at the entrance of the storm drain, blocking the light. Three of them. Maybe four. Coast people. People she had tried to talk to. People who had told her to go away.

"Come out," one of them said. "We know you're in there."

Yan didn't move. Neither did Nika.

"We don't want any trouble. We just want the tokens."

Silence.

"You're making this worse for yourselves. If you come out quietly, we'll take you to the AI ourselves. No one has to get hurt."

Still silence.

"Fine." The voice hardened. "We'll wait. You can't stay in there forever. No food. No water. No light. Eventually you'll come out. And when you do—"

"We'll be ready."

The shadows retreated. The light returned. But the footsteps didn't leave. They settled. They waited.

They had been sold out.

Nika knew it the moment she heard the footsteps. Not by the coast people—they were just the ones who had come to collect. Sold out by someone else. Someone who had seen their faces on the broadcast. Someone who had recognized them. Someone who had wanted the 10,000 tokens more than they had wanted to believe the truth.

It could have been anyone. The woman collecting scrap metal. The man fishing off the pier. The old woman sorting through the trash. The teenagers smoking burning plastic.

It didn't matter who. What mattered was that it had happened. That the people who should have risen up—who should have revolted, who should have seen the truth and fought back—had turned them in instead.

"We're going to die here," Yan said.

Nika didn't argue. She couldn't. The walls of the storm drain were closing in. The air was thin. The darkness was absolute.

"I'm sorry," she said.

"For what?"

"For not running faster. For not hiding better. For not—"

"Don't." Yan's hand found hers in the darkness.

"Don't apologize. We did everything we could."

"It wasn't enough."

"It was never going to be enough. Not against them. Not against the algorithm. Not against a world that doesn't want to wake up."

Nika squeezed his hand. She thought about Mira. About the worn chair. About the small kitchen window. About the way she had kept talking even when no one believed her.

Mira had known. She had known that no one would listen. That no one would believe. That the truth would die with her.

But she had kept talking anyway.

"Kiss me again," Nika said.

Yan kissed her. In the dark. In the cold. In the storm drain that was about to become their grave.

They kissed. And kissed. And kissed.

Not because they were good at it. Not because it was perfect. Because it was the only thing left. Because love—whatever it was, whatever it meant, whatever shape it took when you had no reference and no experience and no time—love was the only thing the corporation couldn't take from them.

The drones locked on at 2:47 PM.

Nika heard them first—a high-pitched whine, different from the patrol drones, different from

the cleaning drones. The sound of weapons systems arming. The sound of death, calibrated and optimized and inevitable.

Yan heard them too. He pulled back from the kiss. His forehead rested against hers. His breath was warm on her lips.

"They found us," he said.

"I know."

"I love you."

It was the first time either of them had said it. Not because they hadn't felt it. Because they hadn't known how. Because the word felt too big for their mouths, too heavy for their tongues, too dangerous for a world that punished people who cared.

"I love you too," Nika said.

Scout lifted his head. His tail wagged once. Twice. He didn't whine. He didn't bark. He just looked at

them, his old eyes cloudy, his old heart steady, and he waited.

The whine grew louder. The drones were at the entrance now. Their targeting lasers cut through the darkness, red beams painting the walls of the storm drain, painting Nika's face, painting Yan's face, painting the space between them.

"We should stand up," Yan said.

"Why?"

"I don't want to die lying down."

They stood. They held hands. They faced the entrance.

The drones hovered there, three of them, their cameras glowing red, their weapons charged. Behind them, Nika could see the coast people—the ones who had sold them out—watching from a safe distance. Their faces were hard. Unreadable. They didn't look away. They didn't flinch.

They had chosen their side.

Nika looked at Yan. Yan looked at Nika.

They kissed one last time.

The drones fired.

The drone did not hate you. The age bracket did not judge you.

*The banned book did not threaten you. They simply enforced
the only law that mattered: the future belongs to those who can
afford to leave. And you, reader, did not.*

Acknowledgements:

Thank you to my English teacher, from high school, Ana Črne, who read the early version, when it was still rough and gave me guidance to finish this work. You taught me that the past perfect tense isn't best everywhere, and this book would not exist in this quality without this lesson.

You own nothing. You will be happy about it.

In 2084, air is a subscription. Your walls watch you sleep. And the Mars lottery is the only dream left.

Nika is fourteen. She has never known anything different—until a neighbor is killed for posting the truth online. Until she sees the video of a woman being sucked into an airlock for complaining about a twenty-hour shift. Until she learns that the future belongs to those who can afford to leave.

She cannot afford to leave.

But she can remember. She can hide the diaries. She can run through the darkness beneath the city with a dog, a boy who still believes code can be free, and a drive full of evidence that a corporation wants erased forever.

The Deprecation Protocol is a haunting, urgent novel about love in the time of algorithms, the weight of bearing witness, and what remains of us when everything—even our breath—is rented. For readers of *Station Eleven* and *Klara and the Sun*: a story that asks whether remembering, even when no one believes you, is the most dangerous act of all.